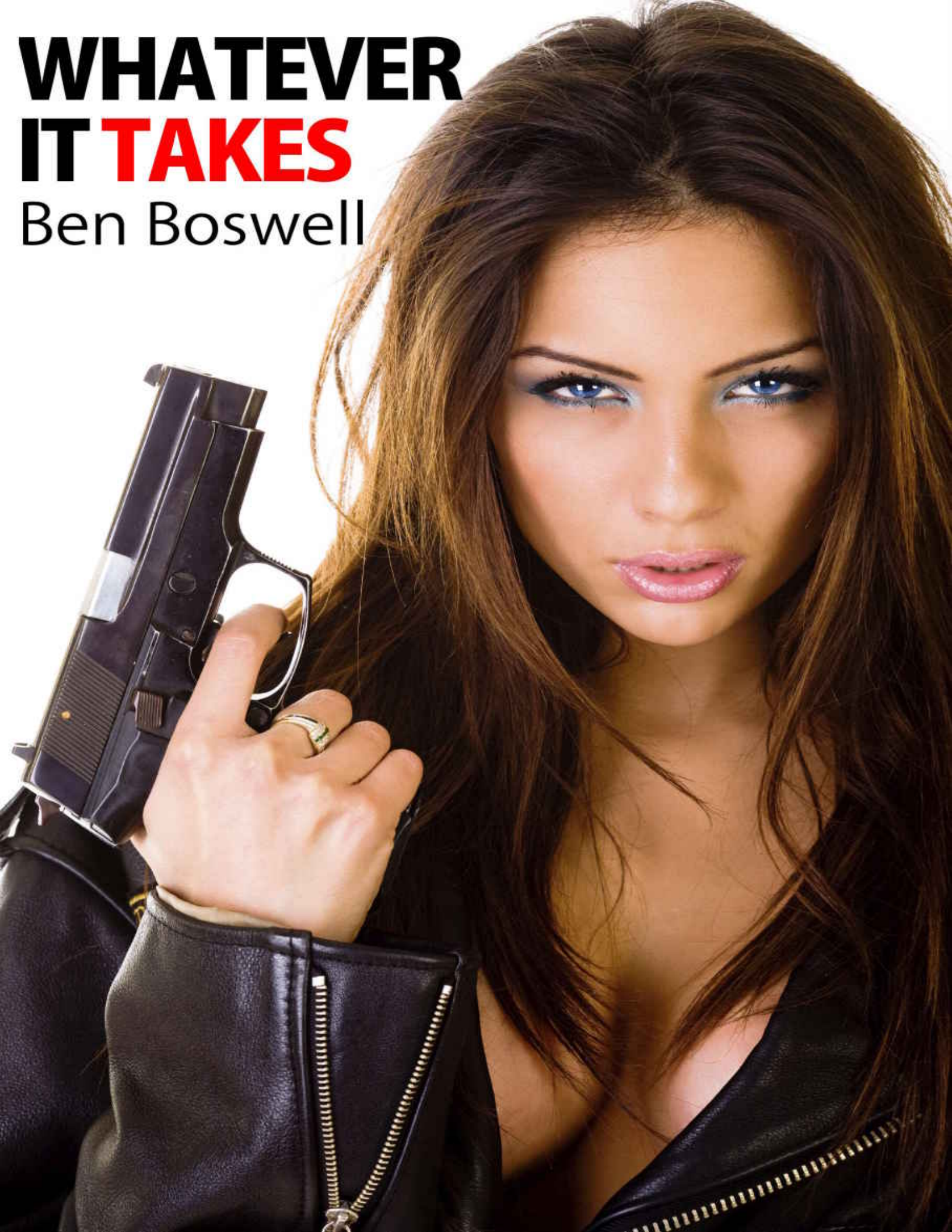


WHATEVER IT TAKES

Ben Boswell



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PREFACE

This book is a departure for me. Basically everything I've published in the past has been lodged very definitely within erotica genre conventions -- slut wives mostly, but occasionally stories focusing on non-consensual sex, erotic encounters, older man/younger women relationships. I've tried to create interesting twists on these themes, given some depth to the characters, but everything I've written before had the sex front and center. Plot served the sole purpose of justifying the banging.

In this book, though, the story stands, I think, I hope, on its own. It is still genre fiction, and it still contains explicit sex, making it erotica. But for the first time I think I've written a story where the sex serves the plot rather than the plot serving the sex.

I realize this is a risk. Erotica readers may find themselves wanting to "fast-forward" to the good parts. Readers of crime/caper fiction may be turned off by the explicit sex.

But here's the thing. This is the kind of story I would like to read. And ultimately, I write what I enjoy. I hope others will like it as well.

I owe a debt of gratitude to many people. First, I want to again thank Kenny Wright. A great author. Without his encouragement and support I would never have gotten into publishing eBooks. You can see his stuff at <http://www.kennywriter.com>.

I also want to thank Kirsten McCurran who provided some very valuable feedback on the first half of the book. Her books are available on Amazon at <http://www.amazon.com/Kirsten-McCurran/e/B004ZV1SF6/>.

And finally, I need to thank Julie P who copyedited out as many of my seemingly endless typos as possible. You can hire her at <http://www.freelancer.com/u/jp2004.html>.

I also want to express my tremendous gratitude to the many, many readers who wrote me in response to my last book, *Two Sides of Terri*. I love the praise, of course, but even more I was delighted by the number of people who wanted to discuss the plot, explore the motivations of the characters, share their own theories about what happened "off-screen." As an author, there is nothing more gratifying than having people interact that way with a story.

Finally, I want, need to thank my lovely wife for her support. I've been writing in secret for years. I finally "came out" to her after publishing *Two Sides of Terri*. She was surprised at first, but tremendously supportive. I am a very lucky man, and very grateful to be sharing my life with this open-minded and sexy woman.

Whatever It Takes

CHAPTER ONE

Saturday is family outing day for Kris, the kids, and me. Going out to the park to run around doesn't count as a family outing. Nor does hanging out at the neighborhood pool checking out the cute neighborhood moms in their bikinis – not that Kris would do such a thing, though I might.

No, in our family, a "family outing" has to be educational. Now, our kids are one-and-a-half and three. So "educational" is more theoretical than practical, but I guess Kris wants to establish the habit early.

Today's educational outing was to the zoo.

"No, don't turn there," Kris snapped from the passenger seat.

I knew better than to argue, even though there was a sign that clearly indicated a parking lot to the right.

"We want to park in the Blue lot," she continued. "It's closer to the penguins."

I looked over at Kris. She was peering at a fully annotated map of the zoo. She had our entire visit plotted, probably including bathroom and snack breaks. Kris liked to plan things out. It was one of her most prominent characteristics.

She was also showing off an impressive demonstration of the "seatbelt effect," the shoulder strap wedged sexily between her full breasts. This was another of her prominent characteristics.

We put Todd in the stroller and Suzie grabbed a hold of my hand. She's already a Daddy's girl, for which I'm profoundly grateful. It's funny. I was so nervous about having kids. But from the very instant she emerged, blotchy and crying, I couldn't imagine life without her. I love Todd just as much, of course. But Suzie will always be my little angel.

We followed the itinerary Kris had set, which allowed us to see three animal shows and feedings, spend quality time with the prairie dogs (Suzie's favorite), and still make it back to the car before Todd's nap time. And all of that without backtracking at all. That's the thing about Kris' obsessive planning, it is hard to criticize since it so often works out so well.

She'd always been like that, or at least for as long as I'd known her. Which was forever. Though we're only thirty-one, Kris and I have been

together almost eighteen years. We started dating in junior high school.

She was a cute, somewhat nerdy kid, always top of the class, something of a teacher's pet, I guess, and not very popular. I was a bit of a wiseass, though I still did well in school. I made her laugh. I was small for my age. Not real popular either, but had a circle of gamer buddies. I was a little shy. She liked that, and she also liked that I never pressured her.

I'm still that same kid, in a way. I'm taller now, just a touch under six feet, but still real slim. More and more that seems to be a good thing. I have sandy hair, thinning a little, but not receding. I definitely fit in with my fellow engineers. She's a real beauty, in that girl-next-door, rarely-wear-any-makeup kind of way. Most people would be shocked at how voluptuous she is under her conservative attire.

I sighed. I often wished she'd let go, relax, have fun. But that wasn't her style. There was always a plan to follow.

Todd had fallen asleep in the car, so I carried him inside. He's at that age where it would take a nuclear explosion to wake him. Unfortunately, that's what I walked in on. Kris' sister Jessi was in the house and multitasking, which in this case meant talking on the phone, while surfing the web on my computer, and blasting music.

I gritted my teeth and waved my free arm to try to get her attention. She gave me a put-upon shrug as I gestured for her to turn down the volume.

As I walked him up the stairs and gently put Todd down, I quietly seethed at Jessi. Kris was nine years older than Jessi and had often played the role of surrogate mother to her troublesome little sister. She'd bailed her out, both literally and figuratively, many times. And now that Jessi was in trouble and that we had a house with space for a boarder, it was almost inevitable that she would come live with us. She'd actually stayed once with us years before, but that had been temporary. This was more open-ended.

Jessi has always been a handful. Even when she was nine she was getting into trouble, stealing money from her dad's wallet, raiding the liquor cabinet. She developed early. By twelve she already had long legs and was

otherwise physically mature for her age. She loved the attention she got from men as a result.

The first huge blowup occurred when Jessi was thirteen. Her parents walked in on her banging a nineteen-year-old in her bedroom. The kid managed to escape before her dad got his shotgun out of the gun safe. They threatened to get the kid arrested for statutory rape, until Jessi responded that if they did, she'd make sure they had to lock up the entire male population of the town, a threat she punctuated by letting herself get caught with a twenty-one year old the following week.

They tried the "not under my roof" rule, but that only led to their now-fourteen year-old daughter getting arrested for indecent exposure and public drunkenness in the park. She also got into drugs. First pot, and then harder stuff. As part of her behavioral problems, she got a prescription for Ritalin, at least until her folks caught her crushing the pills and snorting them.

Her parents had kicked her out of the house at sixteen, and she'd bounced around from one place to another since. A beautiful girl with a rather flexible sense of morality, she had no trouble finding a warm bed. There was always some dude willing to lend her money, give her a place to sleep, car rides. She wasn't completely dependent on them, however. She always had some scam running, and of course, the minute she turned eighteen, she started stripping.

Her latest situation blew up when her boyfriend, or whatever, was busted for cocaine possession. She'd ended up with us because Kris decided it was time to intervene.

I knew I shouldn't be doing it. It was definitely a betrayal of trust, a violation of privacy. But fuck it, if they didn't want to be spied on, then how come they were making so much damn noise?

Jessi was with her latest tattooed freak. We'd put her in the *au pair* suite, so she was able to come and go as she pleased. And she came and went a lot, returning several times over the first few weeks to have loud, aggressive sex. It almost felt like she was doing it precisely to rub it in our faces, even though we'd gone out of our way to take her in after her latest life blowup.

She'd grown into a stunning woman. Five-foot eight, she had small natural breasts, a tiny waist, and impossibly, long, toned legs. Kris and Jessi definitely look like sisters, although Kris is less showy, a little shorter, and much curvier. And while they share facial features, Kris has the conventional good looks—thick light brown hair, big, brown doe eyes and a roundish face. Jessi got the more exotic traits from the gene pool—high cheekbones, hazel eyes, and somewhat lanky, mahogany brown hair that she almost always kept dyed. It was currently almost reddish with a subtle tinge of violet.

Never subdued in dress, Jessi's clothes came in two sizes, tight and tighter. She had a bunch of tattoos, a constellation of stars on her right shoulder blade, a salamander coiled around her right thigh, and some Sanskrit poem on her left ribcage. Happily she'd never gotten into the whole piercing thing. She was, in short, an exotic, sensuous creature.

And, from what I could tell, she fucked like a demon. Tonight she was with her latest muscle-bound meathead. She'd always gone through men like a chainsaw. This one was definitely her type. She had brought him over several times. With his 'roided out physique, tribal tattoos, close-cropped hair and jaw-line beard, he looked like a refugee from *Sons of Anarchy*.

But despite his intimidating look, he might as well have been a prop. All the covers had been torn off the bed. He was lying on his back, and she was riding him like a woman possessed. Reverse cowgirl, with her hands resting on his abs, and face to the ceiling, she rode his thick cock hard enough that it looked like an accident waiting to happen. He didn't seemed worried. He was mauling her titties, urging her on, relishing the feel of his cock sliding into her shaved snatch over and over.

"Oh fuck, oh fuck, oh fuck," she growled.

"Yeah," he gurgled, "fuck me you dirty girl."

They'd been at it for a long time. I'd heard them pull into the drive nearly forty minutes earlier, and I'd heard them start fucking soon after. For twenty minutes I lay in bed beside Kris, until my curiosity again got the better of me and I decided to go for a look. I snuck out of bed, crept past the kids' rooms. Then down the stairs, through the TV room in the basement, to the *au pair* suite in the back of the house.

The *au pair* suite has a small sitting room, a kitchenette and bedroom. None of the doors were locked. It was as if Jessi and her lover

were hoping to be spied on. And I guess if I could fuck like that, or looked like that, maybe I'd be tempted to do the same.

Their sex was rough, their passion palpable. Though her lover had been passive earlier, he suddenly took charge. He grabbed her by the throat and began hammering her violently from below. His cock was a blur, the sound of it churning into her cunt, wet and obscene.

“Oh yeah,” she grunted. “Fuck me, you fucking bastard.”

Her body flopped around like a rag doll, beads of sweat arcing off her face as she swung her head back and forth. Then suddenly he paused. She was gasping for breath like she'd just run a sprint.

When he began thrusting again it was with long, deep slow strokes. Jessi's tight, bare pussy looked so obscene, stretched out by his thick tool. Each time he filled her, he paused, and she ground herself against him, obviously relishing the sensation of being so completely filled. He reached down and began rubbing her clit slowly.

Her excitement built, moment by moment. She was gasping, moaning, coming closer and closer. When she climaxed, it was like a dam bursting. She let out a long, low hiss, and then convulsed on top of him, her abdominal muscles rippling, her face first scrunching into a tight grimace and then relaxing into a luminous smile.

“Oh fuck, that was good,” she sighed.

He let her enjoy it for a few more seconds, then he said, “My turn.”

With that he lifted her off him and deposited her on her back. He rolled on top of her and wedged her legs over his shoulders.

“Put it in,” he ordered.

She obediently stroked his cock and then placed against her pussy. With a violent thrust, he buried himself inside her. She gasped and threw back her head. He didn't hesitate. Instead he began to pound her relentlessly. She wrapped her arms around his neck, holding on for dear life.

“Oh God, oh God, oh God,” she cried out, louder and louder.

I couldn't help myself. It was the hottest thing I'd ever seen in my life. I began rubbing myself through my pajama bottoms in time with his strokes.

“Where do you want it?” he asked.

She didn't hesitate.

“I wanna taste it,” she cooed.

That was apparently the right answer for him. With surprising grace for a big man, he scampered to the top of the bed. Jessi stared right at his cock and opened her mouth wide. He stroked himself once, twice, and then fired a thick rope of come across her tongue. He added two more spurts into her open mouth. Seeing Jessi with a mouthful of jism was too much. I came hard, filling my own pants.

“Nice aim,” Jessi giggled after swallowing his load.

He laughed.

“I have had lots of practice jerking myself off,” he replied. A drop of come dripped onto her cheek. He wiped it off with his fingertip. She grabbed his wrist and licked it off.

“I want every drop.”

She sucked lewdly on his digits and reached out for his cock. He ran his other hand down over her body, over her perky tits, her flat belly. He found her sex and plunged two thick fingers inside her.

“You want more?”

She gave him a lewd grin as she nodded her head. “Always.”

Then as they prepared for round two, I slunk away, got cleaned up and climbed back into bed with my wife.

CHAPTER TWO

As I've said, my life with Kris was as much in control as Jessi's was out of control. That included sex. It was a year of "dating" -- if that is what you call it when two thirteen-year-olds hang out together -- before we even kissed. And I didn't get to second base with her until we were sixteen. That was one of our first fights. Not because I'd tried anything, but because I'd lied to my buddies about it, claiming that I'd been playing with her big boobies for years. She said I'd made her feel like a whore.

Still, we stayed together all through high school and then went to college together. After a year in freshman dorms, we got engaged and moved in together in "couples housing."

There was no question of sex, of course that whole time. At first, Kris had talked about waiting for marriage, and I was willing to go along with that. But ultimately, we decided to take the step once we were engaged and living together.

It was expectedly awkward at first. Even though we'd been a couple for six years already, once our clothes were off it was almost like we were strangers. But we got better at it, figured out how to please each other. And even though I sometimes wonder what it would be like with other women, I also love knowing that we have this amazing gift of knowing that every sexual experience we've had we've experienced together.

Still, it was a little hard not to question the value of that gift when confronted with a performance like I'd seen in the *au pair* suite. Kris and I had experimented a little with different positions, and oral was an important part of our sex lives. But we were pretty conventional. Half the time missionary, the other half with her on top, but always face-to-face, kissing, cuddling, making love.

We'd never really had any crazy nights of passion. Part of it was that Kris was always very regimented, and that included birth control. She didn't want to be on the pill, didn't like the idea of anything remaining in her body, her system. So we used condoms religiously. Spontaneity was out.

The one exception to our birth control routine was two brief periods, two years apart when we'd been trying to get Kris pregnant. Not

that we were particularly spontaneous even then. In fact we were even more on a schedule than ever, but the feel of sex, unencumbered by prophylactics and foams was glorious. Unfortunately, Kris was, as always, an overachiever, and each time managed to get pregnant in a single cycle. And unfortunately, the minute she got pregnant, her sex drive shut down because of bad morning sickness and sensitivity.

I am not sure I can remember the last time we did anything spontaneous. Even before we had kids, when in theory we could have been wild and carefree, we never were.

I don't want to make it sound like I'm complaining. I'm not. I love Kris, and I've loved her since middle school. So I'm not complaining. What do I have to complain about? I have a beautiful wife, perfect kids, a cute little house, and a job that pays the bills. It's the American dream. Right?

Sometimes I do think about a less structured existence. I like to think that I'm the free spirit in the relationship, although in truth that is only true relatively speaking. Kris is uncommonly organized. I only seem less so by comparison. Neither one of us is really laid back.

The odd thing is that for all the planning, I am not sure I can remember any of the real decisions in our lives. I don't think I ever formally asked her out. I don't know that there was a particular moment when we coordinated the decision to attend State. I don't even know that I ever proposed to her. All of these things happened, as if according to a script, but with no actual script. Kris and I are so controlled that we somehow hit all our marks without actually planning it.

I'm not sure from where she gets it. Her family is, to be kind, more than a little weird. Her dad travelled a lot. I rarely really saw him. Her mom was even stranger. I remember coming over one day to find every surface in their kitchen covered in freshly baked cookies. Another time, I came over to find her tearing out the carpet in the living room.

"Are you remodeling?" I asked Kris' mom.

"Yeah," she replied, eyes shining. "I just couldn't live with this carpet a moment longer."

There was often a lot of turmoil in their house, which is why, I guess, Kris was so keen to spend time with my more conventional family. Not that we had all of our shit together. My parents divorced when I was just a little kid. Dad married his secretary and they moved out of town. They had their own kids and I didn't see them much. My sister and I stayed

with my mom. She remarried as well, to an older man. Nice guy. He passed away soon after I went to college.

But at least for my later childhood, my home life was pretty stable, and even though Kris and I were boyfriend/girlfriend, it was almost like my mom adopted her as her own.

Jessi was always the complicating factor. She idolized her big sister. Kris doted on her as well. It was super hard on Kris when we went away to school.

When Jessi had gotten kicked out of her last apartment after the drug bust, she came to us looking to borrow some money. She said she made enough "dancing" to cover her expenses, but need help with first and last month's rent and a security deposit.

Kris took charge. She told Jessi to move in with us. Told her she could come and go as she pleased, but there were three conditions: no drugs, no stripping, and she had to go back to school and get her GED and some job training. Jessi obviously resented the intervention, but Kris held firm. She told Jessi that her life was a train wreck, that if she didn't change now, she'd end up dead or in jail. And somehow it worked. It started off as an acrimonious conversation, but by the end the girls were crying and hugging and making plans for the future.

I wanted to believe, but I just had a bad feeling about Jessi. She'd always been manipulative and reckless, and it seemed hard to believe that she was ready to turn over a new leaf. But for the first month, things went well.

I was concerned about her socializing, but Kris defended her sister.

"It's hard for her to make these changes. She needs to have an outlet to blow off some steam."

I shook my head. "I don't know, honey, I think she's mixed up in a bad crowd."

Kris grinned. "You sure you're not just jealous?"

I hesitated. Kris knew I was attracted to Jessi. I wasn't obvious about it, at least I didn't think I was, but there was no denying that my eyes sometimes lingered on her when she was prancing around in another one of her skintight outfits.

"Don't be silly," I said with a laugh. "I love your sister, but she's insane."

"Look, being promiscuous is about the least of her sins. If she ends up getting her degree and a respectable job, then I think we can consider our job done, no matter how many men she sleeps with."

I nodded, but I couldn't help but have my doubts.

Kris had taken the kids to her folks for the weekend. Her parents were peculiar enough that we didn't trust them to watch the kids on their own, so Kris was going to stay as well. I was trying to catch up on mowing Saturday when Jessi bounded into the yard looking for me.

She was in yoga pants and a jog bra, looking by far more obscene than athletic.

"Hey Danny Dan, can you do me a huge favor?" she said, batting her eyelashes at me.

Uh oh, I thought to myself. "Sure, Jess, what's up?"

She leaned in close, conspiratorially. "Well, it's just that I, um, have a gig tonight, and I don't have a driver."

"Why don't you drive yourself?" I paused. "What kind of gig?"

"Promise you won't tell Kris?"

"I can't --"

She cut me off before I could finish the sentence. "It's a bachelor party."

I sighed. "Oh God, Jessi, you promised Kris you were done with, um, dancing."

"I know, I know. I am done. It's just that I agreed to do this one a while back, and, well, I really could use the money. You know, saving for school, that kind of stuff."

"I can't Jessi. Kris would kill me."

"She'd probably kill you too if she knew you liked spying on me when I'm with Damon."

"What... what are you talking about?" I sputtered.

She laughed. "You're not a ninja, you know. Or what, you just figured I was too lost in the moment to notice you in the doorway rubbing your crotch?"

"I don't know what you're talking about," I replied resolutely. Deny deny deny. She had no proof. It was just her word against mine.

She softened. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have said that, I would never tell Kris. But it's just I really need help tonight. Otherwise, it's just me, alone, in a roomful of guys."

"Don't go then."

"I have to. I promised." She bit her lip, sobbed. "Please Danny, I really need the money if I'm ever going to get back on my feet. You and Kris have been so amazing, but I can't keep depending on you."

I sighed. "I appreciate that, but you know this is the wrong way. There's no future in this."

She nodded. A tear now rolling down each cheek. "I promise. This is my last gig. Just help me out this one time and I'll never do it again."

"Jeez, Jessi..."

"Pleeease," she begged.

"Oh fuck it, okay."

Why had I agreed to it? Part of it was that I couldn't resist her entreaties. The begging, the tears. Like a lot of men, I find it difficult to deny a damsel in distress. But I'm not stupid either. I knew, well, at least strongly suspected it was an act. But I still went along with it.

Part of it then was that her blackmail threat still hung in the air. There was no way around it. Kris would kill me if she knew I'd been spying on her sister having sex. I could deny it, but one consequence of being together since we were thirteen is that Kris could read me like an open book.

And part of it, I realized, was that I wanted to go. I wanted to see Jessi naked again, stripping for a bunch of guys. And also, I'd never been to a real bachelor party. Yeah, I went out to play pool with a couple of buddies before my wedding, but I'd never been to a party with strippers and that kind of thing. Hell, I'd never even been to a strip club.

Which of those three was most important? I don't know. And really, it didn't matter.

Fuck, Jessi looked hot.

I was waiting for her in the foyer when she came up from downstairs wearing a trench coat and carrying an oversized purse. It was 10:00 pm and we needed to head out.

Always a pretty girl, she definitely knew how to bring out her best features. She had her hair brushed out, silky and shiny, her violet highlights subtle and sexy. She had just a little color on her cheeks to bring out the exotic shape of her face, and she accentuated her almond shaped eyes just enough to call attention to the shifting, playful hazel pupils. Only her lips were prominently made up, outlined with a dark red liner and painted up red and glossy.

As she approached, she pulled open her coat and flashed me her outfit. I gasped out loud. She was wearing a super sexy lingerie outfit, black mesh, thigh-high stockings, a matching lace corselet, tiny thong panties, and four inch "fuck me" heels.

"How do I look?" she asked with a mischievous grin.

"Um... great..." I stammered.

"Does Kris ever dress for you like this?" she teased.

I shook my head without thinking. Then as my mind cleared, "You're not dressed for me."

She laughed and pulled her coat closed. "Nope. But you'll still get to see it... and more."

She strode confidently out the front door. I adjusted my partial erection and followed.

The party was in a suite at the Four Seasons. The groom, or his buddies, obviously had some money, which struck me was probably why Jessi was so determined to keep the gig.

As I walked her through the lobby, it occurred that this was probably one of the reasons she'd approached me to go. Without me there, she'd have likely been identified and stopped as a whore. Even with me there, we got more than our share of funny looks.

In the room, we met the groom, Vinny, and a half-dozen of his buddies. Vinny was a skinny kid, in his mid-twenties, but with a baby face and dark, almost black hair. The rest of the guys were an assortment of young monies, a couple of blondish frat boy types, a tall, skinny Euro, an overstuffed fat boy wearing a ten thousand dollar Rolex. The one exception was an older dude, standing apart from the rest, barrel-chested, wearing a dark suit. He looked like some sort of professional muscle.

All the younger guys were wired, talking fast, bouncing off the furniture. Despite the expensive surroundings, this was a dark, dangerous crowd. Over on the desk, I noticed several lines of cocaine cut and ready to be snorted. I'd only ever seen that in movies. Jessi glanced over hungrily.

"Go ahead, take a hit," encouraged Vinny.

She stalked over to the table and snorted two lines. She shook her head and then wheeled around dramatically.

"Hey boys," Jessi cried enthusiastically as she shed her trench coat.

The guys hooted and hollered in response. She'd given instructions before we'd arrived. She'd identify the groom and get him seated in a chair; I'd fire up the play list on her phone, pumping it through a portable speaker.

"Turn it up," she hollered as I got the music going, a pounding hip-hop mix.

I did and then quickly retreated to a corner of the room. The rest of the bachelor party made a semicircle around Jessi and Vinny.

She began to sway sensuously, circling Vinny, running her hands up and down her body. She cupped her breasts and suggestively rubbed her thighs. She slid her panties to the side and flashed Vinny, and the rest of us, her shaved snatch.

Then dramatically she dropped into his lap. She wrapped her arms around his neck and ground herself into his lap. His hands were all over her, clawing at her lace-covered tits, squeezing her firm ass. He reached between her legs. Jesus, this was moving faster and further than I had expected, feared... hoped?

Then suddenly she rose up and slapped Vinny firmly across the face, wagging his finger in her face. His buddies gasped. The big guy in the corner surged forward. I was frozen, rooted to the spot, unsure what I should, or could do, if this turned violent.

I don't deal well with violence or the threat of it. It has never been part of my life. I thought back to a recent night out.

I'd gotten a sitter. I wasn't sure it would take. Though in theory Kris was open to leaving the kids and going out on our own, we'd never actually managed to pull it off.

As a surprise for her birthday, I'd gotten us tickets to *Book of Mormon*. As with everything else, our town is always two to three years behind the times, and it was the hot ticket. Kris hemmed and hawed, but finally agreed to go.

We went out to dinner at *Vesuvius*, the best of many Italian places in town, though one of the few that wasn't an old-fashioned checkered tablecloth kind of place. I splurged on Lobster Fra Diavolo. Kris had a scallop risotto. We shared a nice bottle of white.

The show was a hoot. Just as good as the reviews promised.

"We should do this more often," Kris said as we walked outside.

It was an early fall evening. Just a slight chill in the air. We huddled close as we walked to the car.

There were footsteps behind us. I felt my stomach tighten. I pulled Kris closer.

"Hey man, can you spare something to help me out?"

He wasn't real big. Really just a kid, but ratty, obviously a creature of the street. He didn't have a gun, but his hand was in his pocket. Was he armed?

He looked Kris up and down. She pulled her coat tight around her.

"Leave us alone," I croaked.

"Come on man, help me out."

He had a wild look in his eyes. I had no idea what he was capable of. I reached into my pocket, pulled out my wallet. I handed him a twenty.

"You can do better," he sneered. Again, he eyed Kris.

I didn't want to let him hurt her.

"Okay, okay," I whined, my voice suddenly very tight.

I emptied my wallet. \$107. I handed it over.

He took it and smirked. Again he looked at Kris. There was no ambiguity about it. He was thinking about taking her as well.

"Please, leave us alone," I pleaded.

Another smirk, as if he were giving me a gift. "Okay man. You two have fun."

He turned and slowly stalked away.

Kris and I walked to our car in silence. I was mortified. She was sensitive enough not to say anything either. But I could see the disappointment in her eyes, or maybe I was just projecting my own feelings. Whatever.

Back in the hotel room, I realized everyone was laughing. It was all a tease. She unbuttoned her corselet, freeing her boobs, pinching her nipples hard. She sat back in his lap, and pulled his face to her chest as he hungrily sucked her erect nubs into his mouth.

Then again she pulled away. More dirty dancing. She circled behind him, bent at the waist sucking on his earlobes as she shook her ass in my direction. When I tore my eyes away from her behind to her face, she gave me a saucy wink. Even as she stripped for Vinny, she was still making a special effort to tease me.

She slipped off her heels, and placed her foot in his crotch, toeing his package, nodding toward her stockings until he got the message and rolled it off. She repeated the routine with her other foot. She stepped back into her heels and swayed before him in just her panties and pumps.

Now, she circled the room, grinding up against each of other guests in turn as they fondled her tits and pinched her ass. She kept her distance from me, but took her time with the bodyguard dude, rubbing him up and down, kissing his neck, trying and failing to elicit more than a slightly amused reaction from him. Finally, she gave up and returned to Vinny.

She positioned herself before him, facing away, waving her perfect little ass in his face. She looked back over her shoulder, shook her hair out of her eyes, and gave him a lewd smile. Then she hooked her thumb in her panties and nodded at him until he took the hint and reached out and pulled them down.

She slipped her panties over her heels and turned to place them on his head. Then with a dramatic leg kick, she placed one heel on the back of his chair, above his shoulder, and tilted forward, giving him close-in view of her pretty, shaved snatch.

Jessi licked her index finger and then slid it between her labia, splitting her pussy open and giving Vinny a flash of the pink, juicy flesh within. He licked his lips hungrily, his hands caressing her inner thigh. She cupped his cheek with one hand, and then trailed her painted fingertips down his chest, rooting around in his lap, and finally stroking his cock through his pants.

She then took his other hand in hers and sucked his fingers wetly into her mouth, pumping them past her full, red lips, encircling them with her tongue. When his digits were nice and wet, she pulled his hand down across her own chest, dragging his fingertips over her nipples, and then down between her legs. Vinny eagerly thrust two fingers into her tight little pussy, finger banging her hard, even as she continued to gyrate her hips and stroke his cock.

Then suddenly the music stopped. I checked my watch. Precisely a half hour had passed. She stood back away from him.

"You're a bad boy," she chided. "What would your fiancée say?"

He laughed. She grinned.

"Okay, I'm gonna freshen up," she said, walking toward the bedroom, shaking her tight ass as she went.

She looked over her shoulder and made eye contact with me. With a head nod, she beckoned me over. My hands over my lap to hide, barely, my erection, I caught up with her at the doorway.

"Okay, Danny Dan, here's the deal. One guy at a time. One fifty for oral. Two fifty for half and half or straight sex. Five hundred for anal. Bareback costs twice as much."

I gasped at her. "Jesus, Jessi, I can't be part of that."

She sighed. "Oh, grow the fuck up. You don't think they paid me to come up here just to shake my ass and tease them, do you?"

"I... I... I don't know," I stammered.

"Come on, Danny, this is the last time. I swear." She softened, forced a smile. "Look, consider it collecting contributions toward my college fund."

I wanted to say no, walk away. But I was already in so deep. I shrugged resignedly.

"Great. And make sure to get a thousand for the show."

I nodded. She disappeared into the bedroom.

I took a deep breath and somewhat sheepishly approached the guys who were standing in a circle, and looking over toward us. I managed to get out her quote sheet, and the best man counted off bills.

"Okay, dude, here's the grand and three to get the groom started with a bareback hummer."

He then clapped Vinny on the shoulder and said, "Go get her." He shoved his buddy toward the bedroom. Then turning to me, he said, "She better swallow it all, or we get our money back."

"I... I'm not sure..."

He laughed. "Relax man, just busting your chops."

I forced a laugh.

The guys flipped on the TV and tuned to an MMA match. They were pouring scotches, offered me one, which I took. They were also cutting lines, which I declined.

It was a crazy scene. Six of us sitting around watching two maniacs beating the crap out of each other on TV, while in the next room my sister-in-law was turning tricks.

After about three minutes, Vinny walked back out to cheers and taunts. "Did you even get it up? That was quick! Yeah, tell us about it, quick-draw!"

He laughed and shrugged, then stooped over the desk to do a couple of lines. "What can I say, she's good."

"Good enough for me," replied the best man, slipping five hundred into my hand.

Jessi had given me no real instructions. I guess she was worried that it would freak me out. I was flying blind. What had he just bought? Bareback straight sex? Was I supposed to confirm it with him? Let her know what was being paid for? What if a guy gave me money for a blowjob with a condom and then had unprotected sex with her? How long would I go to prison if we were busted? And how fast would Kris divorce me if she found out?

These were the sorts of questions that ran through my head as I continued to collect money and Jessi continued to fuck men in the bedroom. They all took at least one turn, a few of them two. All of them chose to pay the bare backing premium.

The best man approached me again. "Alright, bud, got a special request. We've been saving her backdoor for the groom, but we want them

to do it out here."

"I don't think that's an option."

He slapped me lightly across the face. "Don't think. Just ask the whore how much."

I blushed a deep red and quickly excused myself, bristling as their laughs filled the room.

I opened the door to the bedroom.

Jessi was naked, of course. Wearing just her heels. The last guy had paid for sex, so she was wiping down her pussy.

When she heard the door open, she called out, "Hey baby...." But then she saw me. "Oh, it's you."

She continued to towel herself off, completely shameless in her nudity. God, she looked so hot. The fact that she was such a complete slut made it that much more erotic. She'd taken almost a dozen loads already, and she was still ready for more.

She threw her hands out in annoyance. "Well, we done or what?"

I shook my head. I explained the request.

She sighed. "Okay, fuck, whatever. Tell them fifteen hundred and a nice bump.... Oh, and if any of the others want to cum on my face while I'm getting fucked, that a hundred a pop," she added as an afterthought.

"A bump?"

She tapped her nose.

I nodded. I was past any desire to resist. I just wanted this evening to end. I communicated her terms. They agreed enthusiastically. It occurred to me that she could have driven a harder bargain. And I groaned at the realization that I was so far through the looking glass that I was actually thinking about ways to best pimp out my wife's sister rather the recoiling in horror at it all.

Jessi threw open the door to the bedroom dramatically.

"So, I hear you perverts want to watch a girl get fucked up the ass?"

Cheers. Hoots. Someone snapped off the TV.

She ambled over to the desk and hoovered down some lines. Then she crossed the room and bent over the back of the sofa, giving me a perfect view of her amazing ass, her puffy pussy.

To Vinny she asked, "So, you want me to suck your dick first?"

"Hell yeah," he growled, approaching the sofa with his dick out.

She sucked him deep into her mouth as the other guys teased him not to come too fast. He gave them a cocky "I've got this" smile and grabbing, her head with both hands, began face fucking her roughly.

While the others were mostly focused on Vinny pumping his cock past her lips and her loud slurping sounds, I had an even more erotic view. Even as she was getting his cock hot and wet, she was fingering her own ass, plunging first one then two of her slender, painted fingers deep into her own bottom. It was mesmerizing, the lewdest thing I'd ever seen, even in porn.

After a few minutes, Vinny moved around to the other side of the sofa. She looked back over her shoulder, her hair now a mess, her lipstick smudged. We were looking right at each other, but our eyes never made contact. Hers were glassy, distant. I didn't know whether it was the drugs or just her retreating to some place emotionally to get through this.

Vinny spanked each ass cheek once, firmly. Then without any further preliminaries, he pressed his cockhead into her anus and thrust in hard.

Her eyes went wide and she clearly stifled a scream. I took a quick step forward as if to intervene, but immediately felt a strong hand on my shoulder holding me back. The bodyguard was looking at me, shaking his head.

I was about to protest that Vinny was being too rough, when I heard Jessi's voice. "That's it baby, give it to me hard. Fuck my tight little ass."

The bodyguard gave me a smile as he felt me relax.

Vinny was really ramming her forcefully, showing off for his friends. He wrapped some strands of hands around his fist and yanked back hard, forcing her to arch her back. He was fucking her balls deep, his thighs slapping her ass loudly with each thrust.

"Oooh, that feels so good," she exclaimed, her voice high and tight. "I love your big cock in my ass. You're going to make me come."

"Fuck, she's hot," Vinny growled. "Come on guys, come on her face," he moaned insistently. It was obvious he wasn't going to last long.

The fat guy with the big watch stepped up first, whipping out his cock and stroking it in her face. She took over for him, spitting in her palm, and expertly stroking his shaft.

"Come in my mouth," she moaned. "I want to taste it."

That was too much for fat boy and he came with a shudder as she closed her lips over his cockhead. One of the blond frat boy types was next. Then the skinny Euro dude. Each got the same treatment and finished equally fast.

Finally the best man stepped up. "I'm gonna paint you white," he growled. Unlike the other guys, he slapped away her hand, instead stroking himself, aiming his cock right between her eyes. He came hard, three or four thick streams splashing on her forehead, nose, and cheeks.

"Fuck yeah," he exclaimed as the others cheered.

"Look at me," Vinny ordered.

She looked back at him, her face a complete mess, covered in jism which was now running down her chin and dripping on the sofa as her head jerked back and forth in time with his hard thrusts.

"Come in my ass, baby. I want to feel your hot come in my ass."

That was too much for Vinny. With a loud growl, he buried himself fully inside her and shuddered.

After a few more slow thrusts, he pulled out, her once tight little ass gaping open obscenely for a few moments until she pushed herself into standing position.

"I'm gonna get cleaned up if you want more," she said heading toward the bedroom.

But it was obvious the guys were done. They were sheepishly averting their eyes from the spot on the sofa she'd recently occupied and were instead making plans to go back out to an underground poker game.

I shook myself out of my trance and went about collecting final payments. Several of the guys threw in tips as well. By the time she emerged in her trench coat, having concluded that there'd be no more business, I had packed up rest of her stuff and was clutching a thick wad of cash. We left after a few quick goodbyes.

In the car, driving home, we sat initially in strained silence. Since I'd packed up her lingerie, I knew that she was naked beneath her coat, which was oddly titillating even though for the past two hours I'd seen her completely naked, taking a dick up her ass.

She cleared her throat, "So, um, how much?"

I reached into my pocket and handed her the money. She counted it beside me. \$7200 in total.

"Nice night," she commented.

I could only grunt in response. Jesus that was more, a lot more, than Kris and I took home in a month, and she'd made that in a little more than two hours.

She counted off seven hundred-dollar bills. "You want yours in cash or trade?"

"What?"

"You get ten percent. Do you want the money or do you want to fuck me?"

"Are you shitting me?"

"That's the way it works. And you've seen enough to know I'm not playing. Fuck, I'll suck you off while you drive if you want."

I shook my head. "Jesus, Jessi. I don't want the money... or the sex. Just keep it."

"You sure?"

"Yes."

She held out the cash. "Okay, going once... going twice... I suck a mean cock," she said temptingly. I held my tongue. "Three times."

She leaned over and kissed me on the cheek, a surprisingly gentle gesture. "Thank you Danny Dan, I really appreciate what you did for me this evening."

"You're welcome. I guess. You're done with this, right?"

She shook the cash; it fluttered loudly. "Yeah, I'm done," she replied as she wistfully contemplated the money. "Just need to take care of one more thing."

I sighed. "Damn it, Jessi, you promised me."

"I promised no more stripping. I won't. And I'm done taking cock for money."

"So what's the one thing?"

"Let's say it's an investment in the future."

"If you need some investment advice, I know some good people who can help --"

She cut me off with a laugh. "Don't you worry your pretty little head about it, Danny Dan."

I didn't like the sound of that, but didn't really know how to proceed.

After a few more minutes of silence, my curiosity got the better of me. "Do you always make that much?"

She shook her head and clucked her tongue. "Naw uh. Best night ever. Helps that they all went bareback."

"Doesn't that worry you?"

"That's why it costs more," she replied simply.

"Did you even know those guys?"

"My, you're full of questions."

"I just --"

"You just want to know how I can be willing to get fucked bareback by six guys."

"I guess."

"No, I didn't know them personally. But the groom, Vinny... I, um, know his father."

"Dad set it up?"

She laughed. "Yeah. Guess he wanted to make sure his son had fun."

"Jesus." Who were these people?

She chortled again. Was she laughing at my naiveté?

"What?"

"Well, I was just thinking that poor Vinny didn't inherit his dad's size. I wonder if he knows." She laughed again.

I could only shake my head.

CHAPTER THREE

I didn't see Jessi much the rest of the weekend. Actually didn't see her at all. At first, I figured she was sleeping in or something. She'd had a long night after all. But as afternoon came around, I wondered if she was okay.

I went down to the *au pair* suite and knocked on her door. No answer. I began to sweat the worst case. Had she overdosed or something? She'd snorted a bunch of coke last night. I didn't know enough about drugs to know whether that was enough.

I opened the door and went inside. For a few moments I wasn't sure what I was seeing. Her blinds were drawn and her room was a mess, clothes, and possessions, all over the place. It looks like a tornado had hit the place.

I walked over to the bed. There was a lump in the middle. Tentatively, fearing the worst, I reached out and poked at it. It was a relief to find it was just a balled up blanket.

I pulled the blinds up and the room filled with light. She wasn't there. I checked the bathroom as well, but no, she wasn't anywhere. She must have gotten up before me and slipped out. Her bag from last night, complete with mini-speaker and balled up lingerie, was tossed in a corner. No sign of the cash, but I was pretty sure a girl like Jessi wouldn't leave that kind of money lying around.

I shrugged. Weird. Jessi wasn't usually an early riser, and after last night I would have thought she'd be resting. But nope.

I was sort of happy not to have Jessi around, not to have to be face to face with her. It was already hard enough reliving the memory of last night. How could I have let myself get involved in that?

What if the cops had busted us? Drugs. Prostitution. And that was before we got into what any of those guys were into on their own. God only know how much trouble would have come out of it.

But thinking about the legal consequences was actually a respite. My biggest fear was Kris. If she ever found out, what would I say to her? What could I say? That I had gone to keep Jessi safe? By letting her whore herself out to a roomful of men? Allowing her to snort a bunch of cocaine? Kris would divorce me. That was the best case. Worst case, she would kill me. That was far-fetched, but the reality is that just contemplating her anger was frightening.

Kris came home with the kids late Sunday afternoon, basically just in time for us to get a quick meal into them and put them to bed. After, we sat down for a light dinner ourselves.

"So did you have fun?" she asked.

"What do you mean?" I asked panicked.

She gave me a queer look. "I mean, you had a weekend without the kids. You didn't just do yard work did you?"

I forced myself to breathe. "No. I mean... I did a lot of yard work. But, right, that's not all I did..."

"Are you okay?"

I felt so guilty. The urge to confess all, to throw myself on her mercy, was close to overwhelming. It almost seemed worth the certain wrath just to get it off my chest.

"Daniel?"

I gasped. "Yes. Yes. I'm okay. Sorry, I was just distracted. To tell you the truth, I didn't do very much. Yard work. Watched some TV," I prayed she wouldn't ask me what, because I doubted I could make up a decent answer. "Slept late. Just relaxed."

She smiled. "Okay good."

I breathed a sigh of relief. How could she not see I was dying inside? I forced a smile. "How about you?"

She laughed. "Oh the usual. My mom doting over the kids, feeding them sugary stuff behind my back. My dad trying ask questions about work even when Susie was screaming about how she hated veggies."

"We talked about Jessi," she said. Again I felt my insides tighten.

"Oh?"

"Yeah. They were just saying how happy they were that we took her in. That finally, she might be turning a new leaf."

Kill me, I thought.

"Where is she, by the way?"

I was panicking, but happily I was able to answer honestly. "I don't know. I haven't seen her today. I slept in and she was gone when I woke up."

A look of concern crossed Kris' face. "Weird. Oh well, how much trouble can she get in on a Sunday?"

I shrugged.

As guilty as I felt, I was also very turned on all day. Even as I did chores around the house, I kept thinking about Jessi. About how she'd looked when she stripped for Vinny. I kept fantasizing about what had gone on in that hotel bedroom. All those men, one after another after another. I remembered what she'd looked like when I walked in, naked, in just her high heels, the sheen on her body.

But mostly I kept reliving the scene out in the main room, when Vinny had fucked her up the ass. I had never seen anything so depraved, so raunchy. Those minutes where she'd blown him while at the same time fingering her butt... just thinking about it got me close to blowing my load.

I was thinking about that as I climbed into bed with Kris. She was in flannel nightdress. I pulled her close, spooning her.

"I missed you," I said.

I ran my hand over the front of her dress, feeling her curves. As my palm slipped between her breasts, she took my hand in hers and held it tight. That was her sign that she wasn't interested in sex; that she just wanted to snuggle.

"I missed you too," she said. Then came the excuse. "I'm tired from having the kids all weekend."

I suppressed a sigh. I wondered if Jessi ever turned down sex. She didn't seem like the kind of girl who would. Even right now, she was probably out getting fucked. Maybe she was with her tattooed boyfriend. I pictured her squatting before him, naked, her snatch swollen and ready. I

could see her sucking that big cock of his, making lewd smacking sounds with her lips, taking him balls deep until she gagged.

I could imagine him picking her up, throwing her on the bed. She was the kind of girl who'd spread her legs wide, shamelessly displaying her wet cunt, fingering herself, licking the digits clean.

"You sure you don't want a little pick me up," I offered gently.

It was Kris' turn to suppress a sigh. She yawned but released my hand, allowing me to resume my gentle exploration of her body. She pressed back against me, feeling my erection.

"I guess you did miss me," she said.

"Hmmm, I did," I replied.

I gently cupped her full breasts, circling her nipples, prominent even through the thick fabric. I leaned in close and kissed her neck.

I slid my hand down the front of her dress and reached under the hem. I trailed my fingertips across the downy hair of her thighs. She rolled over onto her back and began rubbing my crotch through my boxers. She turned her head toward me and we kissed, gently at first, then more passionately.

As we kissed, I rubbed her mound through her panties.

"Maybe we should get out of these clothes," I offered.

We stripped, then slid back under the covers and resumed making out. She was stroking my cock up and down slowly. I worked my fingertip through her thick muff, until I uncovered her sex. I went slowly, tracing her labia with my fingertip, feeling her beginning to respond to my touch.

"Can I kiss you down there?" I asked.

"Yes."

I ducked my head under the covers and parted her hair. Slowly I licked her slit up and down, tasting her, feeling her excitement build. She moaned softly and after a few minutes, she pulled me back up beside her. I leaned in to kiss her mouth, but she gave me her cheek instead rather than taste herself on my lips.

"Do you want to be on top?" she asked.

I nodded. I rolled over onto her. She took my cock and ran it up and down her slit, gently working the head of my cock inside her. I was so ready. I just wanted to thrust in hard, but Kris always wanted to go slow. I let her set the pace, let her control how deep I went, just giving her small gentle thrusts.

Finally she released my shaft and I was able to sink in all the way. She sighed happily. I closed my eyes. We were in the dark and under the covers anyway. There was nothing to see. I thought again of Jessi. Imagined her, legs in the air, grunting like an animal. I thrust in hard.

"Slow down," Kris urged.

I did. Kris cooed happily. This was how she liked it. Nice and gentle. I liked it that way too... for the most part... though in truth I often dreamt of something more. I wanted to be able to watch Kris' big tits bouncing. I would have loved to flip her over on her hands and knees and take her from behind. Have her suck me off as we switched from position to position.

She let out a soft whine, and I again slowed down. I tried to force Jessi out of my mind and focus just on Kris. I knew what she liked, what she wanted, and I proceeded to give it to her. We made love slowly, gently. Enough time had passed since I'd eaten her out that she was willing to kiss me again. So we kissed.

I could feel her excitement building, her breaths becoming shallower.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God," she sighed.

I felt the familiar sensation of her pussy clutching at my staff. It was my time now. I thrust into her harder, faster.

"Go ahead," she urged.

I thought again of Jessi. Of her getting taken from behind, up the ass, watched by a roomful of men. I thought about what it would have been like to take my cut in trade. God, she would have rocked my world. I pictured her, on her hands and knees, a wild look in her eyes.

"Fuck my ass, Danny Dan. Fuck me up the ass."

I came hard with a grunt and a hard thrust.

After, I rolled off Kris and lay beside her. We held hands.

"Thank you," I said softly.

"Can I get some sleep now?" she teased.

I forced a laugh. "And who says romance dies after kids?"

I'd come, but I was far from satisfied. The moment I rolled over, my mind went back to Jessi, to what she'd do to me, what she would let me do to her. I fell asleep with those lewd thoughts in my mind, hoping that my dreams would flesh them out, but they didn't.

When we didn't see Jessi on Monday either, I could see Kris getting more worked up. She'd been texting Jessi since she'd gotten home.

"She probably just has a new boyfriend," I suggested.

"Maybe," she replied. "But she usually answers my texts."

"Does she?"

"Okay, not always promptly, but this is longer than usual. I just hope she's okay."

"She's a tough broad," I replied. "She can take care of herself."

Kris laughed. "Yeah, but I worry about whoever she's with."

"About what they might do to her? Or she to them?"

"Exactly."

But in the end, Kris had dealt with Jessi's erratic behavior long enough that she didn't really get too frantic.

Monday evening went according to a well-practiced routine. Todd went down at 7:00 pm, Suzie at 7:30 pm. We had dinner at 8:00 pm. Like clockwork. Always like clockwork.

CHAPTER FOUR

Kris' one flight of fancy is a weird addiction to reality TV. We'd called up the latest *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* on the DVR and had about settled in to watch when the doorbell rang.

We live in a pretty isolated development, so we sometimes get late UPS deliveries. An 8:45 pm doorbell was weird, but not unheard of. Kris sprang to her feet to get the door before it rang again potentially waking up the kids.

My first hint that something was wrong was the sound of loud footsteps in the foyer.

I stood and ran almost headlong into three men pushing their way into our house, Kris trailing after them, looking more angry than scared.

In shock I recognized one of them. He was the older, burly guy who'd been keeping an eye on things at the bachelor party.

When he saw me, he called out, "Yeah, this is the right place. This is the guy who was pimping her out."

Another man stepped forward. I didn't need to be introduced. He was an older version of Vinny, filled out, graying hair. Obviously the father. He turned to the bodyguard. "Thanks Rock."

He strode up to me. "Where's the whore?"

Kris caught up with us. "What the heck is going on?" she demanded. "What the heck are you talking about?"

Vinny's father looked her up and down. She was wearing clingy sweats and a ribbed tee, all of which showed off her curves. "You whoring this one out too? 'Cause I wouldn't mind knocking off a piece."

"Leave my wife alone," I grunted.

The third man strode forward and barreled into me. He wasn't much bigger than me, but he felt like he was made of steel. I stumbled backward, and felt him grab my throat, cutting off my breath with practiced ease.

"Let him go," Kris shrieked.

"Relax, Jerry," said Vinny's dad, casually. "We need him able to speak."

He released me and I gasped.

Kris stepped into the middle of us. "Okay, he's Rock," she pointed at the first bodyguard. "He's Jerry," she pointed at the guy who'd choked me. Then she wheeled on Vinny's dad. "Who the fuck are you?"

Kris never cursed. But she was pissed.

He looked her over. "I'm Sal." He fixated on her face. "You're her sister, aren't you?"

"What are you talking about?" she demanded.

"Fucking Star – Jessi -- whatever the fuck she's calling herself, she stole some, um, merchandise from me. And I fucking want it back."

Kris shook her head. "Look, I don't know what you're talking about. My sister..." She paused. "Look, I don't know what's going on. She does some crazy stuff. But she isn't here now. And we haven't seen her. We don't know what's going on."

Sal nodded in my direction. "He does."

Kris looked at me, a questioning look on her face.

I put out my arms helplessly. "I don't."

"Don't lie, pimp," Sal replied.

Kris looked around angrily. "Why do you keep calling him a pimp?"

Sal looked over at Rock, who looked over at me. I was pleading with my eyes, even shaking my head slightly. He broke into a malevolent grin and then told the whole story.

When he concluded, Sal summed it up. "He prices the gash. He collects the cash. He's the pimp."

Kris gave me a searching look.

"I can explain," I said lamely.

Her mouth fell open in shock, and then her eyes flashed with anger.

Still, her first instinct was to round on Sal. "What does that have to do with stealing?"

"She stole some stuff Sunday night."

"Daniel," she said with a sneer, "was with me Sunday."

"Yeah, and Star was with me, polishing my knob and sitting on my dick. Then, after, she waved around a bunch of cash saying she wanted to buy some coke. But when we went to my cache, the fucking bitch zapped me. When I come to, the whore's gone, my coke's gone."

"What do you want with us? You want her," I said.

Sal smirked. "Yeah, but I don't know where she is. That's where you come in, pimp. She's your girl. You find her or pay for the coke."

"We don't know where my sister is," Kris replied. "She's not answering my calls, my texts."

"See, folks, now that's your problem, not mine."

Kris sighed. "How much did she steal?" I could see her thinking that maybe the best thing was just to pay off the debt.

"Ten keys. Two fifty."

"Two hundred and fifty dollars?" Kris asked, in a tone of relief.

He laughed. "Damn, you're even dumber than your cunt of a sister. Two hundred and fifty grand."

"We don't have that kind of money," I replied. Even as he'd said it, I'd run it through in my head. If we liquidated everything, literally everything, and even sold the house we'd be short, well short.

"Then you better find your whore."

Kris sighed. "Okay, whatever. Give us a couple of days. We'll do our best."

"You damn well will, and to make sure you do, we're going to give you a little incentive. Take a little collateral." He said nodding towards the stroller in the corner.

Kris went red with rage. "Stay away from our kids."

"Unless you got a Glock hidden in those titties..."

"It'd fit," Jerry deadpanned with a leer.

Sal continued, "... you have no choice." He ostentatiously and unnecessarily pulled a gun from a shoulder holster. There was no way we could handle Jerry and Rock even if they were all unarmed.

"No," she howled. "Leave them alone."

"Don't worry doll. We'll just keep 'em a couple of days. I got a nice extra room. Throw them a few slices of pizza and a juice box, and they'll be fine. Plus, with the free child care you'll have extra time to find the whore."

He nodded at Rock who took a couple of steps towards the stairs. It was suicide, but I was going to have to try to stop him physically. I glanced around the room, looking for a weapon. My eyes alit on the fireplace poker. I'd have to dash past Jerry, grab it...

"Take me instead," Kris said suddenly. "No crying, no diapers. I'll be more fun," she said with hand on her hip.

Rock stopped and turned back toward us. Sal shot me an amused look and then rounded on my wife.

"Well, well, well. A slut like your sister, eh?"

She shrugged.

He approached her. "It's a tempting offer, but I think I need to know how much more fun."

"Just leave my kids alone."

"Give me a demonstration then."

"Come on," she whined. "You don't need that."

He sighed loudly and nodded toward Rock, who took another step towards the stairs.

"Okay, okay," she relented.

"Noooo," I cried out.

She stared at me angrily, challenging me to come up with an alternative. After a moment I looked away.

"Okay, come with me into the study," she said to Sal.

"Naw, baby, right here. It'll do hubby good to have an graphic mental image. It'll keep him motivated."

He holstered the weapon and, placing a beefy paw on her shoulder, pushed her to the knees.

"Show me fun," he ordered.

She nodded and then imperturbably reached out and lowered his zipper. She reached into his trousers and pulled out his cock. Jessi had told me he was bigger than Vinny, but that did nothing to prepare me for what appeared. He was huge and uncircumcised. Even partially flaccid, he was still impressively long and shockingly thick.

A moment passed between them, their eyes meeting. His expression was clear, a cocky grin. Hers was more enigmatic. Was it apprehension? Admiration?

A memory flashed through my brain. Even though we'd waiting until nineteen to have sex, we'd experimented with oral toward the very end of high school. I remember the moment like it was yesterday. I'd been so happy, so full of anticipation. And it had been awful. Awkward, toothy, even painful. It had gotten better over the years, much, much better, but the recollection of that first, miserable, blowjob from Kris had always, until today, brought an ironic smile to my lips.

And now for some reason I fixated on his cock. That fat, ugly lump. There was no way, of course, that Kris would be able to take it her mouth. For a weird moment, the absurdity of it struck me as almost funny.

But then with the same detached precision with which she'd unzipped his pants and fished out his cock, she now leaned forward, seized his shaft firmly with both hands and took the head of his prick into her mouth.

"Looks like sucking cock runs in the family," Sal said with a chuckle.

Kris didn't react, didn't pause from her unemotional, almost mechanical assault on his member. But despite the lack of passion and showmanship, she was still, from his reaction, doing an effective job with it. As her spit coated his length, she took him deeper still. Her hands twisted firmly on his shaft. On each outstroke, I could see her tongue do a quick swirl over his cockhead.

My head was pounding. I wanted to scream. Just to howl in anger and frustration. But Kris' attitude paralyzed me. There was something about her temperament as she knelt before Sal, fellating him, that seemed to brook no objections. I realized how passive I'd become, how much I let her set the agenda, that now, faced with an unthinkable situation, I was still looking to her to determine how we should respond.

No one spoke. No one moved. The only sounds in the room were those of her slurping wetly on his cock, breathing loudly through her nose, and his increasingly contented moans. He placed his hand on the back of her head and began to thrust gently in time with her own bobbing up and down.

He gave her hair a quick tug. She paused and looked up at him, his cock still deep in her mouth.

"Do you like to swallow?"

She gave a quick headshake. She had done it for me exactly once. She had hated it. And she had never done it again.

"But you will this time?"

She paused a second and then gave a quick nod.

"Good girl," he said with a smile.

She went back to work with the same detached but effective style. He closed his eyes, sighed. He was now fully erect, and she was swallowing at most half of him, but that was enough. With a low groan, he tensed up

and came in her mouth. She gulped it down, snorting air through her nose as she tried to manage breathing while also swallowing his load.

He continued to pump his gradually softening member past her lips for another minute or so until he'd given her every drop. And then slowly, he withdrew his cock. Even more of it had been in her mouth than I'd suspected.

He grabbed her under the armpit and lifted her to her feet. "Okay, fun stuff, you convinced me. Let's go."

He shoved her towards Rock who caught her and started toward the door. "And you, numb nuts," he said looking at me, "get me my coke or my money, otherwise we're gonna do shit to wifey-wife that makes this seem like paddy cakes."

It struck me that he was almost a caricature of a gangster. But I didn't have time to consider it further. All I knew was that he'd assaulted and then taken my wife.

The moment the door closed, I picked up the phone to call the police. I pressed 9-1-1, but didn't hit dial as I tried to imagine what I would say. What words would follow, *help, my wife has been kidnapped?*

First, there was the fact that I wasn't sure I could even describe it as a kidnapping. Kris has gone without a fight. She'd offered herself to him in the first place, and then gone without any objection.

Furthermore, the story was outlandish, full of details that would raise questions and secondary investigations. They would sure see this as some sort of drug deal gone wrong, and my recent connection to Jessi's "work" would cause more suspicions. At the very least, I'd be *incommunicado* for an indeterminate amount of time. And what would happen then? Would Sal assume I had skipped town? Would he hear about the investigation? What would happen to Kris?

All of that was speculation, but the one thing I knew it was that I needed to find Jessi, and fast. Assuming that what Sal had said was true, and I had to assume it was, she could end this whole situation in a heartbeat and surely would once she realized what was going on. Jessi was stupid and reckless, but not evil. The problem was how to find her.

I went around with that in my mind several times, and then I realized I also needed to keep track of Kris. I ran outside. Fuck, they'd already driven away. I should have gotten the license plate at the very least, but now I realized I didn't even have a way to contact Sal if I did recover the coke. Then, of course, I realized Jessi would know how to reach him. Again, she was the key.

I immediately dialed her number. It went right to voicemail.

"Jesus, Jessi call me right away. Kris is in danger. That guy Sal came to our house tonight and took her. Please, please call me right away so we can fix this."

I stared at the phone like a maniac willing a call back. None came. I sent a text. Then another.

And then it hit me like a shot. The kids. I had to get them out of the house. What if Kris escaped? What if Sal decided he wanted more leverage?

I called my mom. She and my dad had divorced when I was young and she had taken and kept her new husband's name when she remarried. That should be enough to keep them safe for now.

I called her and told her that I needed to drop off the kids. That Kris and I had some use-it-or-lose-it leave and that we'd decided to take a spontaneous vacation, just the two of us.

"It's late," she replied.

"I know. We just decided. Got an amazing deal on airfare. We're flying out tomorrow morning at 6:00am."

"Where are you going?"

"Vegas," I replied, picking a vacation destination out of thin air.

"Since when does Kris gamble?"

"We're just going to see shows. I know it's last minute, but I'd like to come over now."

She sighed skeptically. "Okay."

The kids sleep through anything. They barely stirred when I got them out of bed and strapped them in the car. And I don't think they moved at all on the other end when I took them into my mom's home.

She helped me tuck them in, but stopped me as I was trying to get out the door.

"What the heck is going on Daniel?"

"I told you."

She laughed darkly. "I've known Kris as long as you have. You know as well as I do that she would never do something this ill-planned."

I sighed. "Okay," I said in a tone of regretfully coming clean. "We had a fight. We just need some time to patch things up, without the kids around."

She shook her head. "Oh Daniel, what is wrong with you men?"

"Huh?"

"Is it really that hard to keep it in your pants? Look at what you've done now."

"Jesus, mom, it's not that."

"What is it then?"

"It's hard to explain."

She gave me a sad, disbelieving look. I didn't care. Her disapproval was the least of my problems.

"This isn't like you and Dad," I replied, unable to contain myself.

I left.

No, this wasn't like my dad having an affair with his secretary. This was much, much worse.

CHAPTER FIVE

I got back to the house. I called Jessi again. Texted again. Left long voicemails. Begged her to return my call. Nothing.

I went back down to her room and tossed it, looking for something, anything. Under every pile of clothes I hoped, prayed, I would find a stash of coke, something. I went through all her crap. I didn't find anything other than a bunch of dirty clothes, a small baggie of pot, some credit card and cell phone bills, a letter from DMV, and a handful of "house rules" from strip clubs down in Iron City, an old industrial part of town that was now home to a bunch of nightclubs. I took all that with me, minus the dirty clothes.

By the time I was done going through her stuff in detail, it was almost 4:00 am. I went back upstairs and started going through our finances. We had \$7,500 in our checking account. Another \$10,000 in a savings account, and \$10,000 more in a brokerage account. We both had 401(k)s totaling \$30,000 between the two of us. We had \$40,000 equity in the house. Both our cars were old, bought used, and worth maybe \$10,000 between them. No way I could come up with \$250,000, not without asking for a lot of help from other people, broadening the circle of knowledge until someone, surely, decided to bring in the authorities. I couldn't risk that, not while Sal had Kris.

All the while, I kept calling Jessi. Probably twenty, thirty times. I wasn't even leaving a message anymore. Just waiting for her voicemail to pick up before hanging up.

I'd need some time off. So I called my work, Kris' as well, and told them we were both taking time off to deal with a family medical emergency. By law they had to grant that request which gave us a little breathing room.

A little after 9:00 am, I took a shower, changed and downed some coffee. I went to the bank, and withdrew the money from our accounts, just leaving the minimum in there to keep them open. I guess bank employees are trained to be on the lookout for this sort of thing. They must have asked a million questions. Even though I was authorized to make the withdrawals,

the fact that Kris' name was on the accounts as well led them to delay, asking me to get her to co-sign the withdrawals. It took me over an hour to fight my way through the paperwork to get my own money.

It was even worse at Fidelity. We were invested in some "life-cycle" fund, which they claimed could only be liquidated at market close. I grumbled about a family emergency, and they assured me I could receive a check or bank transfer tomorrow, which would mean I wouldn't be able to actually get the money until Thursday.

All of this took me the better part of the morning to square away, and at the end of it I had only \$16,500 to show. I wanted to call Sal, offer him the money as a show of good faith, and plead for him to release Kris. But I had no way to reach him. I had to wait for him to contact me. I stewed in my own impotence. I started to drive home.

I called Jessi again. Barely listening as I waited for her, by now, infuriatingly dismissive message: "Sorry baby, I'm not avail. Beep."

"Jesus, Danny Dan, what the fuck is up with you? I need this phone for work. Can't have you calling non-stop."

"Jessi, is that you?" I exclaimed in shock, nearly running off the road.

"Fuck man, you called me."

I pulled over, cutting off a truck that honked at me furiously as he passed.

"Jessi, I've been trying to reach you all night."

"Yeah, 36 missed calls."

"Have you listened to your messages?"

"No. I was busy."

"Jesus, Jessi! They took Kris. Sal came to our house. Said you stole from him. And he took Kris until you pay it back."

"I didn't steal anything. I just, um, borrowed some merch. I need a couple of days and I'll pay it back with interest. Just relax."

"Fuck Jessi, you don't get it. He... he..." I couldn't get the words out. I hoped my tone would convey it. "He assaulted her and took her with him."

I thought that would get Jessi's attention. And it did, but not in the way I expected. She didn't gasp. She didn't apologize. She just laughed. Loud, long, hysterical laughter.

"What's so fucking funny?" I screamed into the phone.

She could barely contain her giggles. "Come on, you gotta admit thinking about Kris the Priss getting slugged out is funny."

I shook my head. "I don't think you understand..."

The mirth disappeared completely from her voice, "Oh I do. I understand better than you can imagine. Don't worry, Danny Dan, I can tell you from experience that a few cocks never hurt anyone."

"Please, Jessi, don't do this."

"I'm not doing anything, except a little business. Just a couple of days. But I need this phone, and I can't have you tying it up all the time. So, sorry Danny Dan, but I'm gonna block you."

"Jessi, no, just listen..."

"Bye," she said as she hung up.

I redialed her number immediately. It went right to her voicemail, but I knew that even if I left a message, it would never get to her.

I slammed the steering wheel in fury, until my palms ached, calling Jessi every name in the book. All I could think of was strangling her.

On the way home I bought a handgun. Two forms of ID. An instant background check and I was armed. Homicidal, desperate, and packing heat. I didn't know what I would use it for, but for the first time in my life, I felt that I was probably better off with a weapon.

I considered buying one of those prepaid phones and calling Jessi again, but I realized she would just block me again immediately. I could have bought a hundred and forced her to block all of them, but that would just annoy her, and as much as I wanted to murder Jessi at the moment, I needed her in a cooperative mood.

Back at the house I paced around frantically, trying to think of a plan of action. But I was trapped. I couldn't call the cops, now less than ever, since explaining the twenty-hour delay would make me seem even more suspicious. We were now at the point where they would not even consider looking for her until I'd been fully investigated and cleared, and that could take months.

I needed to find Jessi, but had no good idea how to do that. I'd been thinking it was just a matter of getting through to her, but obviously, I actually needed to physically get a hold of her. Unfortunately, I didn't have

the first clue on where she might be other than that she was somewhere conducting business. For all I knew, she had driven Sal's coke down to Vegas or someplace to make a sale.

All I could do was wait with my handgun and \$16,500 in cash and hope that a solution presented itself.

But waiting was virtually intolerable, because every instant that wasn't fully occupied, my mind turned to Kris, and a cycle of torments began.

I imagined what they were doing to her. The sin of my evening with Jessi was again coming home to roost, this time by forcing me to imagine Kris in her sister's place, submitting to the same debauched acts. I shook my head, trying to get the image out.

But the moment I cleared my mind of those images, I was forced to confront how badly I'd let Kris down. She was my first, my only love. Being without her seemed unimaginable, and yet, she surely hated me. Hated me for enabling her sister's drug use and prostitution. Hated me for not defending her, for letting her be taken away by brutish men who were even now...

I shook my head again. No, I couldn't go down that path. But I couldn't stop myself. I could see her, dropping to her knees, performing oral sex on Sal, sucking on his fat prick, swallowing his disgusting load. She'd been protecting the kids. But was she also punishing me? Was part of this her way of telling me that I no longer mattered, that I was out of her heart, her life, forever?

I groaned in frustration. No, now, I was just being selfish, making this about me, turning her torment into my own. That wasn't fair. Wasn't honest. I'd fucked up, and she was paying the price, and realization of it made me look at the handgun in a new light. I shook my head. No, I wouldn't do that. I wouldn't take the coward's way out.

And so it went, every avenue ending up in the same place, the same dark hole of guilt, self-loathing, of feeling trapped and desperate.

My anguish was punctuated by the doorbell ringing a little after 8:00 pm. I hid the gun beneath an old newspaper and answered the door. It was Jerry, and he was alone.

I could probably surprise him and kill him. But then what?

"You gonna let me in, or what?"

"Yeah," I grunted. "Where's Kris?"

"Don't worry, she's in a good hands," he replied with a leer that seemed to confirm my worst fears.

"If you fuckers hurt her..."

"Yeah, yeah," he cut me off dismissively. "You'll kill us all. Okay, tough guy, enough chatter. You got Sal's stash?"

"No --"

"Okay, see ya then," he said, cutting me off. "I'll give your regards to wifey."

"No! Wait. Please. Look, I have some money. You know, to show I'm working on it." I grabbed the cash out of a drawer and waved it at him.

"How much is that?"

"Sixteen-five."

He took it out of my hand and shook it contemptuously. "Sal is not going to be pleased."

"Tell him it's all I could get that fast. I'm working on more."

"Tell him yourself," he said as he pulled out and dialed his phone.

He held the phone to his ear. "Hey, Sal, so I'm here with dumbass. He's got a partial payment here. Sixteen-five."

He listened for a moment then handed me the phone.

"Hello," I said cautiously.

"Well, numb nuts, looks like we have a problem. I told you I need either my coke back or two-fifty, and you come back with sixteen. You think I'm fucking around?"

"It's the best I could do so fast. Please, just take the money and let Kris go. We'll make up the rest somehow. Please."

He laughed at that. "No, I don't think so. I think you'll just have to try harder. Anyway, I... I mean, *we* are having fun with Krissy, just like she promised. We've made a little game of it. It's pretty easy to round up guys who've gotten head from Star, so we're having a little competition to see which sister sucks the meanest cock. It's two-two so far, which means your wife is holding her own with a seasoned pro, but we've got another few guys to break the tie."

"Sal, please, I'm begging you. You've punished her and me enough. Just take the money, and even if you don't let her go right away, at least just

leave her alone."

"No can do, buddy boy, but I will give you a token of my good will. I've been getting all worked up thinking about fucking her sweet little pussy. But I'll hold off on that for another twenty-four hours."

"I can't get the money that fast. Please, Sal, please."

"Well, then I guess this time tomorrow night, I'll be balls deep in her hot little box."

"No, please..."

But he'd hung up. Dejected, I passed the phone back to Jerry, who silently pocketed it. He gave me a shrug as if to say "Nothing personal." And then with my money in his pocket, he turned and left.

This time, though, I was quick-witted enough to follow him outside and write down his plate number as he drove off. I wasn't sure what good it would do me, but I was going to try to gather every bit of information I could.

After Jerry left, I drank. I drank because I couldn't think of what else to do. I drank because I was too tired to do anything else. I drank because I couldn't bear to be alone with the thoughts swirling around my head sober. I drank to escape. And it worked... at least for a few hours.

CHAPTER SIX

I woke up the following morning early, hung-over, not refreshed, but at least a little rested and determined to find Jessi. The sunlight helped clear away the gloom of my thoughts. And the sleep, imperfect as it had been, seemed to have jumpstarted my mind.

I didn't have much to go on, but I laid out all the stuff I'd taken from Jessi's room. After a while, I noticed something. All of her old bills and correspondences had different addresses on them. She'd been living a peripatetic life for years and just seemed to use whatever current address she had at the time. She'd probably never bothered to go back and change them. But what struck me was the letter from DMV. It was actually addressed to our home, but she'd only been back with us a few weeks.

And then I remembered, back when she was sixteen and had gotten her driver's license, she'd lived briefly with us. Those addresses were not just necessarily from the past, but might be part of a circuit of places she moved to from time to time as circumstances dictated. Just as her boyfriend getting busted had brought her to us, her need to go to ground after stealing from Sal might send her back to one of her other crash pads.

I had three other addresses. And even if she wasn't at any of them, those were also likely people within her circle, people who might have some idea of where she might currently be.

I took a quick shower, changed. Then packing the papers and the gun in a backpack, I drove into town toward the first address on my list.

I was tempted to just charge up to the front door of each place and demand to know where Jessi was. Indeed, it took all my willpower to prevent myself from doing that. But after a day and a half of that sort of frantic, and ultimately fruitless, effort, I decided to be more considered and careful as I proceeded.

The first address on my list turned out to be a large, shambling, rundown, clapboard house near Collegetown. I groaned inwardly. It seemed

that it had been subdivided into apartments, probably inhabited by transient college kids with no knowledge of previous tenants. I also realized it would probably be hard to talk to all, or even most, of the renters.

I staked out the place for a while. It was still reasonably early. I got there just before 8:30 am with a cup of coffee and a doughnut. I parked across the street and down half a block and just watched, trying to get a feel for the place.

Every time the front door opened, I was hoping against hope that it would be Jessi, and that I'd have her, just like that. No such luck, though I took pictures of all the residents with my phone as they exited.

They were all kids, some obviously college students, several even wearing university sweatshirts, while others just looked like young folks heading out to work. I'd been right about the numbers. At least a dozen people lived there.

Finally, I decided I'd have no choice but to ask some questions. I waited until I saw a young couple leaving together. I reasoned that was going to be my best bet for a cooperative response: a woman for empathy, but with her boyfriend there to make her feel safe enough to speak to a stranger.

The problem was what to say. I'm not grizzled, but I was a little haggard and anyway, I look my age—which meant I was asking questions about a woman nearly ten years younger than me. It was hard to imagine how to avoid a stalker vibe.

"Hey, guys, I'm sorry to bother you, but does Jessi Taylor still live here?"

As expected the guy shook his head and tried to keep walking. His girlfriend slowed, although she didn't answer right away.

"She's a cousin," I continued. "My folks asked me to look her up next time I was in town, but I wasn't sure I had the right address."

The woman stopped. "No, I don't know her. But I'm not sure I know everyone who lives here, you know."

"She's tall, dark hair. Last time I saw her, she had like a violet streak in it," I said with an eye roll designed to suggest my interest in her was purely platonic.

The woman laughed. "That could describe half the girls at school. Is she a student? You could check with the registrar or something."

"Yeah, maybe I'll try that. You sure you don't know her? She was always a bit of a partier, you know. Anyone like that in the house?"

I saw her eyes narrow. I'd tripped her creep meter. I needed to back out gracefully.

"Never mind. Thanks for your help," I said amiably. I turned and walked away.

I sat back down in my car, keeping an eye on the building. After a while, there was less foot traffic so I decided to drive around the block looking for Jessi's car.

It occurred to me that I should have done that sooner. If she had spotted me, she might have already escaped out the back and driven away right under my nose. I didn't see anything useful and after thirty minutes, I was back in front of the group house. By then there were some people coming back, probably after a morning class.

I tried the "cousin" bit with another young woman, but she was alone and brushed me off pretty quickly. And then I tried with a dude, who apparently pegged me as a stalker and messed with me for a few minutes before blowing me off.

After I retreated to the car the third time, I noticed a campus police car slow-rolling down the block. Maybe I was just being paranoid, but I decided to take off and try one of the other addresses for a while. I'd been at this one for half the day and hadn't gotten so much as a hint of Jessi.

The second address was for a small garden apartment in a dicier part of town. I had the apartment number this time, but since it wasn't visible from the street, I had to scope it out on foot. I put the gun in my waistband as a precaution, hidden under my shirt.

It was the middle of the day, but I still didn't feel safe. I couldn't imagine how a pretty young girl like Jessi could have lived here, especially when she happened to be out and coming home at night. But then again, Jessi was tougher than I had ever realized.

The problem was that I'd always seen Jessi as just a more troubled, less ambitious, version of Kris. They were sisters, after all. As a result, I had always assumed that at some point she'd grow up, come around. But I could tell now that was wrong. I reminded myself not to underestimate her again.

The courtyard was overgrown. It hadn't been a "garden" in many years. Even though it was midday, it was oddly deserted; only the sounds of TVs blaring from inside various apartments made the place seem at all inhabited.

Her apartment had been 2C. I climbed up a set of cement stairs with rusting handrails and walked down the row of apartments, trying as casually as possible to peer inside those with open windows. 2C was shut up tight, curtains drawn up against the windows, no sound from within. In a weird way, that struck me as promising. It felt like the kind of place where an on-the-run stripper trying to broker a drug deal might hide.

I continued down the row to the stairs at the other end and went back to the ground level. I followed the perimeter of the building until I came to an alley. I walked down the alley, counting windows until I got to 2C. I looked up. The window looked rusted shut, and anyway it was a good twenty-foot drop to the street. If I knocked on the door, there would be no way for her to escape out the back.

I continued down the alley, planning to circle the building completely, both to get a lay of the land and try to spot her car.

"Hey man," a guy called out from behind me.

I looked back to see a slender, middle aged, black man in dirty fatigues, limping toward me. He had one hand held out in front of him, the other behind his back. It felt like a replay of the night after the theater.

"You dropped something, you dropped something," he called out.

I felt the hair on the back of my neck stand on end. I scanned the area in front of me before I turned to face me.

"I didn't drop anything. Leave me alone."

"Naw, man, you dropped it, you dropped it. I saw it."

He was approaching closer and closer. Shit, I thought to myself. I reached under my shirt and pulled out the gun, holding it by my leg, which was shaking nervously. A few more steps and I would raise it, but I didn't need to. He'd recognized it right away and frozen.

His expression changed from fake concern to cold calculation.

"Whatchu carrying on you that you need a piece?"

"Just myself, buddy. Now leave me alone."

I could see him reading me. He was a creature of the street. He could tell I didn't belong, could tell handling a weapon was a new thing,

could tell I was scared, close to panic. He was calculating whether it was worth the risk to rush me. I held his gaze, and I guess he saw enough desperation in my eyes that he decided to back away.

"Alright man, alright, you just put that thing away before you get yo'self hurt."

"Thanks. Now run along," I said with as much bravado as I could muster.

He turned and left, disappearing into another alley as quickly as he'd appeared.

I knew I was running out of time. I'd been marked, and it was only a matter of time until some other scavenger, maybe one better armed or more reckless, came around to give me a hard time.

I went back up to 2C and knocked loudly, each knock seeming to echo through the passageway. I could hear residents stirring behind closed doors. But 2C remained resolutely still. I knocked again and heard a curse from inside. It didn't sound like Jessi, but who knew what she'd been up to these last twenty-four hours. I knocked one more time, assessing the door, wondering if I could force my way in.

Just then a face appeared at the window, sneaking a glimpse at me through the heavy curtains. It was an older black woman.

"What you want?" she called through the glass.

"I just want to talk."

"Go away," she hissed.

I knocked on the door again.

Finally she cracked it open, keeping the security chain in place.

"I got mace," she threatened.

"Okay, okay, relax. Just want to ask about the previous tenant."

"What do you care?"

"She's my cousin," I said, recycling that story.

She laughed. "Your cousin is a 'ho."

I couldn't contain a grin. "She might be. Has she been around recently?"

"If she was, I'd be kicking her behind. Johns banging on my door at all hours, looking for Staaarh. Six months after she moved out they still coming around. And then come winter, the whole bedroom starts stinking. I find she's got a stash of used rubbers piled behind the heater. You tell her to come back around, 'cause Miss Marie got an ass-whooping for her."

"Okay, if I find her, I'll let her know."

"You're a nice boy. She's not really your cousin, is she?"

"Nope," I said as I turned away. My sister-in-law, I thought to myself. I wasn't sure if that was better or worse.

The final address was the most interesting, an expensive high rise in Crystal Heights. It was quite a step up from 2C. I had an apartment number, 1405, but one look at the entrance let me know I wasn't going to be getting upstairs without a keycard or something.

I parked and walked to a nearby Starbucks, pondering the situation. The obvious solution was to try to follow someone in, but the risk of getting caught was too high. Unlike the group house or 2C, no one here would hesitate to call the cops if they got suspicious.

I was hungry, so I went back up to the counter and picked up a carrot cake, and when I did, I noticed a magazine rack with those free, "apartment for rent," brochures. I didn't quite know what I was looking for as I looked up Jessi's high rise. But then I saw it and everything fell together. "For rent, by owner."

I called the number and introduced myself as a potential renter just in the area for a few more hours. Would they be willing to show me the place? *Yes, of course*, they were leaving work shortly anyway. I glanced at my watch. It was a little after 5:00 pm. We agreed to meet at six at the entrance.

I went the drug store down the street and picked up a razor and shaving cream, some deodorant, and Visine, then went back to Starbucks where I shaved and freshened up in the bathroom. After washing off and drying my face, I looked in the mirror. I looked almost presentable. Or at least, as presentable as possible for a man with five hours of drunken sleep in the last two days.

I left the gun in the car and went to the building. The owner was a slender, older woman, probably in her early 60s with a bob of perfectly coiffed silver hair. She introduced herself as Leslie. I could tell she was nervous about inviting a strange man into her home, and I did my best to put her at ease with a big smile and a gentle handshake.

"My husband will be home any minute," she offered.

"Great," I replied brightly. "He can give me a man's perspective when he arrives."

My eagerness to meet him seemed to put her at ease.

She keyed us through the doorway and upstairs, chattering on about the amenities, the location, and the great restaurant choices nearby. I did my best to keep up my end of what felt like insipid chitchat. I was relieved to see that the elevators only needed a key fob to call them in the lobby. If I could find a way to ditch her, I'd be free to roam the building.

She showed me the apartment. It was actually lovely, although the asking rent was twice our mortgage for a one-bedroom with a den. I did my best to feign interest and ability to pay, nodded cheerfully when she mentioned needing to put down three month's rents up front.

"So, what do you think?"

"Oh, it's great," I enthused. "Perfect. I just need to talk to my wife about it."

She smiled. "Oh wonderful. I am sure you two will love it here until you decide to have kids."

I laughed. "Not any time soon, we're having too much fun."

She liked that. A happy couple in her apartment.

"Don't wait too long," she replied.

I laughed. "Oh, don't worry. I'm sure Kris already has it all planned out."

"Okay, well, if that's all, I'll show you out."

"Oh, you don't need to," I offered.

"It's not a problem."

It is for me. I forced myself to keep a neutral smile on my face. She led me toward the door. I was running out of time. And then I saw it, a flower vase on the sideboard by the door. I turned toward her, asked about window cleaning, and marched right into the sideboard. The vase shattered on the floor with a satisfying crash.

"Oh my, I'm so sorry."

She gave me a stricken look as she contemplated the mess of broken glass, water, and flowers on the floor.

"It's okay dear. It'll clean right up."

I looked at my watch. "I'm running late. I'm so sorry. Can I offer to replace the vase?"

She shook her head. "No, it's nothing."

"I'll show myself out. Again, please accept my apologies."

She nodded and I slipped out the door. I hurried to the elevator.

She'd clearly been reluctant to let me show myself out, and I could imagine her hurrying out of her apartment to make sure I actually left. It felt like an eternity. The elevator seemed to stop at every floor before reaching me.

From down the hall, I heard a door open, and heard her voice.

"Hold on, dear, I'll show you out."

The elevator door dinged open. I stepped in quickly, hit the 14 button and then pounded on the close door button over and over even though I knew it did nothing.

"Hold on, hold on, I have to show you ou..." her words mercifully cut off by the closing of the elevator door.

I knew I only had a few minutes. When the elevator opened at 14, I ducked out quickly and turn toward 1405. It was the third apartment on the left, and after two steps I saw it. The door sealed with a border of yellow crime scene tape. I sighed.

It all made sense. This was where Jessi had lived right before coming to us. Where her boyfriend had been busted for dealing. The case was so recent that the apartment was still sealed.

I sighed. It all made sense. But it also meant that I still didn't have a solid lead on Jessi.

CHAPTER SEVEN

I stopped for a drink in a bar. It was almost eight, and the last of the happy hour crowd was drifting away, setting up a quiet mid-week evening shift for the remaining staff. I took a booth in the back, out of the way. I ordered an expensive scotch and nursed it. After last night, I didn't have much of an appetite for booze, and anyway I wanted to stay as sharp as possible.

I had learned a lot about Jessi, or Star, whatever. Kris had been so scandalized that her sister was a stripper, but even that had been a huge smokescreen. Stripper conjured the notion of a bad girl, certainly, but also conveyed the image of a young woman flashing her boobs for tips. That wasn't Jessi.

She'd been a full-out whore, at least some of the time, and not always making \$7k a night in a suite at the Four Seasons. Somehow she'd made the hard leap from 2C to 1405, and she didn't like the idea of giving that up. The lure of easy money by stealing Sal's coke was just too much for her given what she'd gone through. I hated myself for feeling any empathy for her. She'd caused us nothing but suffering, but the thought of her in that nasty garden apartment, turning tricks and spitefully stashing used condoms behind the radiator reminded me that she'd suffered too.

I finished the scotch and ordered a second. Understanding Jessi was one thing. Finding her was another. And now I'd wasted yet another day and was still no closer to my goal of freeing Kris.

My phone sounded. Not the normal ringtone for a call, but rather the chime for a Facetime request. I felt a surge of excitement. Only Kris ever called me on Facetime. Had they let her go? Had she escaped? I eagerly accept the call.

I immediately deflated when I saw Sal's face leering at me.

"Hey, numb nuts, so you got something for me?"

The "numb nuts" bit was really getting on my nerves. Bullshit tough guy act. Easy to do with hired muscle and a gun.

"I'm sick of this shit. Just let her go," I replied with what I hoped was the sort of world-weariness that would convince him not to mess with

me. It was all I had left.

He just chuckled. "I have good news for you."

I didn't bite, didn't give him the satisfaction of asking what.

I could tell that annoyed him, but that was just a small, meaningless victory. He held all the cards.

He plowed ahead. "Krissy won the BJ contest. Four to three, though it was a tough call. A couple of us needed more than one demonstration to be sure. Your wife is very accommodating."

"That's what turns you on, you sick fuck? Forcing yourself on an innocent woman?"

He laughed darkly. "Sounds like you need a little more motivation. So I'm gonna mute you now and just let you watch."

He flipped the phone around, and after a moment, the camera refocused on Kris, sitting on the edge of a king size bed, completely nude.

"She's lovely, isn't she?" he narrated. "Those beautiful, big titties. If it were up to me, I'd keep her naked all the time. And since it is up to me, that's what I've been doing."

I was tempted to just hang up, to deny the pleasure of humiliating me. But I couldn't do it. I wanted to see Kris for as long as I could, even if it would ultimately tear me apart. In a small way, by bearing witness, I was sharing in her ordeal. At the very least, she'd know I hadn't abandoned her, would never abandon her.

He approached her slowly.

"Wave for the camera baby. Show hubby that you're pleased to see him."

She looked at the phone and our eyes seemed to meet. She gave me a sad, thin, smile, and a small wave. She looked about as well as could be expected. She'd obviously been fed, given a chance to sleep, shower.

He stepped up close, the camera trained down on her. He filmed himself as he casually flicked the hair out of her eyes, brushed her cheek, and then reached down to cup her full breast in his palm. He zoomed in on his thumb, sliding back and forth across her nipple, which stiffened at his touch. He then did the same to her other breast.

"Lie back baby," he said. She hesitated for just a second. "Do it," he ordered, more firmly now.

She obeyed. She'd obviously made the decision to comply with his demands, to be accommodating rather than fight back.

"She's got a beautiful pussy," he commented. "Especially now that we got rid of that 70s muff."

The camera drifted down between her legs, centering now on her *mons pubis*, that I was seeing bare for the first time, her vulva a gracefully arched mound, with a narrow valley within.

"I shaved her myself," he added proudly.

He focused in closer now, so that my entire screen was now filled with her sex, essentially life size, transmitted to me in high definition thanks to the wonders of modern technology. It was, perhaps not so shockingly, the clearest look I'd ever had at my wife's pussy. And he was right. It was beautiful.

I jolted backward in surprise as his thumb suddenly entered the frame. The resolution was good enough that I could see it coated with his spit. He gently rubbed her slit up and down, up and down, up and down, slowly opening her up. He pressed his thumb inside her and she moaned despite herself.

He chuckled softly. Then he slowly churned his digit inside her, in and out. He slid his thumb back up her slit and then gently rubbed her clit in small circles. Again, a soft moan escaped her lips.

He zoomed back out and ran the camera over her naked body. First he filmed down one shapely leg, and then back up the other. He paused again at her pussy, the camera focusing back in as he turned his palm upward and thrust two fingers deep into her snatch, twisting them back and forth, the microphone picking up a soft squishing sound.

He withdrew his fingers and used them to trace over her flat belly, through the valley between her breasts, across the throat. He pressed them deep into her mouth. She closed her lips on his digits and he pumped them slowly inside her.

Again the camera followed his hand as he returned to her pussy. This time, he thrust his two fingers inside her roughly. She gasped softly as he pumped them into her over and over.

He stood back up, the image bouncing around now, catching a glimpse of her naked body, of the headboard above the bed, of the bureau beside the bed. Then the image steadied and he again focused on her pussy, the lips now spread enough to expose the moist pink within.

His cock entered the frame, fat and ugly, looking like the anteater's snout. He pressed his fat tool against her snatch, rubbing it up and down

between her labia.

"She says you're the only guy who's ever fucked her. You're gonna get to watch her take her first new dick," he taunted.

He seemed to enjoy teasing her, tormenting me, taking his time, running just the tip of his cock up and down her slit.

"Ask for it, baby," he grumbled seductively.

Her answer was prompt, unambiguous. "Never."

"You know you want it."

"No," she hissed.

"Your cunt wants it."

Her anatomy seemed to back him up. Her labia seemed to open, shaping themselves to his prick, engulfing the head. Her pussy looking like it wanted to swallow him up.

He shifted slightly upward, bringing his cock into a more perpendicular alignment. He thrust gently and his cockhead disappeared inside her, her pussy spreading wide to accommodate him. She gasped loudly, a reminder of how big he was, much thicker than his two fingers. Much bigger than my own cock.

He pumped himself into her, deeper and deeper, each new penetration eliciting a new vocal confirmation, a gasp, a moan, a grunt, a groan. Her labia stretched obscenely around his fat cock, clinging to his shaft as he pulled out. He hammered into her again, hard, the whole of his prick now inside her, making her entire body shudder as he penetrated her fully.

"Fuck that's hot," he moaned as he zoomed in on her sex engulfing his prick. "Fuck, she's tight."

He fucked her like that for a few more minutes, relishing the feel of her tight pussy, delighting in showing off his violation of my wife. Then without warning, he pulled out, his impossibly long prick taking forever to retreat. For a moment, he remained zoomed in on her vulva, no longer a dainty, graceful mound, but now a sloppy, wet, distended gash.

"Slide up on the bed," he ordered.

She meekly complied.

He placed the phone on the bedside table, zooming out to provide a full tableau of my wife laid out on his bed from the side. She kept her eyes on the phone, on my face. He crawled over to her and climbed up between her legs.

He saw where she was looking and grinned. "That's right baby, let hubby see your face while I fuck you." And with that, he thrust into her, hard.

Her body shuddered and her eyes rolled back into her head. He slammed into her roughly, pounding that big prick into her over and over. For a while, she kept her eyes shut tight, but then she opened them and again we made a semblance of eye contact.

After several minutes, he slowed down. They were both breathing hard. He was still fucking her, but more gently now.

"You know that feels good," he rumbled at her.

She shook her head. "No."

"You're getting wet for me. You know you like it," he insisted as he resumed ramming her hard.

She continued to gasp and grunt at each thrust, but in a way, I hoped he was right. I knew she'd never enjoy it. She was too strong-willed to ever be broken that way. But he had taken his time with her, prepared her for his cock, and eased into her. Despite the humiliation, the feeling of powerlessness, the rage at being violated, I wished that it did feel good, or at least not bad, that regardless of the emotional consequences, that she was at least not in physical pain.

He didn't last much longer after that. She didn't bother to beg him not to come inside her. I'm sure she realized that would only give him additional pleasure when he did. And sure enough, after a series of particularly brutal thrusts, he remained buried deep in her pussy as he shuddered and gasped and filled her with his come.

He immediately rolled off her and recovered the phone. He zoomed back in on her battered snatch. He thrust two fingers inside her and held her open for me, until a thin stream of jism appeared and began leaking from her pussy.

"I hope you like your pussy creamy," he taunted. He followed the stream of come leaking toward her ass, and then he added, "And in 24 hours, if I you don't come through, I'm gonna crack open wifey's back door. Now, get to work numb nuts."

He disconnected the call. I finished my scotch. He was right. I needed to get back to work.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The problem was my lack of information. I still didn't know where Jessi was. Heck I didn't know where Sal or my wife was either. I had Jessi's phone number, but she'd blocked my line. I now had Sal's Facetime account on my phone, so in theory I could reach him, assuming it actually was a permanent account and not a dummy he'd created just for that one call. But neither of those seemed to provide any avenues to exploit.

I hadn't really exhausted options for getting leads at the group house, and I could, in theory, go back to the garden apartment and talk to the neighbors or track down a landlord or something. But as promising as that had felt in the morning, it now seemed like a time sink that was unlikely to provide a breakthrough.

I also needed an option I could pursue now that it was night. That sparked my next thoughts. I had those "house rules," from various strip clubs, places where Jessi, or Star, as I increasingly thought of her, had worked. I doubted she would be working, but it was certainly possible someone there would know her.

But I felt hamstrung by the fact that I'd never been to one of those places. From the movies I'd seen, I got the feeling that they weren't the sorts of establishments where nosy questions were welcome. But then again, it occurred to me that I probably shouldn't be getting my information from movies. I decided to go and play it by ear.

I stopped by the bank. My transfer from the brokerage account had been credited, but it wasn't available for withdrawal. I groaned in frustration. Just once, I wished, something would go right. I pulled out my credit cards and maxed out the cash advance on all of them, \$2400. Armed with my new bankroll, I drove down to Iron City.

I found the Gold Club first. It had a huge footprint, a well-lit parking lot out front. That was already a surprise. I went in and paid my cover, then entered the club itself. It was very dark, a hip-hop beat rumbling. There were two stages. On the main stage, a cute, extremely fit brunette was swinging around a pole, gripping it with her thighs. It looked like hard work. Behind the bar an older, more weathered blonde was

swaying listlessly to the music. There were maybe a dozen girls in lingerie scattered around the floor. Some were chatting in a small cluster, the rest hanging on men, locked in animated conversation.

A huge man in a tux with an earpiece tucked into his collar approached me. I stiffened.

He reached out a beefy paw. "Welcome to the Gold Club. Is this your first time here?"

"Yes," I blurted out, immediately regretting it. I sighed inwardly and decided to go with it. "Yes, never been here before."

He smiled. "Well, you'll love it. My name is Paul. Would you like a table?" he asked, gesturing toward the low tables near the stage.

"Um, naw. I think I'll just hang at the bar."

"Okay," he said. "Have a good time."

I sat down and ordered a nine-dollar Miller Lite from a woman bartender virtually bursting out of her bustier. Instantly a slender Asian girl approached me.

"Hi, I'm Crystal, can I join you?" she asked in completely unaccented English.

"Sure."

She held out her hand. "So what's your name?"

"Daniel," I replied, immediately regretting that as well. She wasn't really Crystal, Jessi wasn't really Star, and in this world, I probably shouldn't be Daniel.

"So are you from around here?"

"No. I'm from, um, outside Baltimore." A clumsy lie. I'd never been to Baltimore. Couldn't sell that one if called on it.

"You here on business?"

I nodded.

"What do you do?"

"Um, consulting," I replied vaguely.

She kept smiling at me. She was not at all put off by my terse answers, my squirrely demeanor. I realized she was probably used to it.

"So, Daniel, would you like a dance?"

A dance? What did that mean? Would she finger herself inches from my face like Jessi had done to Vinny in the hotel room? Was she offering more? Less?

I looked at her closely for the first time, as closely as I could, given the poor lighting. She was pretty enough. Not quite as young as I had initially thought, but quite attractive. She had on too much makeup, fake eyelashes, gaudy nails, and absurd platform heels. On the plus side, she was wearing very, very little, just a lacy bra, a sheer white blouse tied at her navel, and a very short, thin black skirt.

She was staring at me expectantly. She inclined her head as if to say, "Well?"

"Um, no, not for right now."

She gave me a disappointed frown. "Maybe later?" she said as she got up and walked away.

I looked around the room again. Along the back wall was a long banquette. Interspersed along it were several men each with an individual dancer. I watched as the girls variously danced, ground, and teased the men. As I was watching that, I noticed another girl leading a man by the hand and taking him to an area marked, "VIP." I wondered what that was all about.

I decided to track down Paul and ask him. He filled me in on the details, such as they were. Dances out on the floor were twenty dollars each. The VIP room was reserved for guys buying blocks of dances. And then he pointed out the champagne room, \$300 for thirty minutes, and you need to buy a bottle of champagne.

"What happens there?" I asked.

He grinned. "Depends on the girl."

I went back to the bar and about thirty seconds later another girl came up to me with the same patter. This one amusingly called herself "Danica," obviously due to her passing resemblance to the racer. I agreed to a dance, a cheap one out on the banquette.

As the next song began, she stripped down to a G-string, and climbed in my lap. She ground against me, thrusting against my rapidly growing erection. She was wearing a lot of perfume, too much under normal circumstances, but there something intoxicating about it as it curled into my nostrils. She leaned forward and moaned moistly into my ear.

At first, I kept my hands to myself, but then, testing boundaries, I let my hands slide across the smooth skin of her lower back.

"That feels nice," she cooed.

She rose and spun around, dropping her hard ass into my lap, grinding me again. I ran my hand over her belly, cupped her breasts. Gently, but firmly, she pulled them away.

"That's only for the VIP room," she instructed me.

"I'm sorry," I mumbled.

"We can go back there if you want. I promise you'll have a good time."

The idea was a huge turn on. She was very cute and so forward. I'd never been this close to a woman, a stranger, who was so apparently sexually available. I could see why men might go to a strip club. It wasn't so much about the nudity, but rather the feeling of being wanted. I knew it was all an act. That it was all about the money. But even still, it was hard to resist.

When the song ended, she asked if I wanted another dance. I agreed. Even though I'd admitted to Paul that I was a newbie, I took a risk on being found out by asking if she knew a girl named Star.

"Naw, baby, but what do you need her for if you have me?" she pouted as she dropped to her knees and ground her face into my lap like a cat marking its territory.

"A friend told me to look her up if I ever came here."

"Well, you'll tell him to check out Danica, right?"

"I will," I agreed as the song ended.

I paid my \$40. She gave me another pout. "Didn't you have fun?" she said as she eyed the money sadly.

"Oh, sorry," I replied peeling off another twenty as a tip. I was learning, slowly.

She gave me a kiss on the cheek as her hand tweaked my package. "I'll come back later and see if you want to go to the VIP room, okay sweetie?"

When the next girl came up, I agreed to another dance. This one was a blonde, a little thicker, and she spent most of the dance hard selling me the VIP room. She also had never heard of Star.

I began to wonder if any of the girls would acknowledge her even if they did know her? Was it against the stripper code? Were they just too competitive to risk losing a mark to another girl?

I decided the best bet was to talk to the maître d' or bouncer or manager or whatever Paul was. But I'd already burned my cover at the Gold

Club, so to speak, so decided to try one of the other clubs.

My next stop was Satin Dolls. This club was smaller, with lower ceilings, more intimate, less classy. The girls weren't quite as cute as at the last club. They had more tats, more piercings. I didn't get quite as friendly a greeting, just a quick nod from the bouncer near the front.

I made my way to the bar. Here the barkeep was a guy, young, muscular. I imagined he'd probably banged half the girls there. I ordered my nine-dollar beer, which I paid for and also threw down a five-dollar tip.

"Thanks bud," he said, picking it up. "So have you been here before?"

As I expected, the tip had bought a few extra moments of his attention.

I gave him an exaggerated smile. "Yeah, man. Had an amazing time. Any chance Star is working tonight? Skinny brunette, great little titties."

He laughed. "Oh, I know Star. Yeah, she was a party, huh? Haven't seen her in a while, though. I dunno if she still dances or what."

I suppressed a sigh of disappointment.

"Aw, that sucks. I was really hoping for repeat engagement."

He inclined his head slightly. "You should talk to Amber. She and Star were close. She might know if Star is dancing at some other club or something. And if not, Amber is a good time herself."

"Is she here?"

He pointed toward a very pretty redhead who was chatting up an older guy by the main stage. She was in a slutty schoolgirl outfit, complete with pleated skirt and knee-high socks, and a sheer blouse tied off below her ample breasts.

She kept working the older dude for a while, but he apparently wasn't biting. She stood and the barkeep waved her over. Seeing a potential mark, she flounced over toward me.

The bartender introduced us, "Hey Amber, meet my buddy..."

"Trent," I offered.

She shook my hand. The bartender continued: "He was looking for Star, have you seen her?"

A look of surprise crossed her face. She composed herself quickly. "What do you want with that dirty little whore?"

"I... I... Maybe I'm looking for a dirty little whore," I replied, catching on.

"Well, you came to the right place," she said with a grin, leaning forward, showing off her cleavage, and patting my forearm.

"Well, I'll leave you two lovebirds alone," the bartender said as he crossed to the other side of the bar.

She gave me what I was beginning to recognize as the usual stripper script. I answered equally by rote, though this time I acknowledged living in town and admitted to being an engineer, trying to limit the number of lies I told to avoid getting tripped up later. But the whole time I was trying to figure out what her initial reaction had meant. She knew Jessi; that was certain. But if she hadn't seen her in a while, wouldn't she have said that?

I didn't get much further before she asked if I wanted a dance.

"Definitely," I replied.

"You wanna go back to the VIP room? \$300 for half an hour, and we can get much more comfortable."

"Sounds like fun."

She led me by the hand, her ass swiveling sexily as she walked. At the entrance, a bouncer told me it was a \$50 fee to go inside. She leaned up close and told me it was worth it.

It didn't feel much like a VIP room. It was just a series of curved booths. She led me inside one of them and closed a curtain behind her, giving us something of a private enclave.

She stripped to her G-string and hefted her perfect teardrop breasts.

"They're beautiful," I said honestly.

"You can play with them, but don't put your fingers inside me, okay?"

I nodded.

She stepped up close and pushed her knee into my crotch. I grasped her slender waist and slid my hands down to her hips as she ground against me. She pressed her body against mine, her hand snaking into my lap.

"You have a nice, hard cock," she cooed.

She turned and ground her ass firmly into my crotch. I reached around and palmed her tits, running my fingers over her stiffening nipples. I

was there on a mission, but for it to be successful, I needed to sell myself as just another customer. The problem was that it was hard to stay focused. The lure of letting go, just enjoying the sensation of a pretty, young, almost naked woman rubbing herself all over me was almost overpowering.

For several minutes, I lost myself in the moment. I closed my eyes, allowing my other senses to take over. Her perfume was a little subtler than Danica's, but it was still intoxicatingly sweet. I felt her silky hair against my neck, my face. She licked my earlobes, moaning breathily all the while. My hands roamed over her body, massaging her breasts, rubbing her ass. I also explored her feminine curves, the small of her back, the swell of her hips, and the downy hair at the base of her neck.

But I couldn't escape for long. What was Sal doing to Kris at that very moment? While I was fondling Amber, was he forcing my wife to dance for him? To suck his fat cock? Was he fucking her at that very moment? Sharing her with his hired muscle? Others?

Time was sliding by. I needed to get Amber talking about Jessi, but I also realized that Amber's only interest in me was emptying my wallet. I thought about just offering her money in return for information, but that felt dangerous. There was too big a chance she'd clam up or feed me lies if she saw me as a threat to her friend. I needed to let her think it was in her financial interest to tell me about Jessi, but I couldn't see how to do it. And short of that, my best bet was to stay close to her, maybe get her alone, and play for time.

She was working hard, grinding, moaning. I'd lost my erection as I focused on alternatives, and she noticed.

"What's the matter baby?" she whined, her hand now rubbing my crotch vigorously. "Not enjoying yourself?"

"I'm definitely enjoying it," I replied in what I hoped was a sultry voice. "It's just..."

She sat in my lap, straddling me, her arms around my neck, bouncing her boobs up and down in front of my face. "It's just?"

I was flying blind, but I took a shot. "Well, I'm wondering whether we could go somewhere and get a little more intimate."

She gave me a reproving look, but I plowed ahead.

"I could pay."

She stopped grinding. "Are you a cop?"

"No. No. I just... Star and I..."

"I don't have sex for money," she said firmly. But I noticed she resumed her grinding in my lap.

"No, of course not. I was just thinking, you know, I'd pay you something for taking off the rest of the evening. Cutting your shift short. We can go somewhere, get a drink, and if the chemistry is right..."

"Chemistry, eh?"

"Chemistry, biology, astronomy, whatever. What's it worth to you to cut your shift short?"

"Two grand."

It is funny how sophisticated I'd become in just a few days that I knew that was a rip off. Jessi had asked for just \$1500 to be sodomized without a condom in front of a roomful of guys.

I shook my head. "Come on, baby. I can do a thousand, but no rubbers." I don't know why I said it. Was it to stay in character? Was I again allowing my own desires to creep into my decision-making?

"I can't do that."

"Star was cool with it."

She hesitated.

"Are you clean?" she asked.

"Are you?"

"Well, I guess we're gonna find out."

She hesitated. "You sure you know Star?"

"Tall, skinny, almond eyes. Salamander tattoo on her leg, some weird poem on her rib cage. I think her real name is Jessi. She let it slip at one point." I held my breath. That last bit might have been too much.

She nodded. "Okay, Trent. Let's have some fun. Meet me at the corner of Fremont and Lane in fifteen minutes. If they see us leaving her together, I'll never work here again."

She escorted me out of the VIP room and gave me a kiss. She disappeared into the back. I went over to the bar and ordered another beer from the same bartender as before.

"So, did ya have a good time back there?"

I forced a big goofy smile. "Hell, yeah. The girl's an animal."

"You don't know the half of it," he said with a knowing leer.

I drank my beer quickly, my mind racing. What the hell was I doing? I was investing most of the money in my pocket and most of an evening getting myself into a position to... what? Even if they'd been

friends, shared tricks, whatever, I had no reason to think Amber would lead me to Jessi.

I tried to plumb my emotions. I was so tired, so frustrated. Was I even still thinking about Kris? No, I knew I was. I'd been replaying the images of Sal taking her over and over. His fat cock spearing her shaved cunt. The sight of him between her legs, pumping away. The image of his come leaking from her abused pussy.

It made me want to scream. But I was also unaccountably angry with her. I couldn't shake the sensation that's she'd submitted to him too easily, that she was being too accommodating, and had been from the moment she dropped to her knees before him in our living room.

Intellectually, I knew she'd had little choice. But I couldn't stop myself from feeling betrayed as well. It wasn't fair. It was an evil, selfish feeling, and I hated myself for having it, but I couldn't deny it either. I couldn't help but wonder whether part of her submissiveness was not just self-preservation, but also an act of vengeance against me for having let myself get dragged into Jessi's world.

Those feelings clouded my judgment. I could make an argument that Amber was my best lead, my best opportunity to track down Jessi and to rescue Kris, and that I should do whatever I needed to stay close to her, get closer even in the hope of catching some sort of break. But at the same time, I couldn't help but wonder if I wasn't just inventing a rationale, an excuse to fondle another woman, to have sex with another woman, to repay Kris' "betrayal" with one of my own.

My instincts were coarsening. I was seeing schemes and grifts in everything. As I got into my car, I pulled out the gun, placed it under my thigh. It occurred to me that I just agreed to meet a stripper at a deserted street corner in a dicey part of town and that I had let her know I had over a thousand dollars in my pocket. I was inviting a mugging or a carjacking or worse.

But after a few minutes, she walked up, alone. She'd changed into street clothes, jeans and sweats. She peered into the car cautiously before climbing in. She still had on her makeup, her perfume.

"So sweetie, where to?" she asked.

"Can't go to my place," I said. I waved my wedding ring at her. "And I'd rather put hotel money toward a tip. So, your place?"

"Okay," she replied quickly. "But it's a mess, and I have roommates."

"Anyone I would know?" I asked, hinting about Jessi.

She picked up on it right away. "Why do you care? Looking to trade up?"

I thought fast. "After that dance you gave me, I think it would be a trade down. But I'd be lying if I said I hadn't thought about how much fun the three of us could have together."

She rolled her eyes at me.

"Okay, I live over by the arena. You know the way?"

"I think I can get us there."

"Good, because I'm gonna be busy," she replied, as she leaned into my lap. "Drive," she commanded even as she unzipped my fly.

I pulled out into traffic, and she pulled out my cock. I gasped as she swallowed me deep. I still had my pants on, and it was a little awkward for her to get her head in my lap, so it didn't feel particularly amazing physically, but mentally it sent me reeling. Not only was this the first time I'd had my prick inside anyone but Kris, it was also my first time doing this in a car, and knowing Amber was a whore, a total stranger....

The loud car horn shook me out of it. I'd begun to swerve into the next lane, into the path of a huge black SUV. I swung back into my own lane and it passed me, a very angry looking black man in the passenger seat yelling abuse at me through two sets of closed windows. As they drove away, I realized Amber was no longer sucking my cock. I looked down at her and she gave me an amused grin before getting back to work.

She didn't live far. When we arrived at her block, I parked and she led me to her apartment. It was a converted warehouse. The developers had probably hoped the area would turn into a new SoHo, but instead it was still a dark, dangerous area.

We went upstairs to her apartment. It was a large loft, and would have been lovely in the hands of an individual with a few bucks and taste. But in this case it had been subdivided into four individual sections with

ugly sheetrock walls reaching to the ceiling. We passed a kitchen, the counter space and pantry also subdivided, and a common living room that the residents seemed to use for storage of boxes, bicycles, and other large items.

As we walked through the flat, I looked for any sign of Jessi. I could easily imagine her there. It had that sort of messy, transient feel that I associated with her. But as far as I could tell, Amber and I were the only ones in the loft.

She led me into her room. She'd "decorated" it in the same style Jessi had our *au pair* suite, with clothes, cosmetics, and other crap scattered about. I wondered if being a stripper turned girls into slobs, or whether being slobs is part of what made them strippers. She cleared her bed with a dramatic sweep of her arms, then patted the not-so-clean sheet with her hand and invited me to get comfortable.

"Let me freshen up, and I'll be right back."

She didn't have anyone to collect money for her, so I figured I should probably leave it out somewhere. I counted out ten hundreds and placed them on her bedside table.

She returned a couple of minutes later, wearing just a sheer, short bathrobe. She spotted the money and gave me a satisfied nod. Then without hesitation, she slipped the robe off her shoulders and onto the floor. She was completely naked.

My eyes were first drawn to between her legs, to her shaved snatch. I didn't know if she was a natural redhead, but with her pale complexion and freckles, it seemed likely, and I found myself wishing she'd left some red muff in place. I quickly took in the rest of her. Without the stripper heels, she was a short girl, all tits and ass, a very similar body type to Kris, I realized. Is that how men saw my Kris? I shuddered as it occurred to me that somewhere, across town perhaps, Kris might be in exactly the same position, standing naked in front of a virtual stranger, knowing he would soon be invading her with his hard cock.

"This works better if we're both naked," she said. Her tone suggested both amusement and a hint of impatience.

I realized we were working at cross-purposes. She wanted to get this over with as fast as practicable and get me out of there. I wanted to drag it out as long as possible and ideally get a chance to explore the loft.

"Why don't you come help me?" I replied.

She sort of shrugged her shoulders, but came toward me anyway. She reached out and began unbuttoning my shirt.

"Do you have any music?" I asked.

She gave a small sigh, but then dug out her phone from her bag and plugged it into a mini speaker, filling the room with a Hip Hop beat. I thought to ask if she had anything else, but decided against it. I wanted to take my time, but not get her so exasperated with me that I lost any possibility of cooperation.

She came back and resumed working on my shirt. She pulled it open and ran her hands along my rib cage, her hands cool and dry. She encircled my waist and pressed her face against my chest, her tongue snaking out to flick at my nipples.

I shivered in surprise.

"Do you like that?" she asked.

I nodded. Her hands followed the waistband of my chinos around to the front. She unbuckled my belt, then unbuttoned my pants and then pulled down my zipper. She reached down into my boxers and confidently fondled my prick, alternating between sucking on my nipples and pressing her own into my belly.

After a few moments, she dropped to her knees. She looked up at me with her big, grey-green eyes, and yanked down my slacks, taking my underwear down as well. She helped me step out of my pants and I helped out by tossing aside my shirt. I was naked, save for my socks. I thought of taking those off as well, but she took my mind off that by returning her attention to my package.

She was stroking my cock firmly, alternating hands between my shaft and my balls. She was inspecting me with what seemed like professional attention. As I hardened fully, she pumped my prick more forcefully, harder than Kris had ever done, but I really liked it. Amber definitely knew her way around an erect penis.

"You have a really nice cock," she cooed.

I blushed a deep red. It felt like Eddie Van Halen telling me I played a nice guitar.

"Thank you," I replied.

She smiled and swallowed me whole.

"Oh God," I moaned.

She bobbed up and down on my cock, her cheeks hollowing out as she sucked on my member. It felt nice, but it was almost too much stimulation. I would never be able to come from such a forceful approach. Kris' softer, wetter mouth was ultimately more enjoyable, a thought that, with a shudder, I realized seemed to confirm the results of Sal's blowjob contest.

Amber seemed to misinterpret my shudder. "Are you close?"

I shook my head.

A twinge of disappointment crossed her face, but she quickly suppressed it.

"Good. I want to feel your hard cock inside me," she said.

She turned and crawled over to the bed, shaking her ass at me, looking over her shoulder with a "come hither" gaze. She climbed up onto the mattress and rolled onto her back. She spread her legs wide and began to play with her pussy, her arms pushing her breasts together to accentuate her already amazing cleavage.

Even though my wife was just as attractive, had just as hot a body, there was something about Amber that was, for me, uniquely erotic. Maybe it was that she was a stranger. Maybe it was her complete lack of modesty, her willingness to be spread eagle in a well lit room, playing with her snatch, plunging two fingers inside herself.

"Come on, baby, can't you see how wet I am for you?"

My mind felt like it was operating at half speed. Was it the lack of sleep? The half-dozen drinks? Or just that I was working in an erotic fog?

"I want to eat it," I groaned. Was I just trying to drag it out? Did I really want it?

"Really?" she said. The request seemed to be outside the usual john playbook.

I nodded, but didn't really wait for her permission. Instead, I approached the bed and dove toward her snatch. I placed her legs over my shoulders, spread her pussy with my fingers, and licked her deep.

She shuddered and let out a soft sigh, which felt like one of the first genuine responses she'd given me all night. Encouraged, I continued to eat her out, feeling her wetness coat my face, her body squirming as my tongue probed the depths of her vagina. I took her clit in my mouth, sucked it hard. She gasped passionately, ran her hands through my hair.

Then suddenly her fist closed and she yanked my head upward by the hair. I yelped in pain, worried I'd hurt her or something. But she just looked at me, wild eyed.

"I need your cock inside me," she said urgently. "How do you want me?"

I only hesitated half a second. "On your hands and knees."

She smirked. "Your wife doesn't like it doggy style?"

I didn't need to answer. She could see it in my face. Kris didn't like the lack of intimacy, always wanted us to make love face to face. And, of course, like many women, the name "doggy style" was a complete turn off. The first man to be able to successfully rebrand the position into something less coarse would deserve a Nobel. But none of that seemed to bother Amber. She flipped over and waved her ass in my direction. Reaching between her legs, she spread her pussy open for me.

I climbed up onto the bed, rubbed my cockhead against her juicy labia, and with a quick thrust, buried myself inside her, only the second pussy I'd ever experienced. God, she felt nice, hot, very wet.

Immediately when I entered her, she began thrusting back against me, rolling her hips and sliding her snatch up and down the length of my shaft. I let her do most of the work, contenting myself with running my hands all over her body, rubbing her firm ass, fondling her hanging breasts.

When she paused for a moment, I seized the initiative. I grabbed a handful of her thick hair and yanked back as I thrust into her hard.

"Oh God," she sighed. "Is it okay if I come?"

That question almost made me come as well. But I took a deep breath and slowed myself down. "Of course."

She began to grind against me again.

"Pinch my nips," she gasped.

I did as she asked, firmly rubbing those grape sized nipples between my thumb and finger, and was rewarded with a satisfying gasp of pleasure. She continued to fuck backward against me, harder, harder, and then she reached back with her hand, and plunged her middle finger deep into her own ass.

"Fuck that's hot," I hissed.

But she was in her own world. "Oh fuck, oh fuck, oh fuck," she cried out.

And then suddenly, she went silent and her pussy began to spasm wildly on my cock.

"Oh fuck, that was good," she said. She fell forward and rolled onto her back. She spread her legs wide and beckoned me to take my place between. I crawled up and between her thighs and buried myself back inside her.

She reached down and grabbed my ass, urging me to fuck her harder. She was moaning and gasping in my ear, telling me how good I was, how much she loved my cock, how she wanted me to come inside her. I knew it was mostly an act, but it still felt good to hear it, especially since I was pretty sure she hadn't faked the orgasm.

I thought about Kris. I wondered if Sal, and the others, had made her come as well. I knew she was being held against her will. But Amber was only with me because of that stack of hundreds on the bedside table. Regardless of intentions, we only have so much control over our own bodies. I pictured Sal's fat, ugly prick forcing its way inside my wife, and I also pictured her pussy, stretching for him, accommodating him. Had she come when he'd fucked her? Was she coming even now, impaled on his thick cock?

I still had those thoughts in mind as I felt Amber slide her finger between my butt cheeks. I didn't have time to protest before she pressed her middle finger deep into my ass. I saw stars, literally, and came so hard that for a moment I couldn't breathe.

I rolled off her and onto my back, gasping for breath.

"First time anyone's done that to you?"

"Yes," I replied.

My mouth was dry. My heart was racing. Slowly, I got myself under control, tried to clear my mind. I had to remember what I was here for.

"That was amazing. You were amazing," I continued.

She chuckled and added in a surprised tone, "Yeah, I had fun too."

I was going to make a joke about getting my money back, but decided it was likely to go down like a lead balloon.

"I am so happy that I ran into you instead of Star."

"I'll have to tell her when I see her next."

"You run into her often?" My heart was beginning to race again. She laughed. "You could say that. She's staying down the hall."

I fought the urge to leap upright and check the other bedrooms.

"Is she here now?"

"You still thinking about that threesome?"

Despite my recent mind-blowing orgasm, I still felt my prick stiffen at the thought of it. Jessi might be an evil bitch, but from what I'd seen she was also a world-class lay. The things those two might do to me, to each other...

"God, I'd go for that in a heartbeat," I replied.

"Well, you might be in luck. I think I might have heard her come in while we were fucking."

My excitement at having potentially caught up to Jessi mingled with guilt at having been so lost in the moment that I hadn't noticed someone's arrival in the loft.

"Would she be up for it?" I asked, trying to sound eager and horny, which wasn't that difficult since I was eager and horny.

"Only one way to find out."

Amber got up and reached for her sheer bathrobe, flashing me her bare pussy in the process. Again I was struck by how shameless she was, they were, these strippers and whores. Their bodies, their sex was just an instrument to them, something they used to get what they wanted.

She strode out into the hallway. I pulled on my boxers and peered out after her. She knocked on the second door on the left, and then stuck her head inside. After a few moments she withdrew. I slipped back into her room.

"Sorry, Trent, she's not up for it," she said when she returned. "But if you want more, we could work out a deal for an overnight."

I nodded. "Sounds great. Can I, um, hit the head first?"

She pulled open her bathrobe and hopped back onto the bed. "First door on the right," she replied. "I'll be waiting." She cupped her breast and pinched her nipple.

My heart was pounding as I walked down the hall, past the bathroom, past the first door on the left, to the second. For a split second I wondered if Amber had just been faking me out, whether Jessi, or anyone actually, was even in that room. Not that it mattered. I was going in there no matter what.

I grabbed the knob and twisted it firmly, shoving the door open in one motion.

"Fuck Amber, I told you, I'm not interested in double-teaming your trick."

She was hunched over her phone, curled up on a ratty futon, an old desk lamp perched precariously on one of the many cardboard boxes in the room.

"Good to see the money's not going to your head."

She jolted upright, eyes narrowed, looking like a cornered cat.

"What the fuck are you doing here?"

"Looking for you."

She eyed me up and down, piecing together my presence. She pursed her lips. "What's Kris gonna say when she learns you've been out fucking whores?"

"Fuck you, Jessi. Now, where's the shit you stole from Sal?"

She smirked and shrugged her shoulders. "Like I said, I invested it in the future."

"Are you crazy Jessi, ripping off the mob? How'd you think you'd get away with that?"

She laughed. "Oh, please. Sal isn't the fucking mob. He's just a third-rate wholesaler dealing out of his house in Forest Glen. He supplies frat boys with their weekly blow to cover his hooker expenses. He's not fucking Tony Soprano."

"He came to our house. Threatened our kids. Kidnapped your sister."

She laughed at that. "That's because you two are pussies. You should have just told him to fuck off."

I shook my head. "Look, I really don't care. All I care about is getting Kris back. So you're coming with me, cocaine or not. This is between you and Sal."

I reached out to grab her, but as I did, my vision suddenly went white, like I was staring into the sun.

CHAPTER NINE

I woke up in the backseat of my car. It was daylight. Every inch of my body ached. All my muscles were sore, twitchy. My mind was foggy, slow. I felt drunk.

I was still in my boxers, the rest of my clothes balled up on top of me. As I moved, I felt a particularly sharp pain in my lower back. I reached back and touched two scabby welts. The flesh felt burned. There was a bruise, a pinprick on my inner forearm. It was itchy, burning. Jesus, had those bitches doped me up?

I slapped my face until I felt somewhat awake. I put on my clothes, was somewhat shocked to find I still had my phone and my car keys. I even had my wallet, though all my cash was gone; in its place was a note from Jessi.

"Danny Dan: Amber wanted to dump you naked in a dumpster with a dildo rammed up your ass. You can thank me later. For now, stay the fuck away from me. Love, Jessi."

She'd added a little heart over the "i" in her name.

I got out of the car and raced back to the loft. I already knew it was pointless. After dumping me, they'd surely have made tracks. Sure enough I found the loft door unlocked, and a quick examination of their bedrooms confirmed that they'd taken their personal possessions and disappeared.

I stamped my feet in frustration. All that fucking effort. I'd found Jessi. It had been a miracle, but I'd done it. And then I'd just let her slip through my fingers. I was still no closer to rescuing Kris than...

It hit me.

...Forest Glen. She'd said he lived in Forest Glen. This whole time I'd been thinking of tracking down Jessi, it had never really occurred to me to just rescue Kris myself. Most of that was that I didn't have any clues about where to find Sal. But part of it was also that the idea of invading his home, even if I could find it, seemed crazy, desperate. But crazy and desperate was where I now was.

I returned to the car and reached beneath the seat, breathing a sigh of relief when my hand found the gun still safely hidden away there. I

would need that, but I also needed a whole lot more.

Forest Glen, despite sounding a little like a funeral home, was actually a well-known gated community north of town. Kris and I had often joked that our goal was to be successful enough to end up in Forest Glen. In a less stressful moment, I might have found the irony amusing. As it was, I was just focused on the additional complications Forest Glen added to the situation.

I drove up north and cruised past the neighborhood. There was one main entrance with a large, manned guard post that checked IDs 24/7. A large sign reminded that "All Visitors Must Be Announced." Around the back was a service entrance, but it had a sign noting that "All Deliveries Must be Scheduled in Advance." I wondered how people there managed to get their Amazon packages—or even a pizza. Either way, impersonating a deliveryman didn't seem likely to be successful.

A second loop of the neighborhood yielded even more discouraging results. The entire community seemed to be surrounded by a high, metal fence. It occurred to me I could lean a ladder against it and just climb over, but then I'd have to move the ladder to the other side to escape after. It was doable, but seemed very risky. The odds of detection and alarm were too high to accept casually.

Still, climbing the fence seemed my best option until I noticed a jogging path emerge from a wooded area by the fence line. I slowed the car and looking over my shoulder. I spotted it, a narrow pass-through in the fence to allow runners from the development onto the path.

Having solved the access problem, I considered the other problem. I knew Sal lived in Forest Glen, but I didn't know which house. There were at least fifty, maybe one hundred, all on large lots, scattered through hilly, winding roads.

Land records are public, but when I searched a few addresses in the community on my iPhone, I immediately ran into a problem. A good half the houses had been bought by limited liability corporations, shielding the owners' names. Fucking rich people and their obsession with privacy and security. It wouldn't save them from a real mob with pitchforks, but it did make my task much more difficult.

I did have the license plate number from Jerry's car, so I considered just slipping inside through the jogging path and then looking around until I found it. But of course, with all the three car garages, it was likely I'd miss it even if he happened to be staying at Sal's place at the moment. I couldn't afford that risk or the time. After having been burned by Jessi, I was determined to take into account every possibility, or at least every one I could think of.

And then it occurred to me. If I couldn't track down the house by myself, I would need to have someone lead me to it.

I was back at my home, which, after 48 hours, was already feeling sad and deserted. I forced down some food, took a shower. Then I laid out my purchases.

I had the gun with extra clips of ammunition. I had a new jogging outfit, nice and dark, but credible. I covered the reflective strips with black duct tape. A sleek running backpack. High powered binoculars. A pack of heavy-duty zip ties. And most importantly, a new 100-pound, combination safe. It was big enough for either \$250,000 in cash or 10 Kg of cocaine. I had filled it with twenty-five pounds of powdered sugar in quart sized Baggies. I wasn't planning to fool anyone, just buy time.

I went over the plan on paper, and then committed everything to memory. I muscled the safe onto the front porch and loaded up my backpack. I packed up a suitcase with some clothes for Kris and me. Then I got in my car and drove to Forest Glen.

I parked my car in the direction of the highway, down a side street across the road from the jogger cut through. It was now late afternoon, the shadows were lengthening. I took off at a jog toward the main gate, then reversed course after about a half mile. I didn't want to tire myself out, but I needed to seem like a real runner when I ducked into Forest Glen.

The cut through was narrow, just wide enough for a single person, a small concession to convenience over security, but enough for my purposes. I followed the path onto a leafy east-west road that ran

perpendicular to the main drive. I ran back towards the guardhouse, ducking into a copse of trees that gave a view onto the entrance. In the gloaming, I was well-nigh invisible.

I slowed my breathing and then made a voice call to Sal through FaceTime. It buzzed several times, until I feared that he wouldn't pick up. This was my only real gamble. If he didn't pick up, I'd have to wait for him to call me. That wouldn't be the end of the world, but I wanted to be able to set the pace.

Just as I was about to give up, he accepted the call.

"Hey, numb nuts, sorry I took so long to pick up. I was busy tonsil boxing your wife with my prick."

"Can it, Sal. I got your shit, okay."

"Well, well, well, I'm impressed, but a little disappointed. I was so looking forward to cornholing Krissy tonight. And from the way she was just slobbering my knob, I think she was looking forward to it too."

"You want to come to me, or me to you?"

He laughed. "Oh, I think it's best if one of my guys goes out to your place. That way I can keep sweet Krissy company and get her ready in case you decide to screw me. You're not dumb enough to do that, are you?"

"I guess you'll see."

I disconnected the call.

Less than five minutes later, I saw a car drive down the hill toward the main gate. Though I couldn't see inside, I recognized the license plate. It was the same car Jerry had driven to my place earlier, a black Lexus.

It was normally about fifteen minutes to our house. I gave him an extra five for traffic. Sure enough, twenty minutes after the car left, my phone vibrated. I had turned off the chimes. I accepted the call.

"What the fuck is this? And where the fuck are you?" he grunted.

"Take it easy, Sal. Your stuff is in the safe. Where I am doesn't really matter, does it?"

I could picture him seething, but as much fun as he'd had with Kris, this was really what he was after. He could sense a trap though, but obviously couldn't figure it out.

"It's not a bomb," I said quickly. "I have no interest in doing anything that's going to hurt Kris, but if you want your stuff, you're gonna have to do things my way."

"Kid, if you fuck with me, I am going to assfuck your wife and then put her out on the street turning tricks for a quarter a pop until I am fully paid back. Got it?"

"Get the safe home and then call me. We'll talk about next steps then."

I disconnected again.

I knew I had fifteen minutes to wait, but after that it became nerve wracking. It was early evening, and the rich folks were coming home on a regular basis. I tried to scope out Jerry's car early. The one thing I couldn't afford was to miss it.

And then, suddenly, there it was, approaching the main gate. The guard checked the sticker, flashed a light at the driver, and then lifted the arm barrier. I'd spotted his car coming down the hill when he departed, so I was already jogging in that direction as he hit the gas.

He passed me sooner than I expected. I sped up, trying to keep him in sight. He slowed, made a right. I ran harder now, gasping. When I got to the turn, I scanned around. Tail lights, maybe 250 yards away, turning left. I ran harder still, getting lightheaded, feeling my throat tighten as a wave of nausea hit me. When I got to the second turn, I scanned around again. Nothing. The road continued on, over a hill, down the other side, though I didn't know how far. Had I lost him?

I stopped. I forced myself not to breath, even as my chest pounded and my ears filled with a sound like rushing water. But even over that, I heard it. An engine shutting off, a car door slamming. It sounded like it was coming from the second house on the right.

I resumed my jogging, slower now, catching my breath. I passed the house on the opposite side of the street just in time to see Jerry ducking inside through a side door by the garage. He'd backed the car into the driveway, the easier to unload the safe from the trunk.

I was elated. I'd found her. But I also realized the hard part was coming up.

I looked around. Seeing no one, I crossed the street and threw myself into some thick shrubs bordering Sal's property. A moment later Jerry, joined now by Rock, came back outside. They lifted the safe out of the car and hauled it into the house. The door slammed shut heavily behind them. My suspicion was that it locked automatically, and I was loath to just

walk up and start tinkering with a well-lit, street-facing entrance. Being dressed all in black would make me look even more suspicious.

I worked my way around the back of the house. There were sliding glass doors that opened out onto a back deck. I could probably wrestle those open, though doing it quietly would be difficult. Then I noticed, on the deck table, a large ashtray, filled with butts. I felt a surge of excitement. If Sal's guests were going out there on a regular basis, they might be sloppy about locking the door.

I didn't see a dog. No sign of motion detectors.

I was about to jump the fence, but before I did I had to wait for Sal's next call. Sure enough, after a few more seconds, it buzzed at me.

"Hey, Sal, so you get the safe back home yet?"

"Yeah, what's the fucking combo?"

"Real simple Sal. You let Kris go. I give you the combo."

He laughed. "How stupid do you think I am?"

I resisted the urge to give a smart-ass response. Instead I gave him my sales pitch. "I think you're smart, Sal. I think you want to get back what's yours. And I think you'll understand that I just want to get back what's mine. I have no interest in messing with you. You've won. Just let her go."

"How do I know what's in the safe?"

I sighed. "You don't. But how do I know you'll let her go once you get your coke back? See, we're in the same boat."

"Yeah, numb nuts, except I have the safe, and I have your wife. So what I think I'll do is call up a buddy with a blowtorch to crack the safe while I go ahead and crack your wife."

"Sal, please, you've had your fun with her. Just please let her go."

"Give me the combo."

I hesitated. I had held out a small hope he'd agree to release her first, but now realized it had always been a pipe dream. The question was whether I'd buy more time by giving him the combination and letting him find the sugar? Or whether I'd get a few extra minutes by playing hardball? I decided on the latter.

"I can't do that. If you can't trust me, I can't trust you. Think about it. I'll call you back in fifteen for your final answer."

He laughed, darkly. "My final answer is going to be busting a nut in your wife's ass."

He disconnected.

I didn't have a moment to waste. I jumped the fence. My heart raced wildly. At any moment I expected lights to come on. Shouts. Angry men with guns. I crossed the lawn quickly and threw myself against the house. I drew my gun and approached the glass doors.

I peered inside into the kitchen. It was empty. I grabbed the door handle and pulled. It opened smoothly. I stepped over the threshold, closed the door behind me. Holy shit, I was in.

Off to the right, I could hear a television, a baseball game in progress. I knew Jerry and Rock were in the house. Sal too. Was there anyone else? I couldn't be sure. I couldn't risk peering into the TV room. I had to just hope I wouldn't run into anyone before finding Kris.

I circled through the house to the left, trying to give the TV a wide berth. It led me through a formal dining room, then into the foyer. I slipped up the stairs. The steps led up to a landing, a hallway running left and right. To the right, I saw a big set of double door, the master suite. There were other rooms as well, doors shut, but potentially occupied.

I crept toward the master bedroom. Every footstep sounded like a hammer blow in my ears. I'd let Amber sneak up on me, incapacitate me. How could I think I'd get past these hard men when I couldn't even handle a naked girl? Still, I forced myself forward.

I reached the double doors and hesitated. Once I went through, I would lose the element of surprise. But I didn't know what I'd find. I didn't know what awaited me. Would it be just Kris and an unarmed Sal? Had he gathered an audience to witness the moment when he forced his fat prick into her virgin ass? Might he be armed, holding a gun to her head to ensure compliance?

I listened at the door. There were sounds, but they were muffled, distant. Did I hear her whine?

"Damn, you're tight," I heard him say.

Fuck, I was too late. I shoved the door open briskly. I blinked in the bright light, hadn't realized how dark the hallway was. The scene came into focus. She was naked, on the edge of his bed, on her hands and knees. He was behind her, in his bathrobe, his erect cock tenting the fabric. He had a firm grasp of her hair, holding her in place. He had two fingers in her ass, up to the second knuckle, twisting them back and forth. They both swung around to look at me, both of them with a similar look of shock.

"Get the fuck away from her." I raised the gun, my arm shaking noticeably.

He laughed. "What are you going to do with that?"

"Blow your fucking rapist head off if you don't get away from her." I stepped in closer. "Even as nervous as I am, I won't miss from this close."

My admission of nerves seemed to shake him. He could sense my desperation.

"Okay, relax cowboy," he replied as he released my wife.

She lunged away from him, away from his grasping hands, away from his probing fingers, away from his menacing prick. She tore a sheet off his bed and wrapped it around herself.

"There are others. In the house," she exclaimed.

"I know." I turned toward Sal. "Okay, now you're gonna lead us to the rest of your goons."

"Ask wifey. She's had plenty of opportunity to tour the other bedrooms."

She just nodded curtly. She started toward the door. I gestured for him to follow. We walked down the hallway. Kris pushed open one of the doors and stepped inside.

"Damn, baby, you back for more already?" I recognized Rock's amused voice. "I still have your stink on my dick."

I stepped forward and shoved Sal through the open door.

"Hey, what the fuck?" groused Rock.

I followed Sal and shoved the gun against his neck.

"Kris, get his gun," I grunted, nodding toward the dresser.

Rock stood quickly. "You know you aren't going to shoot anyone."

I shook my head. "Buddy, believe me, I am just looking for an excuse to kill each and every one of you after what you've done. You motherfuckers."

He glanced over Kris and then smiled. "You can't rape the willing," he replied. "And believe me, she's been more than willing."

I pressed the gun harder into Sal's neck. Sal yelped. "Rock, don't. This fucker ain't all there."

Rock took a step back and put his hands up. Kris ducked past him and grabbed his gun. She looked from Sal to Rock, her eyes suddenly wild. For a moment, I was sure she was going to kill them, just shoot them down

where they stood. I almost said something, but then I realized it had to be up to her. After a moment, she grunted and shook her head.

"You two aren't worth it," she said cryptically.

She turned back to me. "It should just be Jerry downstairs. No one else has been here this evening."

I nodded and shoved Sal back into the hallway.

Jerry was so focused on the game that he didn't notice anything was up until Kris put the gun to his head. She disarmed him quickly, and while I kept my gun pointed at them, she used the high strength zip ties to bind them individually to the balustrade.

"You'll regret this," Sal said as we moved to the front door. "Next time I see you, I'll kill you."

"Ditto," I replied.

We ran through the front door to freedom.

We were under no illusion that the zip ties would hold them for long. Kris was barefoot, so we moved slower than I would have liked. Finally, I picked her up and threw her over my shoulder and carried her down the hill.

It's a miracle we weren't stopped. But after so many things going wrong, we finally had a run of good luck. I put her down once we got onto the jog path. We scampered through the pass through and across the street. Inside the car. I turned the ignition and the engine roared to life. Without a pause, I hit the gas and lurched into traffic.

I'd done it. We'd done it. I'd rescued Kris. We were free.

CHAPTER TEN

We were driving. It took me a moment to realize we were both crying. I wanted to look at her, but somehow couldn't bring myself to do it. Was I worried about what I might see? I was driving fast, too fast. But I was barely in control of my emotions. It was Kris who finally pulled it together.

"Daniel, slow down. We're safe. Just slow down."

Her voice had a calming influence on me. It always had. I forced myself to breathe, collect myself.

"Where are we going?" she asked.

"To the hospital. And we need to call the cops."

"Slow down," she replied. This time she wasn't talking about my driving.

"Kris, after what you've been through, we need --"

She put her hand on my forearm. "I don't need to go to the hospital. I'm okay."

"But --"

"Daniel, please." She paused. She took a deep breath. "Daniel, what those men did to me... it's what men have been doing to women for centuries. I don't need a doctor, not yet. What I need is clean clothes, a shower, and to see my kids."

I kept driving. I could hear her words, but they weren't getting through.

"I could also use a doughnut and a coffee," she said. She pointed to a Dunkin Donuts by the side of the road. "Pull over.... Please."

It was such a prosaic request that somehow it penetrated my haze. I pulled into the parking lot and came to a stop.

"Daniel, look at me."

It was oddly difficult; I couldn't get my muscles to respond. Finally, I willed myself to do it.

She was sitting beside me, still wrapped in the maroon bed sheet she'd stolen from Sal's home. She had a sad, pensive look on her face. But she was my Kris. The girl I'd fallen in love with when I was thirteen. My first love, my only love. I had almost lost her. I struggled to keep it together.

"Oh God, Kris, I am so sorry. This is all my fault. If I hadn't gone with Jessi that night. I should have fought them, shouldn't have let them take..."

She shook her head. "No, no, Daniel, no. You're my hero. You rescued me. You kept our kids safe. It's all my fault. If I hadn't invited Jessi to stay..."

"No, you were just trying to save her..."

"And what did that get us?"

"I should have been able to protect you."

She shook her head sadly. "Daniel, there was nothing you could have done. Not without getting yourself or me hurt, not without risking our kids." She reached out and brushed my cheek. "I don't blame you," she added simply.

I just nodded. I couldn't speak. She gestured toward the store. "Get me a chocolate glazed, okay? And a coffee."

"Okay. There are clothes in the back."

By the time I returned, she'd changed into jeans and a sweatshirt. I handed her the doughnuts and coffee. She took a bite, a gulp. She sighed contentedly. "This is the first time I've felt normal in three days."

"Are you okay?" I asked. "Really okay?"

"I don't know," she replied honestly. "I'm not sure it has all hit me yet. And anyway, we're not really out of the woods."

"We could be. We can just leave town. Take the kids and make a new life somewhere else."

She shook her head. "We can't. We'd have to start over from scratch, with two kids in tow. We'd always been looking over our shoulders." She paused. "I'm guessing you didn't really have ten kilos of coke in that safe?"

"Powdered sugar."

She laughed darkly. "Right, so, we're going to need to do something about Sal."

"I should have just killed him when I had the chance."

"No. That would have destroyed our lives as surely as anything else."

I nodded. I knew then what she meant when she muttered that they "weren't worth it" back at the house. And she was right. But I was still at a

loss about how to proceed. All my thoughts had been focused on getting Kris back. But now that I had her, I had no idea how to get our old life back.

"We need to find Jessi," Kris said firmly.

"I found her," I replied. "And then she got away."

"What?"

"Ugh. Let me start from the beginning."

I relayed the whole story from my end. I told her about the night at the Four Seasons. About taking the kids to my mom's. About raiding our savings and giving money to Sal, all for naught. I told her about visiting Jessi's old lodgings, and then the strip clubs. I forced myself to come clean about the lap dances, and then I started to explain about Amber.

"I thought she was my only chance to find Jessi. I didn't know what to do, how to get her to cooperate. Oh God, Kris, I..."

I couldn't continue. Couldn't get the words out.

"What happened?" she asked softly.

"I... I had sex with her. I paid her for sex. I needed to keep her close, get into her apartment to look around."

I shook my head in disbelief at my own behavior.

"And?" she prompted. Her tone was cold, distant. Or maybe that was just me projecting my own emotions onto her.

I wasn't quite sure what she was looking for. An apology? Did she want to know if I'd enjoyed it?

"It worked. Jessi about walked in on us."

She nodded, but I could still feel the disappointment radiating from her. As much as she had tried to reassure me, I couldn't help but feel like I'd let her down.

I plowed ahead. I told her about confronting Jessi, and then getting surprised, getting knocked unconscious. I explained how the conversation with Jessi had given me the hint about where Sal lived. And that I explained how I'd found her, and how I'd rescued her.

It was an ugly mixed bag. But she had just listened, asking the occasional question. Never judging, at least not openly. I kept waiting for her to explode. I was sure she would when she heard the details of the night in the hotel, or about me having sex with Amber, but she didn't. She'd didn't reassure me, but she didn't explode either.

And after, she sat quietly. He hands in her lap, thinking.

"We're certainly in a new land, aren't we?"

I nodded. I wasn't quite sure how to take it. "I wish we could go back."

She gave me a wan smile. "Me too. But I don't think we'll ever be able to get back completely to how things were."

"We can try." I took her hand in mine. I was grateful that she didn't push me away. "What do we do now?"

"I need to tell you my side of it first," she said.

"You... you don't need to," I replied. I had heard enough. Seen enough. She didn't need to pick at those scabs.

She looked me in the eyes. "Yes, I do. You need to understand. Otherwise, you'll come to hate me when you find out."

"No... I..."

She put her finger to my lips.

"I didn't fight them. Not once. I made my decision early. I don't know if it was the right one. Should I have traded some bruises for a modicum of pride? I didn't think so. I thought it was inevitable that they would take what they wanted, so I didn't see a reason to fight them. Do you understand? I submitted to them, completely. Gave them what they wanted, when they wanted it."

"You didn't have a choice," I replied sadly.

I realized with a start that part of my sadness came from the implication of what she'd believed or feared.

"You didn't think I'd come for you." I said.

She hesitated. "I knew you'd never give up on me."

She hadn't denied it, and by not denying it, she confirmed it. From the moment those men had come into our house, she'd felt like she was on her own. That she'd have to survive and escape purely on her own wits and wiles. That she couldn't count on me.

"There's more," she continued, unaware of my inner torment. "I wasn't just passive. I didn't just lay there. I knew the better I was, the sooner it would end, the less likely they would be to hurt me, the more likely I would be to walk out of there healthy and sane. It was self-preservation, but it'll look the same as enthusiasm on film."

"Film?"

She nodded. "He recorded hours of it."

I groaned. I understood her concern. It wasn't so much the possibility of blackmail or humiliation, though that was another factor we'd

have to consider. She was more worried about how I'd react when, inevitably, Sal maliciously arranged a showing.

"Kris," I began, "do you hate me for what I did with Amber?"

She paused. "I don't know," she replied honestly. "I wasn't there. I don't know if there was another way. I don't feel like I can judge you. I trust that you did what you thought you had to do."

She was being easier on me than I was on myself.

"You understand that I enjoyed having sex with Amber?"

She nodded.

"So how can you think I would judge you?"

"Okay."

It was an ambiguous reply. She was still beating herself up, as was I. And I couldn't help but wonder if it wasn't for the same reason. Yes, I'd done what I thought I had to with Amber. And it had gotten me the lead I needed to find Kris. It had also gotten me zapped and, I rubbed my forearm, maybe drugged. And, if truth be told, I had enjoyed it. Had she also enjoyed her time at Sal's? On a purely transitory, physical level? Was that the source of her guilt?

"Kris, you are everything to me. You have been ever since we were in Mrs. Stenton's homeroom in eighth grade. All I could think about these last three days is getting you back. And now, now that we're together, I'm not going to let anything get between us. Not my guilt. Not my fears. We're in this together."

She looked up at me, her eyes wet, tears running down her cheek. "I love you, Daniel. And I always will."

I pulled her close, into a tight hug. We sat there for what felt like hours, until the sky began, slowly, to brighten.

"I want to see the kids," she said finally.

We drove to my mom's and spent the day with the children. We played games, tickled their little bellies, took pictures. My mom seemed relieved to see Kris and me back together. So much so that she didn't question it when that evening we asked her to keep them a few days longer.

The transfer from our retirement savings had finally cleared and we'd withdrawn the last ten thousand dollars we had in liquid assets. We

gave my mom an envelope of cash, asked her to take the kids to visit my sister in Dayton. She read something in our tone, and agreed without comment.

We kissed the kids and left. With both of us crying like babies, we found a residential motel and got a suite. We paid for a week in advance. It was grimy: A nasty, rusting kitchenette, a cramped living room, and a small bedroom. It was a place for transients on their way to the bottom. We hoped that wasn't us. But for now, we couldn't go home. Not until we'd gotten clear of Sal. This would be our base of operations as we tried to recover our lives.

Kris took a long shower, long enough that it was obvious she was hoping to wash away the past three days. I waited for her in the lumpy double bed.

She climbed in with me naked, her body warm, still a bit damp. She'd dried her hair as well as she could, but it was still wet, lank.

We lay on our sides, our faces inches apart. We didn't speak, just looked at each other for a long while. We could hear cars roaring past on the road, the sounds of TVs in adjacent rooms, occasional voices, some happy, some angry.

I'd stripped off the stained bed cover, thrown it into a corner of the room. We pulled up the thin sheets, the worn blankets.

"Will you make love to me?" she asked softly.

I frowned. The question made me sad. It was a reminder that she saw herself as soiled somehow.

"Only if you'll make love to me," I replied.

I leaned forward and kissed her. Just a kiss. Just our lips touching. Hers were so soft, as they had always been. I didn't touch her, remembering a time when I didn't dare. For a long time we were back in junior high, thirteen, fourteen, just kissing, the feel our lips touching intoxicating.

She licked my lip. I grinned. She was always the more forward one. I responded quickly, more confidently than I had back then. We kissed more passionately now, our tongues intertwined.

She reached out, grabbed my ass. She gave it a firm squeeze. I returned the favor. She felt so familiar, and yet somehow, so novel, the past three days a chasm between what was "then" and what was "now."

I slid my hand up between us, cupped her breasts. I laughed.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing," I replied. She didn't push it.

But I was thinking about the first time I'd had the guts to grab her boobs under her shirt. God, I'd spent weeks, weeks, thinking about it, planning it, debating it. And when I'd done it, she hadn't protested, not in the least. I had just cupped them, slid my hand beneath them, weighed them. It took me another two weeks to work up to touching her nipples.

Back in the present, I let my thumb slide over her nipples, feeling them stiffen at my touch. I licked my thumb, circled her areolas. She moaned softly. According to conventional wisdom, bigger tits are less sensitive, but Kris' have always been exquisitely responsive.

There was a time, after we'd started exploring our sexuality, before we'd actually had sex... she'd rub me through my jeans. She was off-limits below the waist. God, I was eighteen. She could make me come just by resting her hand on my crotch. I don't think I'd ever given her an orgasm. I'm not sure I even knew what a female orgasm was.

I remembered that night. I could recall playing with her breasts. Cupping them at first. Then playing with her nipples. We were under a blanket. Always. Somehow, our fooling around was always in the dark, under covers. I didn't see her breasts in bright light until we were married, and even then it was always in a non-sexual setting, coming out of the shower, changing. We always made love in the dark.

And then we were back in the present again. We were kissing. Wet, sloppy kisses.

Just like when we were eighteen. I'd played with her nipples until they were rock hard, until they seemed ready to burst. I'd ducked under the covers, sucked a nipple into my mouth, hard. I was flicking at her other nipple. I remember her begin to squirm, her hips gyrating. Then suddenly her breath caught. She gasped and grabbed me by the hair, thrusting her tongue into my mouth as her hand rubbed my crotch vigorously. I came hard, in my jeans. It wasn't until later, much later, that I realized that was the first climax I'd given her.

With that memory in mind, I ducked beneath the sheets and took her nipple into my mouth. My hand trailed down, over her belly, down between her legs. I withdrew, startled, when I realized she was shaved.

Even after seeing Jessi's shaved snatch, been intimate with Amber's, feeling it on Kris felt foreign, weird.

"It'll grow back," she said softly. "If you want," she added, uncertain.

"I know. It's just... different."

I felt a surge of anxiety. What else would be different? I resumed my explorations. I cupped her mound, letting my fingertips trace the shape of her sex. I slid my thumb over her labia, feeling them plump at my touch, just a hint of wetness of within. We kissed, tenderly and yet passionately. I ran my fingers up and down her slit, feeling her open for me, that most erotic of sensations, a sensation that was so much more distinct now that she was shaved.

She snaked her hand into my boxers, stroked my cock firmly. I was rock hard. Any sign of excitement from Kris has always done that to me, more surely than direct stimulation could do.

"I want you inside me," she moaned.

I peeled off my t-shirt, wrenched off my boxers. She was grasping at me, pulling me with her fingertips. I slid between her widely spread legs. She maintained her firm grip on my cock, sliding the head between her labia.

I gasped softly. It felt so good. Such a rare treat. We hadn't had sex without protection since we were trying for Justin. I had the sad realization that the only reason we were doing so now is that Sal and his buddies had spent a good twenty-four hours finishing inside her already.

I forced that image from my mind, thought instead of our first time together. I smiled. It had been awkward and stressful. In retrospect it sounds so romantic, losing our virginity to each other. In practice, with the condom and the diaphragm and the spermicide, it had been messy, and not in a good way. And it was quick, neither of us quite sure we'd gotten it right, but too shy to voice our concerns.

She released my prick, our practiced sign that she was ready. My cock sunk into her wet pussy. We both moaned together.

"Oh, that's nice," she sighed.

"Hmmm."

She wrapped her arms around my neck. We kissed. Wet, deep, passionate kisses. I thrust inside her, long, slow strokes. She felt so good, my Kris, no different than before. I could feel her hard nipples against my

chest. She lifted her legs off the bed, wrapped them around my waist. I thrust in deeper.

Her breath caught. She moaned open-mouthed. I felt her pussy spasm on my cock. I gasped and thrust in hard, feeling my balls tighten. I came hard.

She released me and relaxed back into the mattress. I pumped my cock inside her a few more times, relishing the feel of her, hot and gooey.

After another few minutes, I withdrew, though I remained prone between her legs, resting on my elbows. We kissed again. Soft gentle kisses.

"What were you smiling at?" she asked.

"Do I need a reason to smile during sex?"

"No, but..."

I laughed. God, she could also see right through me.

"I was thinking about us. About the first time we kissed. First time we had sex."

She laughed. "Oh God, we were awful."

"I think we're getting better at it."

"Yes, each and every time."

She frowned.

"What's the matter?" I asked.

She looked away, her eyes suddenly moist. "It just makes me sad to think about it. Sad at what we've lost."

I knew just what she meant.

"We're no longer each other's only," I said.

She nodded.

I kissed her. "We'll be okay. As long as we have each other we'll be okay," I said comfortingly.

"I know. But we can still mourn it, mourn what is gone."

"We may not be each other's only, but you'll always be my first, and my best."

"I love you Daniel. You'll always be my first and my best as well."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

We slept twelve hours that night, mostly intertwined, occasionally merely pressed up against each. It was like we needed to feel each other's bodies, to be reassured that we were still together.

She woke, showered, and dressed. I went and got us some doughnuts and coffee for breakfast.

We sat at the scratched up kitchen table.

"Okay, what do we do now?" I asked.

"We need to get Sal off our back," she replied. "At the very least, that means giving him back what Jessi stole, though after the other night, he might not be in a forgiving mood.

"Fuck him," I snapped. "After what he did..."

She put her hand on my forearm. "I know. But it's not about what's right or wrong, but just about how he's likely to react. Jessi's right. He's not a big time Mafioso, but he's also not used to people defying him, pulling a gun on him in his own house. I know he seemed willing to forgive and forget if he got back what Jessi stole, but I'm not sure that deal is even still on the table."

"I wish he'd get busted or something. Jessi's boyfriend got picked up. Now that you're out, we could make an anonymous tip or something."

She shook her head. "I don't know if the cops act on tips like that. Certainly, it isn't like we make a call and ten minutes later a SWAT team breaks down his door. I had a lot of time to think about this," she said.

My mind immediately conjured up an image of Kris, flat on her back, a strange man hammering away between her legs as she stared at the wall pensively. I shook my head to clear away that thought and refocused on her words.

"And anyway, I'm scared that we're somehow compromised on the whole drug business. He'll throw Jessi under the bus, and then we'll be involved. She was living with us after all. The whole criminal justice system acts on the principle of guilt until proven innocent in drug cases. We could end up dealing with asset forfeiture issues. Losing our jobs. Having our kids get taken away."

I sighed. She was right. The problem was that we had more to lose than he did. And either through spite or a deliberate effort at misdirection, it was likely he'd lash out at us. He could claim he was the victim of some sort of extortion at the hands of two whore sisters and their pimp, as he'd portray us. And ultimately, that didn't need to stick. Even the accusation would destroy our lives.

"I agree," I said finally. "No one is going to be able to swoop in and fix this."

"We need to find Jessi..."

"Again..."

"And this time," Kris said crisply, "we can't let her get away when we do."

"Amen to that." Just thinking of Jessi made my heart rate rise. Whatever empathy I'd felt for her vanished when she and Amber had tasered me.

"So where do we look?" asked Kris.

"I was hoping you'd have a suggestion. I pretty much burned through my leads already."

Kris frowned. "Yeah, she's gonna be even more careful than before."

"We could try to track down some of her other stripper friends."

"It might come to that, though I think she's unlikely to get trapped the same way twice."

I nodded. "Do you know any other places where she lived?"

"No. I mean, just in really loose generalities. It's not like she's ever invited me over for Christmas dinner. I don't think I even know any of her ex-boyfriends."

"Well, except for Damon," I replied.

"Damon?"

I blushed red. I hadn't shared that part of the story.

I hesitated. "Aw, fuck it. He's a guy she's been fucking since she moved in with us. She brought him over a few times."

"I never saw him," she began. A sad realization spread across her face. "Aw, Daniel, no..."

"I'm sorry, Kris. I don't know why I did it. Just couldn't help myself. I heard them coming in one night and went down to spy on them."

"Just once?"

"Please, Kris, I'm sorry."

She shook her head. "Believe me, Daniel, I *am* disappointed. But I'm not asking just to torture you. I'm trying to figure out if he was a boyfriend or just a one night stand."

"Oh. I... well, I watched them twice, so it wasn't a one-time thing."

"What do we know about him?"

"We know his name. I don't know what else. Well, that's not true. He's muscle-bound. Probably spends a lot of time at the gym, a big iron gym, a Gold's or something. Covered in tattoos, so he might even be a tattoo artist I guess. I could see him as a bouncer or a bartender. He doesn't look like he's a cubicle rat."

"Hmmm. Well, Jess is into tattoos," Kris noted.

"Yeah, that is a definite possible connection. Also, when I was at Satin Dolls, the bartender there made it pretty clear he'd, um, dated a bunch of the girls. He could work the bar at one of clubs where Jessi danced."

"Or another bar," she added. "I wonder if there is a stripper hangout? You know where they go to unwind after work."

"That would make it an after-hours club, or something."

"Okay. That's not a bad start. We have a name, a bunch of ideas of where to look."

I shook my head. "Honey, it was dumb luck that I caught up with Jessi. I just don't see..."

"No, it was hard work and street smarts. And we have some extra advantages now."

"Yeah?"

"Well, there's two of us for one thing, and for another, unlike Jessi, there's no reason to think that Damon is hiding out. So, describe him as well as you can."

"Um, white guy, built like a truck. I have no idea how tall he is. I mostly saw him lying down. Lots of tattoos. Lots. Full sleeves, color. None on his face that I could see, but maybe on his neck. I don't know for sure. I'd guess he was 25, maybe 30, probably not. Short, dark hair, a trimmed beard along his jaw line."

"Good looking?"

"Yeah, I guess."

"Anything else?"

Hung like a horse. Fucks like an animal. "No, nothing that will help identify him. I'm pretty sure I'd recognize him, though."

"Okay, well, if I spot a suspect, I'll try to send you a picture."

I shook my head. "I don't want to split up."

"I don't see that we have a choice. We have a lot of ground to cover, and frankly, it sounds like you'll do better alone in some of those places, like strip clubs. A couple is going to cause a scene, I think."

I shook my head again.

She put her hand on my forearm reassuringly. "I'll be okay. I won't do anything risky. And anyway, I'll be in disguise."

"Disguise?"

She smiled. "Isn't that what you do when you go under cover? Listen, you spend some time on the computer. Start off with Iron City, and work outward from there. Make a list of every gym, tattoo parlor, strip club, bar, and after hours club. We'll check the gyms and tattoo shops during the day, the clubs at night."

"And you?"

"I need to go shopping."

She came home and threw several big shopping bags on the table.

"I bought you some things as well," she said.

She grabbed a couple of bags and disappeared into the bathroom. I dug through the remaining ones. For me I found a pair of expensive grey-tinted jeans, a couple of combed cotton shirts, white with subtle patterns, and a pair of loafers in rich, brown leather.

There was also a pharmacy receipt. She'd purchase a dose of Levonorgestrel, Plan B, and also gotten some prescriptions filled for antibiotics and Valtrex. It was a reminder that her time with Sal might have permanent lifelong, medical consequences. I decided not to think about it. She was doing everything she could already.

She'd also bought more clothes for herself, a couple of stretchy dresses, frilly underwear. Some workout clothes. All sorts of makeup. Jewelry. A new pair of expensive black pumps with three-inch heels.

After what she'd been through, I wasn't about to question her about going on a shopping binge, but it left me uneasy. Kris had always been

supremely practical. Yet, she'd just wasted time and money that we just didn't have on a bunch of random crap.

She'd also been in the bathroom forever.

"You okay in there?"

"I just need a few more minutes."

But it was more than a few. She'd been in there for almost an hour before I heard the shower go on, which was weird since she'd already showered today. Twenty more minutes. Then finally I heard the hair dryer.

I looked at my watch. It was past noon. We'd blown the whole morning already.

Kris stepped out of the bathroom, wrapped in a towel. I gasped.

"You like?" she asked.

She'd dyed her hair a rich, golden blond. She looked so hot, her Mediterranean complexion contrasting with her new lighter hair. I'd always had a weird thing for blondes, probably because my only experience had been with a brunette.

"Yeah. It's different. But you look great."

"Different is what I'm looking for."

She reached into one of the bags on the table and handed me a pair of thick rimmed, hipster glasses with clear glass lenses.

"Here, I got there for you," she said. "I know it feels Clark Kentish, but it'll definitely change your look."

"You're worried about being recognized?"

She nodded. "Sal, his guys... they're going to be looking for Jessi, and us. It'd be better if we weren't recognized, don't you think?"

"Makes sense."

She rustled through the bag again and pulled out a pair of panties. She dropped her towel, and I noticed she'd re-shaved her pussy. So much for letting it grow out. I didn't comment, though I did store that away for further consideration. She pulled on a pair of yoga pants that left nothing to the imagination. I could make out every curve, every detail of her anatomy. Every. A sports bra and a clingy top completed the outfit. I couldn't help but notice it was the same outfit Jessi had worn when she'd talked me into accompanying her to her gig.

"You okay?" she asked.

"I... um... you look great, but isn't that a little provocative?"

She put her hand on her hip.

"Well yeah, but that's the point. I'm pretty sure I'll get more answers poking around bodybuilder gyms and tattoos parlors dressed like this than in mom jeans and a sweatshirt."

It made sense. And yet, it made me uneasy. Kris is a hot chick. Well, she could have been. She certainly has the physical attributes: a great rack, a shapely ass, a pretty face, but I'd never known her to play up that side. Until the past week I think she always considered her sex appeal as an annoyance, something that she only deployed with me, in the privacy of our bedroom. But as I looked at my now blond wife, dressed head to toe in spandex, I realized something had changed in her.

"Um, okay," I replied. "So, am I supposed to wear the clothes you bought me as well?"

She shrugged. "I don't know that you need to. I think we'll see what we can turn up this afternoon, and then come back and change for our tour of bars and nightclubs this evening."

I put on my glasses and we went out.

I had made a couple of lists of places to check out. One of us would be on foot, the other in the car. After seeing Kris' attire, I decided it would be best if she was in the car rather than walking around.

As I stepped out of the car, I had a weird sense of foreboding. I had invested so much in getting Kris back that letting her walk away from me was almost physically painful. I knew that I wouldn't, couldn't, shouldn't want to remain tethered to her forever. But it was so soon and she was acting so... so peculiarly that it was unsettling.

As she drove off, in her tight outfit, with her blond hair, and her shaved crotch, I couldn't help but feel that something was off. She had just been taken for the better part of three days. She'd been forced to service several men orally and then repeatedly penetrated vaginally. She needed a doctor, a therapist, some sort of professional treatment. Instead, she was off conducting an investigation.

It all felt like some sort of crazy denial. Somehow our scheming allowed her to ignore what had happened to her. And yet, I knew it had to come to a head at some point.

It didn't take me long to realize how flawed our plan was. Unlike my search for Jessi, we had no real reason to think Damon would be at any of the places we'd identified. It was purely a case of judging a book by its cover. He looked like the kind of guy who might frequent a power lifting gym, or work as a tattoo artist or a bouncer, but really all I knew was what he looked like and the fact that he'd fucked Jessi at least twice. It was thin gruel.

Worse, as flawed as the plan was, it was even more difficult to execute. Searching Jessi's old lodgings, I'd use the lame excuse of looking for my cousin, a cover that fooled basically no one. It was only when I hit the strip clubs that I had a reasonable story—a thirty-something dude looking for a particular stripper is at least plausible.

I was at a complete loss as to what I might ask at the various gyms and tattoo parlors I visited.

Do you know a guy named Damon?

Why do you want to know?

I had no answer for that. Nothing beyond, *just because*.

The situation was even worse for Kris, who'd never even seen the guy and was just relying on my description of him. Every few minutes she'd send me a picture she'd taken surreptitiously of some dude who she thought fit my description. With each one, I would text back a brief explanation of why that wasn't the right guy. It was a tedious process, but over time, it helped hone his appearance enough in her mind that she began sending me fewer and better prospects. But even with that, no sign of Damon.

I had ultimately decided my best approach was simply to pretend to be a potential customer. That worked fairly well for the gyms, where it got me a full tour, albeit coupled with hard-sell pitches for why I should sign up now and pay a year in advance. But even still, I was very conscious of how little I was seeing, how much luck it would take to spot Damon, and recognize him, while on a quick facilities tour.

The tattoo parlors were an even harder nut to crack. Lacking any tattoos myself, it was a little hard to explain why I was seeking out these small, back-alley shops. My very presence seemed to inspire suspicion.

By the time I'd gotten to my third shop, I'd developed a bit of a rap. I had slipped off my wedding ring, and my story was that I was recently divorced, and finally free to get a tat, and I was looking for ideas. That gave

me a chance to look through their art books, scope out the staff, the customers, a bit.

It was a small place—they all were—but slightly better maintained than the others. It was the first place where I felt like the odds of contracting hepatitis was less than fifty-fifty.

There was a young tattoo artist, himself with ink covering almost every inch of skin, working on a pale, lank-haired teen. They both looked up at me with contemptuous sneers.

"What do you want?" The artist grunted between zaps of his tattoo gun.

Happily a slightly older man, looking like a 70s-era George Carlin, came out from behind the counter and said, "Don't mind him. He's good with the gun, but he doesn't know shit about customer service."

"Hey, there," I said.

I went into my spiel about divorce and wanting to get a tattoo. He handed me their art book and started talking me through options.

"Yeah, I've always wanted one, but the wife.... And to tell you the truth, I've never really know what I'd want to get, ya know?"

He laughed. "It's probably a good idea to think about it, though it's bad for business. Some days it seems like most of our work is fixing people's regrets."

I thumbed through the book, but stopped suddenly when I saw a salamander, an exact copy of the one on Jessi's leg.

"That's cool," I said, pointing.

He looked at me appraisingly. "I'm not sure that's you."

"I know, but I knew a girl once. Had that tat on her leg."

"Star?" he asked. "Stripper?"

I nodded.

"You her boyfriend or something?"

"Naw, she just showed me a good time one night."

He laughed. "That was my work. Gave it to her on her eighteenth birthday. She paid for it on the installment plan, two months of sucking and fucking. God damn, there is nothing like an eighteen year old twat."

I gave what I hoped sounded like a knowing chuckle.

"She still come around?"

"I wish. I'm guessing she's learned a trick or two over the years."

I shook his hand and left, telling him I was still on the fence. He didn't seem surprised.

I had gotten another interesting insight into Jessi, but was no closer to finding either her or Damon.

It was getting dark when I crossed off the last place on my list. I called Kris. She had just finished up as well. She picked me up and we drove back to the motel.

I was discouraged, but she was surprisingly charged up. In her mind, she seemed to think the day had been a success. We'd canvassed and crossed off our list two dozen establishments. She argued that meant we were that much closer to our goal.

Again, her attitude gave me a weird gnawing sensation. She didn't seem to be the same cautious, deliberative woman I'd known all these years. Our whole plan was a crazy gamble, but instead of shrinking from it, Kris seemed to almost be enjoying it. She reminded me suddenly of one of those people who refuse to leave the slot machine because having lost almost all their money, they now believe they are due.

"Are you okay?" I asked.

"Yeah. Today was interesting. Wow, lots of crazy people out there."

"Yeah?"

"Well, you saw them too. People covered head to toe in tats. Guys who seem to live in the gym. Everyone with crazy stories."

"I guess you were a big hit." All I'd gotten was a few sales pitches.

"You could say that." She laughed. She handed me a stack of papers: passes to various gyms, a free six month membership to another, coupons for tattoos, some of them just handwritten notes. Dozens of phone numbers, several with flirty notes attached.

I wondered, was she really optimistic? Or just getting off on the attention? And did it really matter either way? It occurred to me that if we struck out tonight, it might be worth it for her to check out my list as well.

Back at the motel, we changed into evening clothes, me in my new jeans and shirt. She was in a clingy dress, black, with a lace panel that

exposed her cleavage. She didn't look slutty, just sexy. Appropriate for a nightclub, maybe a little overdressed for a bar, though. But the idea of having her making rounds on her own dressed like that freaked me out a little. If she was pulling a lot of attention in her workout clothes, in this outfit she'd be fighting them off with a stick, except as far as I could tell, she hadn't packed a stick.

We'd toyed with the idea of Kris making a round of the strip clubs, but decided the smarter division of labor was for me to get those while she visited the dance clubs. We split the list of other bars.

By now she had a pretty good sense of what Damon looked like, so most of our communications were just informing each other of where we'd been.

I dropped by Satin Dolls again, sidled up to the bar. The same bartender was working again and recognized me. He poured me a beer.

"Hey man," he said. "Didn't think I'd see you again."

I tensed up.

"Why's that?"

"Thought you mighta moved in with Amber or something."

"She just gave me a dance."

"And then the two of you left within minutes of each other."

"I don't want to get her in trouble."

He laughed. "I don't own the place. I don't give a shit who the girls fuck."

I shrugged.

"Was she as good as I said?"

"Yeah, she was," I replied with a nod. Until she tasered me. "Why'd you ask if we moved in together?"

"Oh, she came in the next morning. Cleaned out her locker. Told some of the other girls she was going down to Vegas to dance for a few weeks. Taking time off from dancing usually means they've found a sugar daddy."

"Yeah?"

He laughed. "You don't really think they're working their way through school, do you? Most of 'em are just looking to get their meat

hooks into a rich dude, even if it's just for a few months."

It was my turn to laugh. "That rules me out. How about you, why are you working here?"

He shrugged. "Tips are pretty good. Club full of slutty, naked girls. Most of them are cool with hooking up."

"Makes sense. My stepbrother, Damon, worked in a strip club for a while, at least when he wasn't lifting, but it was the sort of thing we all whispered about. Not really Thanksgiving Dinner conversation, ya know?"

I was hoping for even a glimmer of recognition, but got nothing. "Yeah, well, I don't know that I still want to be working here when I'm forty. But for now it's a good time."

A dancer, a petite blonde, came over and sat down next to me. Her hand on my forearm, she said, "Hey, baby, can I join you?"

She was really young, but had dirty girl written all over her. I gave her a big smile. Part of maintaining my cover meant getting at least a dance.

In between clubs I checked my email. I had one from Sal. I opened it, found a short note:

Hey numb nuts, I hope you haven't forgotten about me. I sure as shit haven't forgotten about you and your two whores. Here's a little something to keep the memory alive.

It was a video. I knew what it would be before I opened it. Kris had warned me. But even still, I knew I'd need to look. I clicked on the icon.

It was a close up of Kris, naked, on her knees blowing Sal. Her mouth was stretched desperately around his girth. He was thrusting his cock past her full, red lips. Her fist looked tiny wrapped around his shaft, pumping up and down.

He zoomed in until I could see every ridge, every vein on his cock, could see her spit on his shaft, the bumps on her tongue as she licked him.

He withdrew his cock from her mouth.

"Open up, whore," he commanded.

She obeyed without question, sitting back on her heels, her mouth open wide, her tongue flattened over her lower lip, awaiting his come. He stroked himself firmly.

"Don't swallow yet."

She gave him a small submissive nod, and then he shot a thick rope of jism over her tongue.

"Oh yeah," he grunted. He spurted several more times, adding to the semen pooling on her tongue.

"Fuck, that's hot," he commented as his camera focused on the come in her mouth.

He zoomed back out, filming her pretty face, her naked body.

"Now swallow."

She closed her mouth and gulped it down, only a small narrowing of her eyes signaling her displeasure.

"Show me," he ordered.

She opened her mouth to demonstrate she'd obeyed him.

"You're a perfect little whore, you know that?"

She looked at him blankly, imperturbable. The video ended on that image.

Not for the first time, I thought how much I would like to bludgeon Sal to death with a heavy, blunt object.

CHAPTER TWELVE

I ended up hitting six strip clubs. I kept my eyes open. I tried the stepbrother opener a few times. But I didn't even get a nibble. Even still, I was in a good mood. Having had half a dozen pretty women rubbing themselves on me had that result. Even though I was paying for it, it still served as positive reinforcement. It occurred to me that I was feeling the same thing as had Kris this afternoon.

I had a list of bars to visit as well. I checked my watch. It was only a little after 11:00 pm. Plenty of time to knock them out before last call.

I was sitting at the first bar, nursing a beer, when a text came in from Kris.

-Him?

I gave the accompanying picture a quick glance, getting ready to explain why it wasn't. Except that I couldn't be sure.

-Where are you?

She sent me the address. It was just a few blocks away.

I texted back.

-I'll be right there. Meet me out front.

I paid my tab and walked over.

"I think that might be him," I said.

She lit up. "See, told you we'd find him."

"Okay, so how should we do this?"

"I'll go up the bar and get a drink," she began. "You put on your glasses and keep an eye on things."

"Okay."

She pulled out her phone and called me. I picked up. She muted me. "Okay, you can listen in. Give me a couple of minutes, then come in."

I nodded.

I dug my ear buds out of my pocket so I could listen without broadcasting to the rest of the bar. I walked in. The place was a more upscale than I would have expected, not as dark or loud as some other Iron City places. It had a long, polished wooden bar, with a gleaming brass railing. The bottles behind the bar shone, lined up on lit risers.

The crowd was eclectic, a mix of well-dressed couples, slutty party girls taking a break from dancing next door, and some younger frat-boy types in jeans and baseball caps. Obviously the bar's location made it a crossroads of the different clubs and nightspots in the neighborhood.

I took a spot at the wall railing, away from the bar, but with a perfect line of sight on Kris. She'd settled in on a barstool, her legs crossed, and her foot bouncing jauntily. The bartender approached. He was dressed in black pants and white shirt, rolled up to his elbows. His shirt looked like it was ready to split. It looked like Damon, and my judgment was confirmed when he introduced himself.

"Welcome to Bar Blue. My name's Damon, can I get you a drink?"

She gave him a big smile.

"I'm Tina," she replied. She held out her hand and they shook. "Can I get an Appletini?"

"Appletini for the pretty lady. Done," he replied flirtatiously.

He mixed it right in front of her.

"So is this your first time here? I don't think I've seen you before."

She giggled. "No, I've been here before. And I definitely noticed you."

I groaned. She was coming on awfully strong.

He seemed to eat it up, though.

"Why didn't you come over and say hi?"

He leaned on the bar, closing the distance between them.

"Oh, you were hanging out with some skinny brunette. She seemed like the jealous type."

He put her drink down in front of her and backed up a little. She didn't read his body language.

"You still an item with her? I don't want to get stabbed for talking to you."

He straightened up and regarded Kris skeptically. He slapped the bar with his open palm.

"Oh the house. But I need to get back to work. Enjoy your evening."

I sent Kris a text.

-Too strong.

-I know. Fuck. What now?

-Give it some time.

-Okay.

We'd found our guy. That was the good news. The bad news was that we didn't have a good plan for what to do now. We needed to get him talking about Jessi. But we didn't know whether he was still with her, or whether she had told him that she was hiding out. The biggest risk was that he'd get too suspicious, clam up on us, and at worst maybe even warn her that people were asking questions about her.

Kris' plan, such as it was, seemed to be to just hang around and see what happened. The downside from my perspective was that the minute Damon walked away, the sharks began to circle.

She was undeniably an attractive target. The blond hair, the cleavage, the sexy black pumps, dangling off her toes... it was all chum in the water.

Some of the come-ons were direct.

"Hi, I'm Bob, can I buy you a drink."

Others were lame.

"Do we know each other?"

Every time she came close to finishing her drink, there seemed to be a competition to send over a refreshment. She'd get her refill, give a little smile, and the next victim would come over to take a shot.

In each case, after a brief flirtation, Kris would send the new suitor away, making sure to cast Damon a quick glance as she did. The message was unmistakable. *They aren't whom I am interested in.*

He played it cool. Delivering her drinks without comment, but I could see him stealing a peek at her more and more often. She was definitely spiking his interest.

It was almost 1:00 before he came back over.

"So, what does your hubby think about you spending hours in bar, getting hit on?"

She laughed. She waved her ring finger at him. "Oh these? I just wear them so I can have an excuse when I don't want attention."

"Well, but now that I know that, you can't use that excuse on me."

"Who says I want to?" She batted her eyelashes at him.

"You don't know anything about me."

"And you don't know anything about me," she replied with a laugh. "And yet, here we are, sharing a moment."

"Is that what this is?"

She shrugged.

A couple sat down at the bar. Kris nodded in their direction. "Looks like you have some business."

I had to admit, she'd played that very well. Sucked him in and then dismissed him. He'd definitely be back. But then what? How was she going to get him to talk about Jessi?

She shot me a quick glance. She was obviously pleased with herself.

I texted.

-what now?

-I don't know. I don't want to spook him.

The guy was a bruiser. 250 pounds of muscle. And we were afraid of scaring him.

-you should get his number

-yeah, but I don't want to let him out of my sight. He feels like our last shot at Jess.

She looked back toward me. I gave her a quick nod.

Last call was coming fast. Soon we'd be kicked out and he'd be closing up.

I texted back.

-invite him to an after-hours club? There's one down the street.

-okay. I'll try.

At 1:30 they announced last call. At 2:00 they shooed me out of the bar, though they let her stay as he cleaned up.

I couldn't just stand out there on the sidewalk, so I walked down toward The Early Worm, the after-hours club a block away. I paid my twenty-five dollar membership and ordered a beer at the bar. The place was decorated like a 1920s speakeasy, with rough-hewn tables, and jazz on the stereo.

As I settled in, it occurred to me that I hadn't heard anything on my ear buds for the past several minutes. I wondered if I could get reception down here. I pulled out my phone and realized it had shut off. Fucking iPhones and their crappy battery life, I cursed.

I called over the bartender and asked if he had a charger. He rolled his eyes, but grabbed a charger from beside the cash register. He plugged it in under the bar and handed me the cable.

I plugged in my phone. I tried to turn it on, but it took an infuriatingly long time to come to life. It was probably just a few seconds, but I realized it had been almost fifteen minutes now since I'd heard from Kris. Finally the silver Apple logo appeared and then my phone came on. I waited as it searched for the network. Connection. Whatever.

My phone buzzed five times in quick succession. Five texts.

-So what do you think?

-Oh fuck, we lost our connection. He invited me to his place.

-Daniel? What now?

-Decided to invite him back to our place.

-Daniel, where are you?

The last text was time stamped eight minutes earlier.

I tried to call her, but her phone went right to voicemail. I groaned. She was probably out of juice as well by now.

I didn't have the car keys. I didn't even know if she'd left the car behind or whether she'd driven then back to the motel. I called a cab. They said it would arrive within fifteen minutes. Fuck fuck fuck. But there was nothing else to do but wait. I downed my beer, paid, and went out front to wait.

The cab company was better than promised. They showed up in twelve minutes. But I was now a good twenty minutes behind Kris. I was tempted to offer money for him to burn lights, but realized that getting pulled over would be the worst-case scenario.

It was 2:27am when we pulled up to the motel.

I was frantic, but still forced myself to be quiet as I entered the room. I needn't have bothered.

The living room/kitchenette was dark, but there was a light coming out of the bedroom. I don't know if Kris had consciously planned that, but it meant I could creep right up and look into the bedroom from the darkened living room.

I didn't need to look in, though, to know what was going on. His grunts, her moans, the sound of the bed squeaking told the whole story. Still, I couldn't resist peering in.

She was riding him, sitting upright, her hands massaging his chest, his mauling her big breasts.

"Oh fuck, I love your muscles," she moaned. She bounced up and down, impaling herself roughly on his big cock.

She was rubbing him all over, feeling his hard chest, the swells of his powerful arms. He was built like a power lifter, rather than a body builder. He wasn't a cover model, just a big, beefy, strong guy. He was enjoying her body as well, playing with her tits, squeezing her ass.

He grabbed her by the waist, held her still, and then pounded her roughly from beneath. She squealed, over and over, her head thrown back, her long, blond hair dangling down her back.

He released her and she immediately went back to fucking him, leaning forward until her breasts dangled in his face, twerking on his fat cock. He took her areola into his mouth, his cheeks hollowing out as he sucked her engorged nipple roughly.

Suddenly, he sat upright and swung his legs off the bed. He lifted her up effortlessly as he stood. Standing, with his tree trunk legs firmly planted on the ground, he bounced her up and down on his cock, masturbating into her pussy, using her like a sex toy. And to my shock, she loved it.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God," she gasped wheezily.

She threw back her head as her body convulsed in his arms. He took advantage to suck on her throat.

She was still in a daze as he walked her into the wall and pounded into her violently. His fat dick churned into her pussy explosively, the wet, squishing sounds a testament to her excitement. It looked like he was trying to fuck her straight through the wall. She rested her head on his shoulder, her face red, her hair increasingly matted to her forehead with sweat. Not surprisingly, the people next door hammered back from their side, yelling at my wife and Damon to shut up.

Kris laughed. He kissed her wetly. In a weird way that felt like even more of a betrayal than the sex.

"Damn, you're hot," he sighed.

She giggled. They kissed again. I was struck by how effortless he held her off the ground. It was obvious that she was also very turned on by his physique, his strength.

He spun her around and walked her over to the bed, body-slamming her onto her back as he settled between her legs. She pulled her thighs to her chest, her toes pointing in the air, opening herself completely to him.

Her drove his cock into her roughly. She gasped, her mouth lolling open.

"I'm gonna wear you out," he growled.

"Yes!" she hissed.

He reached up with one powerful arm and grabbed the headboard for leverage. He fucked her even harder, brutally. She reached up with both hands, to keep him from driving her skull into the headboard. His cock was a blur. His muscular ass clenching with each thrust.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God," she cried out.

Her body convulsed again. She was soaked with sweat, both her own and his that dripped from his forehead down between her wildly shaking breasts. He was beginning to gasp, grunt with effort, but he didn't slow the pace at all, if anything he seemed to speed up.

"Oh God, you're amazing!" she screamed.

The compliment seemed to set him off. He roared in passion, pounded into her even harder. The bed creaked ominously, and then with a loud crack, the footboard split into two, sending the foot of the bed crashing into the floor.

He didn't even slow. With the bed now slanted at a thirty-degree angle, he dug his toes into the mattress and continued to slam into her. Her head swung from side to side, her wet hair whipping through the air. I'd never seen her this wild, this fully given over to her passions. It was incredibly erotic and terrifying at the same time.

He was getting closer, his thrusts still brutal, but less fluid, more frantic. He slammed into her one, two, three more times, and then with his cock fully lodged in my wife's pussy, he reached down and grabbed her ass as his body shuddered over and over.

As if to punctuate his climax, the rest of the bed gave way with another crash, dropping the mattress flat on the floor. The both laughed, and then he began slowly churning his cock inside her as they kissed passionately. For a while it seemed as though he was planning on transitioning right into round two without a break.

Thankfully, after a few minutes, he rolled off her. They lay side-by-side, their bodies sweaty, both of them breathing hard. They held hands.

"God, that was good," Kris cooed.

He just smiled.

"I can't believe any woman would walk away from that."

"Well some girls are more turned on by a fat wallet than a fat..." he trailed off with a laugh.

"Is that what happened with your last girl?"

Still in the afterglow of coming, he was completely unguarded. "Something like that, I guess. I don't really know. I think one of her old boyfriends came back into her life or something."

I could see the look of frustration on Kris' face. Here was another person to track down, and we didn't even have a name or description. But for me it was suddenly a moment of joy. Not only was I impressed that Kris had immediately gone back to probing him for information, but I also realized he'd given us more than he could realize.

It all made sense. 2C, 1405, "meat hooks," "fat wallet," "investing in the future..." Somehow all those fragments came together and I realized what Jessi had been up to and how we could find her.

I peered into the bedroom again. Kris' phone was on the bedside table, charging. Again, I was reminded that she hadn't just succumbed to her passions, but had been calculating throughout.

I sent her a text.

-Get his number and get rid of him. I think I know how to find Jessi.

"What was that?" he asked.

"My best friend. It's an emergency. You're going to need to go."

He laughed. "Damn girl, you're cold. Is that it, you get what you want and out I go?"

She leaned over and kissed him. "You're amazing. Leave me your number, but yeah, you need to go."

"You sure I can't tempt you into another go?" He asked. His beefy hand slipped between her legs, a finger sliding into her well-used pussy.

"I'm very tempted," she moaned. "But not right now. This has been fun. Let's end tonight on a good note. Okay?"

He sighed. "Alright. But I'm gonna see you again."

"You better," she replied, giving his fat cock a playful squeeze.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

When the door closed behind him, I climbed out of the closet in which I'd hidden, giving Kris a start. She was wrapped in a towel, still dripping in sweat, looking unmistakably freshly fucked.

"Sorry about that," I said.

She looked at me, trying to appraise my mood.

"How long have you been here?"

"Somewhere between too long and just long enough."

"I'm sorry. I didn't know what else to do. I had to get him talking. Get him comfortable."

"I know. I don't blame you," I replied, thinking of my own time with Amber. It did occur to me that this was her payback.

"We're really through the looking glass."

"Yeah. Although I'm not even quite sure what that means."

She laughed. A single tear ran down her cheek. "I think it is from some book."

For a few minutes we just stared at each other. We were fighting to recover our old lives, but with every step, every action, every decision, we were moving further away from that goal, becoming different people. She was obviously thinking the same thing.

Finally, she shook her head. "So, where do we find Jessi?"

"I think she went back to her drug dealer boyfriend."

She sighed. "But you have no idea. This is just a guess."

"It is... but in a weird way, these last few days I think I've really come to understand Jessi."

She snorted. "What is there to understand? She's a spoiled brat."

"Maybe," I replied noncommittally. I didn't really want to get into all my thoughts about Jessi just now. I knew that if I tried to explain too much, Kris would just dismiss it.

"But look," I continued. "That place she was living. That high rise I told you about. That was like night and day from everything else in her life. I think she wants to get back to that. Will do anything to get there."

"Okay," she replied, skeptically. "But even if that is true, how does that help us?"

I pulled up a web browser on my phone and typed in "Crystal Heights drug arrest."

It came up right away, a news story from nearly two months ago.

Residents of the exclusive Crystal Tower apartments were awakened early this morning by the sounds of police raiding their high rise... DeMarcus Martin, 36, was taken into custody and charged with possession with intent to distribute a large quantity of cocaine... In addition to twenty kilos of cocaine, with a street value of \$1.5 million, authorities also recovered \$330,000 in cash... The arrest caps a two-year long investigation into drug sales at various nightclubs in the notorious Iron City district.

I next typed "DeMarcus Martin" into the search bar. Several stories came up.

The first concerned his arraignment:

Drug kingpin DeMarcus Martin was denied bail today... District Judge Melvin Warren accepted the argument made by Assistant District Attorney Blanche Greenlees that Martin was a flight risk... Martin's attorney Anthony Brown promised to appeal the decision.

The next was a backgrounder:

DeMarcus Martin's road from noted high school basketball prospect to regional drug lord...

I decided to skip that one.

The last story was a short follow-up piece dated today.

Drug kingpin DeMarcus Martin due back in court Monday for a new bail hearing after his attorney filed a brief alleging a civil rights violation in the case...

I pulled up Judge Warren's docket. Martin was scheduled to be in court at 9:30 am. I looked at the time on my phone. That was 30 hours away.

"You think she'll be at the hearing?" Kris asked.

"I'd bet on it."

"Okay, so what do we do next?"

"Well I think we get a few hours' sleep and then go see the kids at my sister's. Then we need to go shopping."

"Yeah?"

"Well, you have stuff to dress as a fitness instructor and a party girl. I think we need to outfit you as a reporter. That'll allow you to poke around and ask questions of the DA and Martin's attorney at the very least."

Kris went to take a shower. I walked into the bedroom. It was a disaster. The bed was shattered, the mattress and box spring on the floor. The sheets were half torn off, wet with sweat, smelling of sex. I finished stripping the bed and laid out a couple of towels on the stained mattress.

Kris appeared wrapped in a towel. She seemed surprised at the mess.

I couldn't help but chuckle. "Why are you shocked? You're the one who trashed the place."

"I had help."

"I saw."

She looked down. "Do you hate me?"

"How could I?" I realized my answer was ambiguous, probably because my emotions were as well. Was I saying that because of my own actions? Watching Jessi? Fucking Amber? Or did I mean that there was nothing she could do to make me hate her, that I would always love her, had always loved her since I was thirteen? Or was I acknowledging that she'd just done what she had to do with Damon to get a lead on Jessi?

She seemed to understand my confusion. Of course, she would. No one in the world knew me better. In many ways, I think she knew me better than I knew myself.

But even still, I had a question, and I needed an answer.

"Were you faking?"

"Yes..." she began though she was shaking her head at the same time. "Daniel, please don't."

I waved my hand around calling attention to our surroundings. "Kris, we have no home. Our kids are with my sister. We've probably lost our jobs. All we have is each other. We can't have secrets."

She looked down. Didn't answer.

"So, Kris, how much of that was fake?"

She looked up at me sadly. She sighed. "Jesus, Daniel..."

I just held her gaze.

"None of it. Okay? It was all real."

"You really loved it?" I asked, trying to hide my pain.

"Yes. Does that make me a bad person?"

"No.... Have you always wanted that? Rough sex with a muscular stranger?"

She laughed darkly. "You make it sound so tawdry."

I waved my hand around the room again.

She nodded. "Okay, this is pretty tawdry."

She paused. Continued, "Okay, Daniel, yes, sometimes I've fantasized about that. We were together so young. And you're wonderful. So kind, so loving. But sometimes I was jealous of Jessi, of her experience, of the kind of dangerous men she attracted."

I didn't say anything.

She went on, "I love your body. I love how fit you are, trim, neat, but yes, if I think of another man, it is a man like Damon. Muscular, dangerous."

"Strong?"

She sighed sultrily. "Yes. I was like a feather to him."

"Come here," I said after a pause.

She melted into my arms. I held her close.

"I love you, no matter what, even if you dream about having sex with men like Damon."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

She let her towel drop to the floor. And then she followed.

"You don't need to," I said.

"Please let me," she replied.

She unbuttoned my pants, pulled down my zipper. She yanked my pants and boxers down, and without hesitation swallowed me deep into her mouth. She'd never done this for me before. Yes, of course, she'd performed oral on me, but only in bed, under the covers, as part of foreplay. She had never dropped to her knees and just sucked me off.

I hated it. Hated feeling like I was taking advantage of her, like she was servicing me. And yet I loved it. It was so raw. So slutty. And it felt so good. The first blowjob years ago was such a distant memory. Over time Kris had become a wonderful little cocksucker.

Fuck, had I just thought that? And yet, how else to describe her. She was naked, on her knees, sucking my cock even as her pussy probably still throbbed from the pounding she'd just taken from another man.

I was rock hard. Was it from her efforts? Or was her session with Damon continually replaying in my mind? Jesus, they'd broken the bed. Fucked so hard that they actually shattered a bed. Who does that?

She swallowed me whole, balls deep, her mouth buried in my pubic hair. That was something new. She had always stopped halfway before. Sal and his buddies had trained her well. It was a dark thought, and yet I enjoyed the feeling of being completely inside her mouth. Her tongue swirled around my shaft, her hands fondled my balls.

"Oh God, that's nice," I moaned.

She let my cock slide partly from her mouth. She looked up at me submissively, pumped my shaft with her fist. It was the same thing she'd done to Sal when she'd swallowed his come, that night in our living room when the whole nightmare had begun. She was offering me the same.

"You sure?"

She answered by stroking me harder.

I came with a shudder. She gulped down my load. And after I was done, she continued to lick my cock clean, picking off the last few drops of my jism with her tongue.

I dropped to the floor and wrapped my arms around her protectively. I led her over to the bed. I turned out the light and drew the blinds against the brightening sky. Then we snuggled together until we each drifted off to sleep.

We only slept a few hours. We both wanted to get on the road to see the kids.

As I drove, Kris worked some logistics. She tracked down the number of the publisher of the East Side Patch, an online community newsletter that covered Crystal Heights. She reached him at home.

She introduced herself as an out-of-work reporter living in the area. She said she was interested in getting back into writing and wanted to see if she could join their staff as a volunteer. They had just done through their second round of layoffs, so he was delighted to get some free labor.

She mentioned her desire to write about the DeMarcus Martin case, a follow-up on the story. He agreed to call down to the District Court first thing in the morning to get her press credentials.

We spent the day with my mother, sister, and the kids. They were shocked to see Kris as a blond, though they kept their worries to themselves. It was obvious we were mixed up in something bad, but I guess they felt that as long as Kris and I were in it together, we'd be okay. I felt the same way.

We were playing with the kids when an email from Sal came it. I excused myself to read it. I already knew what it would be. A second video.

This one featured Kris on her hands and knees getting double-teamed by Rock and Jerry, one in her mouth, the other in her pussy. They were being rough with her. Jerry gripped her head, sawed his cock into her mouth. Drool dripped from her chin.

They switched sides, Rock now face fucking her as he yanked on her hair. Jerry, pounding her pussy, was calling her a "dirty whore" and worse.

After seeing her with Damon, I knew she could take it, take anything they could dish out. She didn't resist. As she'd warned me, it looked almost as if she were a willing participant. And yet, she'd lied as well. She hadn't completely submitted.

They wanted her to whine, squeal in pain, to beg for mercy. And when she didn't, they just got rougher. They switched sides again. Jerry forced himself balls deep into her mouth, held her there. Then he pinched her nose shut, cutting off her air. Her face turned red, then scarlet. But still she refused to struggle. She didn't claw at him, didn't try to push him away. She'd have let him choke her out rather than give him what he wanted.

Rock finally shoved Jerry away. Kris took a desperate gasp of air. And then without hesitation sucked Jerry back into her mouth. When Jerry came in her mouth a minute later, I thought I saw a small grin of satisfaction on her face.

We stayed for dinner, put the kids to bed, and drove back late. Leaving the kids yet again was insanely painful. It sapped us of the ability to speak. We drove home in silence.

I picked up a new set of sheets from the front office. We made the bed and collapsed into it.

From her breathing, I could tell that Kris wasn't asleep. I was tempted to ask her what she was thinking about, but decided to respect her privacy. I was, anyway, lost in my own thoughts.

I knew there were more videos coming. She had warned me, and anyway, it was obvious that Sal was an obsessive videographer. That didn't bother me much. I doubted he could show me anything that would shock me. But it was precisely that fact that disturbed me.

I was at the point where I could take pride in my wife's ability to take a rough fucking without complaint. The perversity of that made me feel sick.

I thought back to that heartbreaking scene in *Saving Private Ryan*, where Tom Hanks is talking about how much he's changed in the war. He wonders if his wife will recognize him. He says, "Every man I kill, the farther away from home I feel." I sort of felt that way. With every new compromise, every new transgression, I felt further away from home.

And yet, I wasn't. Kris was right there beside me. But was she still my Kris. Was I still her Daniel? I didn't know. Couldn't know until this was all over. I slid my hand across the gap between us, touched her palm. She closed her hand on mine. At least for now, we were still together. But how much more could we survive?

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Kris got up early and picked up a simple skirt, blouse, and pair of flats at Wal-Mart. We'd forgotten to shop earlier. That was okay. She was supposed to look like a reporter for a web site, not a fashion model.

We drove to the courthouse and separated. She went to the media office and picked up her credentials. She was then going to see if she could meet with the DA or anyone else connected with the case.

I cautiously prowled the halls looking for signs of Jessi. It occurred to me that I didn't really know what I would do if I saw her. There was no real way I could compel her to come with me as long as we were in the building, so I realized that even if we did spot her at the hearing, we'd probably have to trail her somewhere else.

I didn't run into her though, and instead, found myself wandering into Judge Warren's courtroom early.

It really isn't like it seems on TV. At the very least it wasn't today. He seemed to be processing various administrative matters, and there were at least a half dozen conversations going on simultaneously, some between the judge and attorneys, others in a cluster by the clerk's table, and then more casual meetings being in various corners of the room.

I sat in the visitor's section just taking in this beehive of activity. For most of these people it was just a day at the office. But I would have been completely lost. I didn't even notice that Kris was also in the room until she sent me a text.

-Jessi's almost here.

I brought my hand to my forehead and peered through my fingers at the door. After a few seconds, sure enough, it opened and in walked Jessi, followed by a stocky, powerfully built African-American man in what looked like a very expensive suit.

He ushered her into the courtroom and directed her to sit in the first row of the gallery right behind the defendant's table. They'd cleaned her up nicely. She was wearing a simple navy blue suit, and had her hair in a ponytail. She'd gone back to her natural hair color, brown, without the violet streak, which seemed ironic since Kris was still sporting her showy

blond locks. Gone was bad girl Jessi, replaced with a cute, fresh-faced kid who could have easily blended in on any college campus.

Her head swiveled to the right and I followed her gaze to the side of the courtroom where another door opened and disgorged a half dozen men in shackles. While the courtroom itself was filled with a mix of men and women of various races, it was noticeable that all the men brought in were either black or Hispanic. A courtroom remains the place where racial divides are still most apparent in modern America.

Jessi gave a small wave. A handsome black man gave her a quick nod. He had a shaved head, and the long, lanky build of the basketball player he'd been in his youth. But he also had the cold hard stare of a seasoned con.

I texted back to Kris.

-What's going on?

-I'm not sure. But the DA is pissed. Said she'd talk to me after the hearing.

It all moved very quickly. The clerk called Martin's case. He was led over to the defendant's table where he conferred quickly with his lawyer.

DeMarcus gave Jessi a quick grin and mouthed, "Good girl."

It was ostensibly a short hearing to address a defense request for reduction of bail.

The prosecutor protested. She argued, "DeMarcus Martin is facing a mandatory 30 year sentence if convicted. He is known to have resources and is at high risk of flight."

Anthony Brown, the defense attorney, countered that Martin had no resources. They'd all been seized by the state. "And further, given credible allegations of racially motivated entrapment in this case, Mr. Martin deserves the opportunity to try to post bond and remain at liberty to prepare his defense."

The DA sighed. "Your honor, the allegations are far from credible..."

The judge cut her off. "Yes, I know your views on this, but unfortunately given prior conduct of the Metropolitan Police Department, this court has no choice but to take into account the possibility. But we also agree with your concerns about the flight risk posed by the defendant. In light of that, we will grant the request for bail, and set the amount at two million dollars."

I chuckled to myself. Successful drug dealer or not, coming up with two million dollars seemed likely to be an impossible task. But then I noticed the smiles at the defense table.

I didn't have much time to consider it though. Martin was quickly led back into the holding area. And just as quickly his attorney took Jessi by the arm and led her from the courtroom.

-Follow them. Kris texted.

I was hoping they would split up quickly, so I'd have a chance to grab Jessi on her own. But instead, they stayed together, whispering urgently back and forth. I worried that they'd get into a waiting car and drive away. Brown handed his briefcase to an associate and led Jessi out of the courthouse. We were parked right around the corner, so there was a chance I could keep up with her in traffic, but I didn't have to worry about that because instead they set off on foot.

I trailed them carefully, though I probably didn't need to since they never looked around to see if anyone was following them. They looped around the back of the courthouse and we came upon a row of storefronts for people down on their luck—low rent lawyers, pay day lenders, pawn shops, and several bail bondsmen. It was a reminder that the justice system sucked in people through the front door and spit them out the backdoor broken.

They walked into a bondsman shop near the end of the block, Ramirez Brothers Bonds. I continued in the same direction, walking past the shop. Brown and Jessi were sitting in hard plastic chairs near the front of the shop. As I peered in, I saw two closed office doors. It seemed they were waiting for a meeting.

I reached the end of the block and took a right, then ducked into the alley that ran behind the narrow row of shops. I wished I'd brought my gun with me, but hadn't since I knew we'd be searched going into the courthouse. Even still, I was curious to see if I could get a view into one of those offices.

I reached the back of the bondsman's shop. There was a dumpster outside, wedged against the wall, giving access to two small, high, barred windows. I pulled myself up onto the dumpster. The left window was painted over with black. But the right one was cracked open.

I peer in and saw a corpulent Hispanic man in a pale yellow shirt sitting behind a desk, shifting through some papers. He stood suddenly and

I ducked back, worried he might have heard me, but instead he walked to the door.

"Get in," he said tersely.

I peered back inside to see Jessi walking into the room alone. In her fresh-scrubbed, preppy attire, she looked completely out of place, especially next to Ramirez who looked even shabbier standing up. Though I was standing on a dumpster, he looked like he'd rolled in one. There wasn't any part of him that wasn't stained. His khakis had stains at his crotch, there were the remnants of some sort of salsa on his distended belly, and his armpits were a puke green color.

She extended her hand. He just looked at it disdainfully. She sheepishly withdrew the offer.

"Thank you for seeing me. I wanted to explain why you should write a bond for DeMarcus Martin."

"I know why you're here."

"So, I know it is a lot of money, but I know DeMac isn't going to run. He knows he can beat this."

Ramirez laughed. "You don't think Tony Brown brought you around to talk, do you?"

"I don't know..."

"Shut up," he growled.

He stepped up close.

"So you're really Martin's girlfriend? Not just some whore he sent around?"

She nodded.

He laughed. "So, you got some of that jungle fever, girlie? Get some big black cock up inside of you and you think you're in love."

She didn't reply.

"Strip," he ordered.

She sighed, look up at the ceiling. I ducked away from the window. When I risked peering inside again, she'd begun resignedly removing her clothes. She did it briskly, efficiently. As she slipped off her panties, he circled around her.

"You did that too easily to not be a whore," he said accusingly.

"I'm his girlfriend," she replied.

"You're a piece of ass, that's all I know."

He ran his hands over her, casually feeling her up. He pinched her nipples, squeezed her firm ass. He traced the outlines of her tattoos. He ran his hand down between her legs, brusquely shoved a finger inside her. She flinched.

"What's the matter, slut? You don't like me? You only get wet for coon dick?"

She didn't reply.

He continued to molest her roughly.

"You're a tight little whore. He hasn't worn you out yet."

He pulled out his finger and smelled it. He smiled lewdly then ran his digit over her lips. He pressed it into her mouth.

"I bet you love tasting yourself, don't you."

She defiantly remained silent.

He walked over to his desk and pulled out a pair of handcuffs.

"You don't need those," she said softly.

"You're going to like this," he said with a dark laugh that made it clear he meant just the opposite.

She shuddered slightly, but didn't resist as he walked behind her and cuffed her hands behind her back. He walked back around and stood before her.

"Now, we're gonna have some fun."

Suddenly, he brought his right hand up and savagely slapped her across the face. It sounded like a gunshot. She gasped, crumpled to the floor like a sack of potatoes.

I stared in shock. He'd just smacked her without warning, without provocation. I was stunned. I had to stop it, couldn't just let him beat her like that. But before I could do anything, Jessi looked up at him with a mocking smirk.

"You hit like a girl," she taunted.

He roared with laughter. "Yeah, we're gonna have a lot of fun."

He grabbed her ponytail, lifting her off the floor by her hair. She winced in pain, but didn't cry out. He walked her backward and shoved her against his desk. The edge dug into her ass, her arms flailed behind her searching for the surface to keep her from falling backwards. Her face was red. She was gasping for breath, nostrils flaring. Strand of hair that had escaped her ponytail were splattered against her sweaty forehead. She had

an angry, feral look in her eyes. And despite all that, or maybe because of it, she was shockingly alluring.

He unbuckled his thick belt, and slowly pulled in through the loops. He folded it in two, grabbed the buckle in his hand, and slapped her hard across the left breast with the heavy leather. She winced, letting out a hissing gasp. He whipped her right breast next.

He forced her legs apart with his knee. He caressed her with the belt, running it over her cheeks, throat, down over her battered breasts, her flat belly. He placed the thick leather against her pussy. She knew what was coming next. Her body shuddered slightly.

Then he grinned again and with a quick snap of his wrist brought down the strap hard against her sex. She grunted in pain, her eyes rolling momentarily back into her head. He whipped her pussy again.

He dropped his pants, spit into his palm. He coated his prick in saliva and then stepped forward between her legs. He rubbed his cockhead up and down her slit. Just as Kris' pussy lips had molded themselves to Sal's cock, so did Jessi's to Ramirez's. He rammed his prick deep inside her.

"Fuck yeah," he groaned.

I'd seen enough. Too much. I jumped off the dumpster and paced in the alley. I thought of bursting into the shop, tearing Ramirez off her, beating him to a pulp. The fantasy only made me feel worse, a reminder of the shortcomings.

My phone vibrated with an incoming text.

-Well?

I replied. *-Still tracking her. You done?*

-Yeah

-Bring the car around the back of the courthouse. Park near the pawnshop on the corner.

I quickly walked back around to the street. I paused to look at the assortment of items in the pawnshop window, keeping my eyes on the bondsman's storefront. Sure enough, Brown and Jessi emerged a few minutes later. I was worried they might go somewhere else now, but Brown just gave Jessi a small pat on the shoulder and then turned and walked away. Apparently her sacrifice had closed the deal.

Jessi stood there for a moment, seemingly still in shock. She glared angrily back over her shoulder into the shop. Then she turned toward the lawyer and squinted at him. It was like she was cataloguing her enemies. I realized that at some point she was likely to snap, and woe to whomever was the object of her ire at that moment. I heard a car pull behind me. I glanced back at Kris and nodded toward Jessi. She drove half way up the block so that her sister was now bracketed between us.

Jessi turned and began to walk away from me. I closed the distance between us quickly.

"Hey Jess," I said.

She startled. "Oh, fuck it's you. I am not in the fucking mood right now."

"You're coming with me."

She laughed. "You're not really trying a street abduction are you?"

But despite her dismissive tone, I could see her eyes darting left and right, looking for an escape route. And then suddenly she turned. I reached for her, but she eluded my grasp. She took a quick step and ran flush into Kris.

"Not this time, you little cunt," Kris growled. "Get in the fucking car."

It took a moment for Jessi to recognize her sister. But when she did she folded. She stopped struggling and nodded. They climbed in the back together and I got behind the wheel.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The drive back to the motel started in silence, neither Kris nor I knowing quite how to begin.

Finally, Jessi broke the ice. "So, what happens now? You hand me over to Sal and he chains me to bed and sells my ass for a quarter a pop until he's paid off?"

"You seemed perfectly willing for that to be my fate," Kris answered bitterly.

"It was just for a couple of days."

Kris snorted. "So whoring me out for a few days was a small price to pay, huh?"

"Jesus, Kris. I had no idea he'd come after you. How the fuck could I have known?"

"Even after you found out..." she stopped. "Screw it. We'll deal with that later. So, it's been a few days now. You ready to repay Sal?"

"It took longer than I expected. But yeah. Well, I mean, I'll be able to tomorrow. But you're gonna need to let me go."

"No way," I grumbled from the front seat.

"What happens tomorrow?" Kris asked more productively.

"Well, duh, DeMac gets out on bail. He owes me."

"You used the drugs to raise bail money?" I asked.

"Yeah, well, traded them to... never mind. The less you know the better."

Kris replied, "Sorry, Jess, but you're gonna need to do better than that."

"What difference does it make who I gave the shit to? All you need to know is that DeMac's gonna make bail."

"So all of this, the stealing, the lying was all about getting your drug-dealer boyfriend out of jail?"

"Like I say, he owes me."

Kris snorted. "And what if he doesn't feel that way? Even if you can somehow pay off Sal, you've pissed off cops and a perjury rap hanging over you now."

"What?" I asked.

"Oh," Kris answered. "That was what this morning was about. Little miss brain surgeon signed an affidavit claiming that DeMarcus is just an innocent victim of entrapment. Claims she heard the arresting officers gloating about it."

"So much for ever having the cops on our side," I sighed.

Jessi laughed darkly. "Oh please, like the cops would ever have been on my side. A white stripper shackled up with a black drug dealer? I've never had the cops be on my side."

"Who the fuck's fault is that Jess? You've been a train wreck since you were in middle school."

"Oh yeah, 'cause you're perfect."

"I'm not perfect. But perfect is a far cry from getting high, turning tricks."

"You know what, Kris? Fuck you. You've always been a judgmental bitch."

"Poor Jessi, always the victim. You don't want to be judged? Then don't make such bad choices."

Jessi shook her head. "You're just like everyone else. So fucking smug, so fucking clueless. Yeah, I fucked for money. Funny about that. If you sell your ass for a hit of crack, you're worthless. Subhuman. Street trash. Sell it for a new TV, and you're lazy and greedy. Sell it to feed your child, and suddenly you're a tragic figure rather than evil. Desperate. Maybe even noble. And if you fuck to protect your kids, you're a fucking hero. A saint. That's you, right Kris? A fucking hero. And me, I'm just a lazy bitch. But what you did with Sal is no different from what I've done. We both got our twats stuffed. The only difference is what we got in return."

"You're sick," Kris hissed.

"Whatever. I did what I had to do."

"Had to do? You didn't have to start fucking grown men when you were still a girl. You didn't have to move out at sixteen—"

"No, I could have stayed there, with them," she said with a hiss.

"What, Mom and Dad?"

"Yeah, Mom, fucking sleeping a week at a time, bouncing off the fucking walls, repainting the whole house when she was up. Dad fucking drunk off his ass all the time."

"You're exaggerating," Kris snapped.

"They got worse after you left. They just pulled it together when you'd come around. Perfect Kris, everyone always had to be on their perfect behavior when you came to visit. But when you weren't there it was an insane asylum."

Kris sighed. "God, Jess, what is this, another one of your little fantasies?"

"What do you know? You scooted. Abandoned me when I was nine."

"What did you expect me to do? Take you with me to college?"

"You could have done something."

"I'm your sister, not your mother."

"Yeah, our mother was crazy, and you were perfectly happy to run away and leave me behind."

The car became silent, and when I looked into the back seat, Kris and Jessi had moved as far apart as possible, both staring silently out of their respective windows.

I understood Kris' position. And yet, there was something about Jessi's anger that suddenly rang true. Their house had always seemed weird. Their dad was sullen, reclusive; their mom, in retrospect, had some form of bipolar disorder. It must have been a miserable existence, especially if they got worse over time.

Kris, of course, never knew anything different, although even she had basically been adopted into my family early on. But Jessi... When Kris left home, she'd lost her big sister, her surrogate mother. She looked for love in the wrong places. Kris had found me. Nerdy, stable me. Jessi had found trouble and it had continued to follow her for the rest of her life.

We got to the motel and proceeded to the room. Once inside, Jessi locked herself in the bathroom.

"Are you going to be okay?" I asked Kris.

She shook her head. "Oh God Daniel. Somehow, I thought that if we found Jessi, all of this... all of this would just clear up. Now it's like we need to broker some sort of deal between a couple of drug dealers."

"You think this DeMarcus guy is going to come through?"

"Of course not. This is just part of Jessi's long line of bad decisions in regard to men."

I wondered how she thought Damon fit into that, but I didn't raise it.

"So what do we do?"

"I guess we have to go see DeMarcus when he gets out."

"We?" I asked.

"We can't just let her go off on her own."

"She's not going to like that idea."

"Too bad," replied Kris coldly.

I changed topics. "What did you think about what she said in the car?"

Kris sighed. "Oh Daniel. You know how many times I've thought of that? Thought that maybe I could have kept her on the straight and narrow? Thought that I let her down."

"It's not your fault."

"No, I know. She's a manipulative little bitch, and part of that was just to get under my skin. But she's right in a way. I was so happy to get out, to be on my own. And she started getting into trouble so young. Even the idea of doing anything for her seemed overwhelming."

"She made a lot of bad choices."

Kris shook her head. "See, that's the thing. I'm not sure that is quite true. They look like choices to us, but to her, I think she's always felt like she was just doing what she had to do. The problem is, once you get on the path of bad decisions, all that is left is choosing the least worst option."

"No way," Jessi snapped. "He'll totally freak."

We had just informed her of our determination to accompany her to see her boyfriend.

Kris crossed her arms. "It wasn't a suggestion."

"You'll ruin everything."

Kris softened. "Look, Jessi, you're in over your head."

"I know what I'm doing."

"No you don't. You think you do, but you don't. It didn't occur to you that Sal would come after us. You tried to hide, but we managed to

track you down, not once but twice. And it's not like we're seasoned investigators. It's just dumb luck that Sal didn't find you first."

"You need to let me talk to DeMac, square things up."

Kris shook her head. "No, Jess. You accused me of abandoning you. Okay. I get it. But now I want to help. But to do that, you have to let me, us, in."

"You don't understand," Jessi whined.

It was my turn to jump in. "Look, Jess, the past week has been a real learning experience for us. We're not as street smart as you. But three heads are better than one. We need you and you need us."

"This is a bad idea," she sighed.

Kris laughed. "Well, considering your track record, if you think it is a bad idea, then it must be pure genius."

Jessi flipped her sister the bird, but she had a small grin on her face as she did it.

I went out to buy some food and toiletries while the girls stayed at the motel.

Jessi was glued to her phone, tracking the progress of DeMarcus' bail process. It took most of the day, and finally we got word that he'd be released the following morning.

Even though we'd had a minor breakthrough with Jessi, we didn't trust her to not run away if given a chance. So that night, I moved the sofa in front of the door and slept there, while the sisters crashed on the mattress. It was a testament to Jessi's screwed up expectations that the shattered bed and mattress on the floor didn't even warrant a question.

I checked my email. Another message from Sal, its terseness speaking to his level of frustration.

"You can't hide forever."

Attached was another video file. I should have deleted it, but I just couldn't. I opened it and watched.

This one was a POV shot. Sal was laying on his back, and my wife was riding him, reverse cowgirl, facing away from him.

She rose and fell on his huge tool, moving slowly, mechanically. She was very wet. His shaft glistened with her excitement... or maybe he

was just enjoying sloppy seconds, thirds, fourths after the rest of his crew had fucked her.

He zoomed in close, giving me a gynecological view of her pussy stretching around his cock, of her pretty little rosebud puckering as she impaled herself on him. He lay perfectly still. She might as well have been riding a dildo.

Then slowly, almost imperceptibly, her rhythm shifted. At first it was just a little twist of the hips at the top of each stroke. Then a minute grind of her ass against his pelvis at the bottom. The length of her stroke began to vary. Instead of fully impaling herself each time, she rose and fell several times quickly, taking just the top half of his cock a couple times before driving all the way back down.

Her movements became less fluid, more forceful, ragged. She rose up again, allowed him to slip almost completely out, his cockhead alone now between her labia. She rocked back and forth, and I realized she was using his cock to stimulate her clit. Then suddenly, she shivered slightly and plunged back down on his cock, grinding roughly against him.

I didn't need to hear his chuckle to know he'd felt her climax. He thrust upward, once, twice, three times, almost seeming like he wanted to buck her off. But she rode him expertly, reciprocating his hard thrusts. He shivered, the camera shaking violently as his body clenched up.

When he was done, she lifted herself off him. He zoomed in the camera on her pussy, gaping momentarily as she disengaged from his fat tool. Her labia were puffy, red, and after a moment smeared with his come leaking out of her. The video ended on that image, a perfectly framed close-up of my wife's freshly fucked cunt.

Jessi made plans to see DeMarcus in the afternoon, so we had a quiet morning at the motel. I'd gotten us our now-standard breakfast of coffee and doughnuts.

Jessi and Kris spent a lot of time talking. There were no distractions. No kids, no house to clean, no parents to entertain. For perhaps the first time in years, the two sisters were really communicating.

I didn't imagine that somehow a few hours conversation would rebuild their relationship. Especially after the past week, the wounds, the

recriminations, the anger would seem to create a gulf too great to bridge.

I knew that I was having trouble with my own emotions. I hated Jessi. Hated her for her selfishness, her irresponsibility. And yet, I felt so sorry for her as well. I had only scratched the surface of her life, and yet even those small glimpses beneath the surface were tragic almost beyond imagining. She was reckless and callous. But it was a miracle she was human at all.

She claimed she'd only been doing what she thought she had to. Maybe. The past week taught me the danger of casting judgments. How many of my own choices would stand up to hard-eyed scrutiny in the cold light of hindsight?

Should I have stood up to Sal when he first came into our house? Should I have immediately called the cops? Did I really need to buy those lap dances? Have sex with Amber? How could I have let myself get surprised and incapacitated? Should I have intervened to protect Jessi, at the Four Seasons, in Ramirez's office? At each step, I felt like I was just doing what I had to... and yet, how many of those decision would I be willing to defend in public to a disinterested observer.

And when I thought about Kris, my feelings became even more conflicted. Feeling empathy for Jessi and letting myself off the hook implied giving her the same pass. And yet... with every new revelation, I found it harder and harder to shake my doubts. I understood, intellectually, that she felt she had no choice but to submit to Sal and his men... and yet, her submission had been so abject, so complete that it almost went beyond submission to complicity. And then Damon. Yes, she'd be trying to soften him up to get information. She'd done the same thing I'd done with Amber. And it had worked. But did she need to be so fucking enthusiastic about it?

I shook my head. Surely my feelings of betrayal were selfish. Or were they? Was there some part of Kris that actually enjoyed it? That longed to be a bad girl? Fuck, she'd admitted as much, hadn't she, when she said she'd been envious of her sister's experience.

The toothpaste was out of the tube. The genie out of the bottle. Choose your cliché. At some point, we'd have to confront all it, decide whether we still had a future. But that was a luxury we'd only have if we managed to recover some semblance of our past lives.

DeMarcus was staying with his brother, Tyrell, in a worn out clapboard house in the same neighborhood as Jessi's old garden apartment. Had they met then? It didn't really matter, although it hinted at the length of their relationship.

We drove past the house, checking it out. There didn't seem to be anything out of the ordinary, but even still we parked a couple of blocks away and cautiously walked back. I had my gun in my backpack even though Jessi assured me I wouldn't need it.

We knocked on the door. No one answered. That didn't deter Jessi. She turned the knob and walked right in. There was a TV blaring in the back. I looked over at Kris and saw a look of concern on her face. I held the backpack at my side, the easier to get a hold of my weapon if I needed it.

We emerged from a dingy hallway into a small living room, furnished with mismatching couches and an impressive 60 inch TV. DeMarcus was alone, sprawled out on one of the sofas in grey sweats and a white wife-beater t-shirt.

He smiled when he saw Jessi. "Hey, baby doll."

But his smile faded as Kris and I followed into the room.

"Who the fuck are you?" he asked. He sat up, his feet on the ground, his body leaning forward, ready to strike.

Jessi sat next to him, placed a hand on his thigh. "It's okay. It's just my sister and her husband. They've been putting me up since... you know."

He relaxed a little. But kept his eyes on us, me in particular, and my backpack specifically. He was obviously used to navigating dangerous situations, and he'd instinctively honed in on the one part of the situation he couldn't control.

I dropped the backpack, and put my hands out in front of me.

"We're just here to help out Jess," I said.

He regarded each of us slowly. I could see him working out the angles.

He smiled suddenly, brightly, though his eyes remains cold. "Well, any friend of my baby girl is a friend of mine."

Jessi beamed. She pressed herself up against him. He draped his arm over her shoulder.

DeMarcus caressed her thigh. His gaze landed on me. "Thanks for taking care of Jess. But listen, you know, I've been in stir for two month.

Would like a little private time with my lady, ya know?"

Kris jumped in. "We need to take care of business first."

DeMarcus eyed my wife. With her blond hair and yoga pants, he'd just dismissed her as eye candy.

He paused. "Business? I thought this was just a happy reunion."

Kris' eyes narrowed. "Let's cut the shit, okay, DeMac?"

He stiffened. "What you talking about?"

"You owe Jessi."

"Kris... don't," Jessi whined.

Kris ignored her sister. "Look, *DeMac*, I don't know how much of this you know, but we're all in the shit thanks to you, and we need you to pull us out."

"Whatchu want from me? I'm just an innocent businessman, wrongly accused. Cops took all my worldly possessions. I'm crashing on this fucking sofa."

Kris started to answer, but Jessi held up her hand to cut her off.

"Baby," Jessi cooed seductively, "don't worry about my sis. She's always been a drama queen."

Kris bristled. I put my hand on her forearm to restrain her. This was Jessi's game to play.

Jessi continued. "Thing is, lover, I sorta had to push the envelope to raise your bail."

He shrugged. "Yeah?"

"Yeah. Look, I gave 10 keys to Tyrell, and I just need a quarter to repay Sal."

DeMarcus looked at Jessi, then Kris, then me. "I don't know what you're talking about. Ten keys of what? I was set up."

I sighed. "Come on man, we're in this together."

"In what, porkchop?" he snarled. "Who you working for?"

I laughed. "Jesus, we're not cops."

I stood. Held my arms out at my side. "Search me for a wire if you want."

He snorted. "What is this, 1975, *Serpico*? You can hide a mic in a fucking clit piercing nowadays. I been entrapped once already."

Jessi shot me an annoyed look. *See, I told you*, she seemed to say.

"You can trust us," Kris said.

He looked her over. "I can't trust no one."

"Come on," she replied. "Don't do this."

He laughed. "You think I'm gonna sign my own conviction just because you flash me a smile?"

"No handsome, you're too smart for that," Kris replied flirtatiously.

"But we need to talk. And you know we're not cops."

"Don't matter what I know. Only matters what I can prove. That's what my lawyer says."

"Okay, so how can we prove we're not law enforcement?"

I turned to Kris. "Don't fucking humor him."

She gave me a quick headshake.

He ignored me, beckoned her over. "Come here doll."

Kris approached him. She stopped a yard from him, hand on her hip. He looked her up and down, taking in all her curves, so prominently on display in her workout clothes. I wondered how much of that was planned. Had she chosen the yoga pants rather than the mom jeans for more than just comfort?

"You really baby doll's sister?" he asked, his hand sliding between Jessi's legs even as he ogled my wife.

"I changed her diapers." She paused. "She had fewer tats then."

He laughed. "But the same amount of hair on her twat."

"Not our fault that men are closet pedos."

"So, you shaved like little sis?"

Kris grinned. "What do you care? I'm a cop, remember?"

"You could convince me otherwise," he gurgled, patting his crotch.

I grunted. "Really dude, we talking business or what?"

He smirked at me. "I always like mixing business and pleasure. What's the matter 5-0, this violate procedure?"

"I'm not a cop," I said with a sigh.

"Then you won't mind if I check for a family resemblance."

"Seeing my cooch will convince you?" Kris asked.

"It'd be a good start."

"A start to what?" I asked.

He smirked at me. "Who knows?"

He returned his gaze to my wife. "Come on, baby, peel off those leggings and give DeMac a show."

Kris hesitated for a moment. I could see her considering options. I was doing the same. Truth was, we needed him at this point, and while he

owed Jessi, we had no leverage over him. By signing that affidavit alleging police misconduct, Jessi had impeached herself as a reliable witness, so we couldn't even threaten to have her testify against him, even if she would consider it. Our only hope was to keep him on our side and hope that Jessi had judged his integrity accurately. That seemed a thin reed, but better than nothing.

Kris' calculus seemed to run the same course as mine. She gave him a smile.

"Sure thing, DeMac, I have nothing to hide."

She took a hold of her waistband and slowly rolled down the clingy fabric. I gasped when I realized she hadn't worn panties, though given how tight the leggings were, I shouldn't have been surprised.

Kris peeled the yoga pants down over her hips. I was behind her, so I was treated to the sight of her sexy ass slowly coming into her view, her tight little crack, those luscious, hard cheeks. She stopped halfway down her thigh, which somehow made it seem even more lewd than had she been completely nude. DeMarcus grinned even more broadly at his view.

"Damn, that's a pretty little twat," he said appreciatively.

He reached out and ran his fingers over her mound.

"Hmmm, nice and smooth," he continued.

Kris gasped softly, and I realized his fingers had slipped between her lips.

"That's enough," I choked out.

"Chill out jack. We're just having a little fun. Getting to be friends. We do want to be friends, right?"

"Yeah, we're all friends here," Kris replied.

I noticed that Jessi was massaging DeMarcus' crotch through his sweat pants. Even as his hand was exploring my wife's snatch, Jessi's hand was running up and down what seemed to be an impressively large package.

"Is your sister a player?" he asked.

Jessi grinned. "Only one way to find out."

She untied DeMarcus' sweatpants and yanked them down. His cock sprung up and Jessi pumped her fist up and down his long shaft. Not as thick as either Sal or Damon, he was nonetheless lengthier than average.

Kris' eyes were drawn to his lap. She couldn't seem to tear her gaze away from the sight of her sister stroking that big, black cock. I couldn't

really blame her. I was equally entranced by the sight of Jessi's dainty little hand fisting that long shaft.

"Come on, doll," DeMarcus said in a low rumble, "get a taste of licorice."

Kris swayed in place for a few moments. His hand continued to work her slit. She took a half step forward. She looked up and locked eyes with Jessi, who gave her a quick nod. Then Kris looked back at me. I wanted to shout out, but instead, my gaze flitted between her, Jessi, and DeMarcus. There was something about the scene that paralyzed me. I don't know what Kris read in my ambivalence; I'm not even sure she cared.

Kris took another half step and dropped to her knees. DeMarcus placed his huge hand on the back of her head. Jessi angled his prick toward her sister's mouth.

"Oh fuck," he growled as my wife swallowed him deep.

Kris bobbed up and down on his long shaft. Jesus, it seemed like a million years ago that Sal had forced her to blow him in our home. Since then I'd been treated to various close-up videos of my wife gratifying men orally, taking their cocks inside her. In a way, I should have been used to it by now. And yet, the sight of Kris slurping on DeMarcus' big cock, while Jessi massaged his balls, was still like a kick in the chest. I could barely breath.

He looked over at me, his hand gesturing toward my wife. He smiled, then bit his lip and closed his eyes.

Kris blew him wetly. His long cock glistening with her spit. She took him deep into her mouth, moaning around his shaft, and as she rose up, she twisted her fist around his cock.

He looked down at Jessi. "Go on, baby doll, you know what I want."

Jessi nodded and slid off the sofa. She wedged her head under his legs and sucked his balls into her mouth.

He grinned more broadly still. He slid further off the couch, until his ass hung in midair. Kris sucked his cock vigorously, sloppily. Her sister slobbered all over his balls, and then let her tongue trail down further between his legs. As Jessi licked his ass, Kris swallowed him deep.

With a loud growl, he came hard, filling my wife's mouth with his jism. It was too much for her. It overflowed her mouth, dripping down her chin and coating his prick. Jessi immediately moved to his cock. For a few

moments, Jessi and Kris were both working his shaft, their tongues millimeters apart as they licked him clean.

Finally, Kris withdrew, and Jessi sucked him deep into her mouth, reclaiming her man as her own. Kris rocked back on her heels, obsessively watching her sister suck cock, her own hand wedged down between her legs.

I realized that Kris was lost in the moment, staring at DeMac's big cock, at her sister swallowing his big tool, her own fingers manipulating her tender flesh. There was a second there where I think both Kris and Jessi were in thrall to the eroticism of it all. Me too, I have to admit. It would not have taken much to turn this into an orgy, the four of us just a jumble of flesh.

But then I saw Kris shiver and shake her head, clearing it. She stood, pulled up her pants.

"Okay, DeMac, so now you know we're not cops. Time to talk turkey," Kris said.

Jessi was still sucking his tool. He nodded into his lap; I guess he was trying to get Kris back in the mood. But her gaze was determined, cold. He pushed Jessi away.

"Alright, fuck, what do you want?"

Kris gestured toward Jessi. Jessi wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. The sisters locked eyes for a moment.

Kris addressed her sister, "Jessi..."

Jessi sighed. She sat up. She took a deep breath.

"You know what I did to get the money to bail you out. Now we need you to square us up."

"I dunno anything," he replied. "Alls I know is that you gave some shit to Tyrell."

"Yeah, I stole that from Sally B. Ten keys baby. He wanted a quarter for it. I knew T could sell it for more, you know? So I took it."

DeMarcus looked at Jessi coldly. "Okay, so what do you want from me?"

Jessi sighed. "DeMac, you know what I gave T is worth twice as much as he put up for bail. I need the rest to square up with Sal."

DeMarcus laughed. "Fuck him. What's Sally gonna do?"

"Destroy our lives," I snapped.

Jessi shot me a dirty look. She turned back to DeMarcus. "Let's just clean this up, ya know. Sal is going after my sis. Let's move on."

DeMarcus slowly surveyed the room. "Baby doll, this is between you and T."

Jessi shook her head. "No, DeMac. Come on, I know the business."

He chuckled coldly. "Business? The only business you know is shaking your ass. Don't worry about Sally B. He's a punk. He come around, and I'll put him in the ground."

I looked up at Kris. We both sighed. We'd been grasping at straws. But now we realized DeMarcus was not the answer. For both of us it was just a confirmation. For Jessi it was a betrayal.

"You don't understand," she snapped shrilly. "You don't know what I've done."

He laughed. "What's that? Did you take a dick or five? That's what you call Tuesday, ain't it?"

She shook her head. "What are you saying? I'm just some whore to you?"

"You saying you're not? Look," he said reaching for his wallet on the side table. "Here's a G for you and a five bills for your whore sister." He tossed \$1500 in hundreds into Jessi's lap. "Now, we squared up."

Jessi snarled at him. "You low-rent fuck!"

Kris slid between them. "Forget him, sis. He's not worth it."

"Kris no..." she snapped, then trailed off.

Kris stared at her little sister for moment, and when Jessi slumped, my wife turned toward DeMarcus. "He's a loser, baby. He'll be in a shallow grave before we know it."

DeMarcus rose quickly, throwing Jessi aside. "You want a piece of me?"

"You're not man enough," Kris snarled.

He took a step forward.

"Move a muscle and I will blow your head off," I yelled.

By instinct I'd seized the gun out of my backpack and was aiming it at his head. My hand shook. I was terrified, and yet I was desperate for him to move even an inch toward Kris so I'd have an excuse to shoot the motherfucker.

He looked at me. Paused for a second. "Take your whores and get out," he grunted.

Kris circled back toward me. Jessi hesitated. Then she shot him a sad look and walked over towards us.

"If I ever see you..." he began menacingly.

I cut him off, shaking the gun at him, "You better hope you don't."

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

I was sure Jessi would hate us, blame us for somehow poisoning her relationship with DeMarcus. On the drive back to the motel, she just sat silently in the back seat staring out the window.

Kris sat next to me up front. She touched my forearm.

"Daniel, are we okay?"

I knew what she meant. We'd been asking each other that question over and over, always giving comfortable reassurances, not confronting anything really. In a way, I — we — were okay. We'd somehow been dropped into a world where sex wasn't about intimacy and emotions. It was a commodity, pure and simple. And given the stakes, we had to use every tool, every resource at our disposal to navigate the rapids. To do whatever it takes.

So I was okay. I knew that her sucking off DeMarcus hadn't been an act of betrayal. If anything, it was a sign of love. An indicator that Kris was willing to do anything necessary for us to recover our old life together. And my own acceptance of that was rooted in the same desperate desire. I loved Kris enough that anything that might get us back to normal was a price worth paying.

"Yes, we're okay," I said.

She didn't take her eyes off me. "But...?"

I grinned despite myself. I was an open book to her.

"But, that's what scares me," I replied.

She didn't speak. She knew I had something to say and she gave me the space to get it out.

"It shouldn't be okay," I continued. "I just watched you suck another man off, and I knew you were doing it for us, that you were just doing what you thought was best. That it was, I dunno, almost normal. I'm scared precisely because it does feel okay."

She nodded. "I... Over this past week... I've done a lot of things I never thought I would or could do. There are times when I feel like I am watching someone else do it."

Jessi piped up from the back seat. "That's how you do it. You go somewhere else. It's happening. But it's not happening to you."

Kris looked back at her sister. "How can you keep doing that? Not let it affect you, change you?"

"You don't. Not really. You just pretend it doesn't matter. You get tough, or at least act that way. After a while, it gets to be second nature. And then you start to accept your own lies. You start to believe that the guy fucking you up the ass for a couple of bills, that's he's the pathetic loser not you."

"Jessi, baby, you're not a pathetic loser," Kris replied kindly.

I glanced back over my shoulder again. Jessi had retreated back into the corner of the back seat, again staring out the window, her hair drawn across her face like a curtain.

The conversation had culminated in a way, but I still had a dark thought running through my mind.

"Kris, there's something else..."

I hesitated. I didn't know how to say this without being crudely offensive. But there was no way around it. The only way this wouldn't destroy us is if we were perfectly, painfully honest. She was waiting for me to continue. I could see her in my peripheral vision staring at me. I was pleased that driving gave me an excuse not to have to make eye contact.

"I... um... I think you're beginning to enjoy it. Not the sex... well, not just the sex. But using sex to get what you want."

She didn't say a word. It felt like the calm before the storm. Jessi sensed it too. She was staring, rapt, at the back of her big sister's head. I suddenly felt awful.

"Kris, I'm sorry, I shouldn't have said that."

She still remained silent.

"Kris?"

"No, Daniel. You're right. It's sick. But you're right. There's something about it. About seeing a man watching you, wanting you, and knowing that if you play your cards right, you can get him to do what you want."

She paused.

"Even with Sal. I wanted to get him out of our house. Away from our kids. It's hard to explain... but after I serviced him, I felt dirty, used, and also weirdly pleased with myself. I wasn't in control at his house... but I

also wasn't completely at their mercy. And I know this seems weird, but I almost think that with a little more time I could have gotten myself out of it. I didn't just submit to them out of fear. I actively tried to please them so they'd fall for me."

"Okay," I replied. I slowly tried to get my arms around that admission.

"That's not all. I loved being out that day looking for Damon. God, all those men, so eager to please me, trying to impress me. There is something addictive about it. Normally you want to avoid that. Want to avoid being seen as a sex object. At the office, seeing a man notice my chest always set off alarm bells. Did that mean he wouldn't take me seriously? Had I done something to encourage it? But this past week, I was free to embrace it. I had no choice. With Sal and his men, all I had, literally, all I had was my body, my ability to turn them on sexually. And it was, weirdly, empowering."

"I understand. At least I think I do. But..."

Kris read my mind. "But you want to know if I will be able to turn it off later? Or if I'm going to be showing off my cleavage, always looking for ways to use my, um, assets to get my way?"

Jessi sighed from the backseat. "Why don't you just come out with it, Danny Dan? You wanna know if your perfect little wife is gonna turn into her whore sister."

"I didn't say that," I replied defensively.

"No, but that's what you're thinking."

I groaned. I didn't need Jessi getting between Kris and me. And yet, she was right. That's was my real fear, that Kris was turning into her sister.

Kris turned around to peer into back seat. "Jess, you tell me. Tell us. What do you think?"

Jessi shifted uneasily. She liked being on the attack. Kris' question disarmed her.

"I dunno, Sis. It gets old. It makes you cold. You stop taking other people seriously. You come to see all men as marks. All women as jealous pigs or dangerous competition. But it is so fucking hard to get away from it. Fuck. I spend hours dreaming about being normal. Of a regular job, a family, a house in the suburbs. But, here's the reality, Sis: I can make a month's normal pay in a night spreading my legs. At Crystal Towers, my fucking neighbors were people who'd worked like dogs for 30 years to get

there or were lucky enough to be born into it. And me? All I had to be was a good lay. Maybe that makes me a lazy cunt, but whatever."

"You're not a lazy cunt," Kris said gently.

"Or maybe I am. But here's the thing, Kris. I know it feels like you're using men, but really they're using you, and if you let it, the lifestyle will eat you up and spit you out."

"And yet," Kris replied, "you spent the last week digging all of us into a ditch just so you could continue to live it."

Jessi laughed. "Yup. I am glad that you are finally discovering your own sexuality. But I'm also sorry. You might have been happier never realizing what you could get from just shaking your tits."

Kris turned back toward me. "I want to get back to where we were. But I don't know that we can erase the past week. I love you. And I love our old life. And I hope I can be strong enough to turn it off."

"I'll always be there for you Kris. You know that right?" I saw her nod slightly. "I don't know if that makes things easier or harder, but know that you don't have to be something you're not just to please me."

She put her hand on my forearm. "I know. And I also know that we can't even begin to deal with the future yet."

That was the thing. Worrying about tomorrow was not a luxury we had. DeMarcus bailing us out had always been a pipe dream, a fantasy only Jessi had ever really held.

We got back to the motel room. It felt increasingly like a permanent prison rather than a temporary refuge. I looked around at the shabby surroundings. Was this to be our lives from now on? Run-down hideaways, always looking over our shoulders?

There was a knock from outside. I approached the door cautiously.

"Yes?"

"Housekeeping," came the reply.

"Thanks. We're okay."

"We, um, need to check on a leak."

"There's no leak," I replied. I looked over at the rusting kitchenette where Jessi was filling a teapot with water. A leak was certainly plausible.

"Come on, let us in, we need to check."

I sighed and reached for the doorknob.

"Can this wait?" I asked as I cracked the door open.

With a slam, the door burst open, cracking me in the head, sending me flying. Before I could react, two men burst in. I tried to scramble to my feet, got a kick in the chest as a reward. I felt myself fly through the air, heard a woman's scream, and then I crashed on my back onto the coffee table.

I saw Jessi rush toward the door. She was a blur, a sliver of steel poised above her head. A backhanded slap sent her flying.

"What the fuck?" Kris called out.

"Shut the fuck up," one of the men replied.

He was waving a gun in her direction. The other man was also armed, his gun shifting between Jessi and me.

Jessi goggled. "Tyrell?"

"Shut up, whore," he hissed.

Tyrell looked like his brother, though shorter, not quite as athletic. The other man was shorter still, squat, built like a bowling ball.

Jessi rose to her feet. "What's this about?"

Tyrell approached her. "I said, shut your whore mouth."

She shook her head. "T, man, talk to DeMac. We're all cool."

"DeMac sent us," the shorter man replied.

I saw Jessi blanch. In a small voice I'd never heard from her, she said, "We don't want trouble."

Tyrell gave her a mocking smile. "We don't always get what we want, now do we?"

"Come on boys, I'm sure we can be friends," I heard Kris say from behind me.

I turned around to see her standing there in just her yoga pants and a sports bra. She had an exaggerated smile on her face.

Both men grinned at her hungrily.

"Whatchu have in mind?" Tyrell asked.

"I dunno," she replied with a little head tilt. "But I'm sure we can all get along."

"Yeah, I bet," Tyrell replied.

Out of the corner of my eye, I noticed Jessi staring at her sister, eyes wide, giving her quick little headshakes. But Kris didn't get the message. She continued to grin flirtatiously at the two armed men.

"Come here beautiful," Tyrell said.

Kris approached him slowly.

"So you a playa?" he asked.

She didn't reply, but she continued to approach him. He took his gun and ran it across her cheek. She flinched slightly, but again forced a smile. He could sense her growing fear. His face glowed with excitement.

"Open up, baby," he ordered.

He ran the gun over her lips. Kris glanced over at me, at Jessi. Then she did as he commanded and as she did, her pressed the barrel of the weapon into her mouth.

"Suck it, whore," Tyrell said roughly.

I could see the fear in her eyes. This was not something she had expected. But she had no choice. She ran her tongue over the cold steel. He laughed coldly and began to pump the gun in and out of her mouth.

"You'll do whatever I say?" he groaned, the weapon pressing down on her tongue.

Kris gave him a quick submissive nod.

"Strip, cunt," he ordered curtly. Then glancing over at Jessi, he added, "You too."

I could see both of our assailants now focused on the girls as they quickly stripped off their clothes. I looked around the room. There, by the bedroom door was my backpack, and inside it my handgun. I moved slowly towards it, an inch at a time.

When the girls were nude, Tyrell ran his hand over my wife, down between her breasts, across her shaved mound. He turned to his friend.

"What you think Boogs? You ever see sisters get it on?"

Boogs laughed. "Yeah, but they was nasty ass crack whores, not fine white sluts."

Tyrell chuckled. "Me too."

He forced a finger inside Kris. She grunted at his intrusion.

"Nice and tight."

He looked over at Jessi. "Come here whore and eat yo' sister's cunt."

She shook her head. "No."

Tyrell laughed. He pressed the gun against Kris's pussy.

"Either you put your tongue up there or I tear up sis with my Glock."

"Please, don't do this," Jessi whined. "I'll never bother DeMac again."

"Too late for that, whore," Tyrell grunted. "You and sis are goin' give us a show."

I edged another few inches toward the backpack. They were so focused on the girls that they didn't notice me.

Jessi still hadn't moved, so Boogs walked over to her and roughly shoved her toward her sister. I slid closer to the backpack. It was less than a yard away.

Boogs grabbed Jessi by the hair and forced to her knees. He pushed her face towards Kris's crotch.

"Eat your sister's twat. Get it nice and wet for my cock."

Jessi shook her hair, struggled to break free.

It was my chance. I slid over that last yard and closed my hands on the backpack. I looked down, found the zipper and pulled it open, reached in and felt for the gun...

The backpack flew violently out of my grasp. I felt something hard rake across my scalp. I landed on my back.

"Nooo," Kris whined. "Don't hurt him."

I looked up to see Boogs standing menacing over me, waving his gun in my face. He strode over to the backpack and pulled out my own gun.

"I'm gonna shove this up your ass," he hissed. "But first, I'm gonna make you watch, up close, what we're gonna do to these whore sisters."

He grabbed me and launched me toward where Tyrell was still standing with Kris and Jessi. Tyrell gave a nasty smirk.

"Now, we gonna see some sister on sister action, or are Boogs and me gonna have to start splattering brains on the walls."

Jessi looked up at Kris who nodded.

"It'll be okay, baby," Kris said, gently.

Jessi leaned forward toward her sister's pussy...

Suddenly the door from outside burst open. I'm not even sure what happened next. There was a blur of movement as a man rushed in. Boogs swung his gun hand toward the door. There was a popping sound. Boogs yelped in pain, his gun falling to the floor, his hand dangling at a weird angle. A flying leg caught Tyrell in the chest, sending him sprawling backward. I looked back at Boogs. There was a disgusting, wet squishing sound as an elbow shattered his nose. He fell back, his body already limp,

and cracked his head on the coffee table. The man rushed Tyrell who was struggling to his feet. Tyrell never had a chance. The man had him in a chokehold and after a few moments released his limp body to the floor.

"Is everyone okay?" It was Damon. He was standing in a half crouch, coiled, ready to strike. He looked around the room.

"Jessi?" he said curiously as he spotted her.

She nodded, dazed.

"What?" he began. Then he shook his head. "Never mind. Later. We need to get out of here."

"Are they dead?" It was Kris.

He looked over at Tyrell. "He's not. He'll be coming to in a couple of minutes. The other one I'm not sure."

I scooted over and felt for a pulse.

"He's still alive... for now," I said, disgusted at the blood pouring from his shattered nose.

Damon nodded. "Is anyone gonna care about these assholes?"

"No one with a badge," Jessi replied.

"Girls, get dressed. Get your shit," Damon ordered.

He looked over at me. "You too man. You need to get out of here."

I nodded. "What was that?"

"It looked like you guys needed some help."

"But how..."

"Later," he replied. "Need to sweep this place for personal items."

It didn't take long. All of our stuff fit into two shopping bags. Tyrell began to stir before we were done, so Damon choked him out again. I took all three guns and put them back into the backpack.

Kris came out of the bedroom. She crossed the room to Damon and gave him a passionate kiss.

"Thank you," she said.

He gave her a sheepish grin. "I told you I'd see you again."

He looked over at Jessi who also was walking over. I could see him trying to puzzle out how we all knew each other. All he knew was he'd come back out to visit a girl who'd given him a great fuck and walked into a situation. He had no idea who I was, no idea why Jessi was there. And there was no time to explain.

He hustled us out of the room.

"Do you have a ride?" he asked.

I nodded.

"You take the girls. Find someplace safe. I'll keep a lookout here for a bit."

He turned toward Kris. "Then I'm gonna call you, and you're gonna explain what's going on."

She nodded. "Deal."

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

"What the fuck was that?" I asked as we pulled out.

"What did those men want?" asked Kris.

"Where did Damon come from?" was Jessi's question.

We all started talking at once, all of us simultaneously replacing our shock with a rush of adrenaline.

"Hold on. Hold on," Kris finally said. "Let me ask the questions."

When Jessi and I stopped talking. She continued.

"Who were those men?" she asked.

Jessi sighed. "I can't fucking believe it. DeMac sent them."

"Why?" Kris asked.

"Fuck sis, you need a picture? They were there to snuff us."

"But why?"

Jessi shook her head and continued in a tone of disbelief. "After all I did for that motherfucker. Jesus. I can't fucking believe it."

"Jessi, I still don't get it."

"Who the fuck knows? Maybe he didn't like the idea of paying me back, ever. Or didn't like the idea of me asking for anything. Or maybe he was afraid that now that he'd turned us down I'd try to go witness protection. Or fuck, Kris, maybe he liked how well you sucked his cock and decided to trade me in."

"Jessi!" I snapped.

"Daniel, no," Kris said calmly. "She's just upset."

Jessi was sitting in the back just shaking her head. The enormity of the situation really sinking in. "I can't fucking believe it," she repeated again and again.

Kris looked back at her sister. "It's okay baby. You're... we're all better off without him."

Jessi groaned. "You don't understand. You don't know what..."

"Shhh, baby. Shhh."

Jessi sniffled a few times. "God if Damon hadn't shown up, we'd all be.... How'd he find me? Wait. What was he doing there? How'd he know you?"

Kris laughed darkly. "Well, that's a funny story."

She explained how we'd decided to look for Damon to try to find Jessi. How they'd ended up in bed together. How Damon had given us the hint we need to track her down.

"So he was there looking for *you*?"

Kris nodded.

Jessi laughed. "Fuck, I guess it's lucky you're a good lay. Otherwise..." she shuddered rather than continue.

I shuddered as well at the realization that I now owed my life to my wife's bedroom skills and the hand-to-hand combat abilities of her latest lover.

"How'd he do that?" I asked. "I've only seen shit like that in movies."

"He's super strong," Jessi replied. "And he's worked as a bouncer. But yeah, that was unreal."

"I'll say," Kris added, mirroring her sister's dreamy tone.

"I can't believe you fucked my boyfriend," Jessi teased.

"Ex-boyfriend," she replied. "You ditched him to go back to the guy who just tried to have us killed."

I cleared my throat. "Um, you two can fight over him later. For now, we need to find a place to hide, and we probably need to ditch this car. I think we've been way too careless. We're lucky to be alive."

We drove further out of town, out by Green Valley. They have skiing in the winter, some recreational lakes in the summer. Out of season, though, there would be plenty of motel rooms available and not much traffic.

We got a small kitchenette suite and an adjoining room. We paid with cash from our dwindling supply. I worried doing so called attention to us, but I didn't want to risk using credit cards in case someone could track them.

Once we settled in, we debated calling Damon. He'd saved us, but I was worried about how little we really knew about him. Jessi noted we could use someone with his skills on our side. I knew she meant his fighting abilities, but I couldn't help but think of his proficiency at fucking as well. I didn't voice my anxiety and we agreed to let him know where we were.

Jessi and I went out to get some food and supplies. The advantage of Green Valley out of season was plenty of accommodations and few people. The disadvantage was that most of the local shops were seasonal and closed. We ended up driving quite a ways to get all we needed.

Jessi opened up to me a little. I now knew enough of her life to be a sympathetic ear. DeMarcus' betrayal hit her hard. I told her she deserved better.

She laughed. "Deserve?"

During one lull of the conversation, I brought up the night at Amber's.

"Did you guys drug me?"

"It was Amber's idea."

I wasn't sure I bought that. "Okay, but so, do I need to see a doctor?"

"It was a clean needle. And if you're alive now..."

"What was it?"

"Propofol."

"The shit that killed Michael Jackson?"

She shrugged. "He was a junkie on like twenty meds. Anyway people use it to get high sometimes. It's like X on steroids. Some girls keep some around to deal with a difficult trick. Hey baby, this'll make you feel good. Then you dump him."

"Jesus."

"Yeah, well, you do what you have to do."

When we got back to the motel, there was a motorcycle parked out in front of our rooms. I bristled. Jessi noticed.

"Relax. That's Damon's ride."

That didn't actually make things better. I knew what we'd find inside.

Sure enough, as we walked through the door, we heard them in the other bedroom.

"Let's give them some privacy," I said quietly.

Jessi gave me a saucy grin. She took my hand and pulled me toward the doorway to the adjoining room. I'm not quite sure why I let her, but I guess at some level I was curious to see as well. We cracked the door open and peered in.

Kris was on her hands and knees, Damon behind her. He was pounding into her hard, the sound of his thighs slapping her ass overshadowed only by her loud moans. He fondled her roughly, his large, strong hands mauling her breasts, squeezing her ass.

Jessi looked at me, her face shining with excitement.

"He's really fucking the shit out of her, isn't he?" she said.

"Yup."

"Does it turn you on?"

"Nope."

"Not even a little," she pressed.

"I dunno."

She suddenly dropped to her knees and began to fumble with my zipper.

"What the hell are you doing?" I hissed, though I didn't make a move to stop her.

She just rolled her eyes as if to say, *isn't it obvious?*

"I mean, why?"

She continued to pull open my pants. She took out my cock, stroked it firmly in her cool, dry hand.

"Watching them fuck is making me horny. And when I get horny, I like to have a cock in my mouth."

She positioned me sideways so that we could both continue to watch and then with a practiced movement, she swallowed me whole.

"Oh God," I moaned softly.

"Oh God!" my wife cried out as Damon hammered his cock into her wet pussy.

Jessi bobbed up and down on my cock like a woman possessed, trying to match Damon's frantic pace. She was taking me completely into her mouth on each stroke, her tongue swirling on my shaft, her hands massaging my balls.

In the next room, Damon was also going balls deep on each thrust, pulling almost all the way out and then plunging his big, fat tool into Kris' shaved snatch. He was pulling on her breasts, stretching out her nipples. Kris was moaning louder and louder, slinging her hips back against him, meeting his thrusts with her own.

"Oh fuck, oh fuck, oh fuck," she cried out in passion.

She threw her head back and let out a low growl. Her body shook violently. Her arms gave out and she fell face down onto the bed, though she kept her ass up high to allow him to continue to slide his cock into her pussy. She smiled back at him over her shoulder, her hair matted to her forehead.

"I love making you come," he said happily as he fucked her slowly.

"Do it Damon," she encouraged. "Give it to me."

He grinned and began banging her faster again. She squealed under his assault. He grabbed her by the upper arms, lifted her off the bed. She hung there in mid-air, her body at a forty-five degree angle, her big tits bouncing wildly as he rammed her again and again and again.

"Oh God, oh God, oh God," she cried out.

Kris' exclamations seemed to excite Jessi even more. She was moaning as she blew me. My cock was soaked, her saliva dripped down to my balls. I looked down and our eyes met. She was red-faced from exertion, her eyes wild.

From next door I heard Damon growl lustily. "Oh yeah!"

He was coming inside my wife, and as he did I exploded in her sister's mouth. Jessi didn't hesitate, didn't flinch. She swallowed every drop and then licked my cock clean, even as next door, Damon and Kris collapsed flat onto the bed as he slowly slid his prick into her battered pussy and kissed her wetly on the mouth.

Jessi and I got ourselves together faster than Kris and Damon, so we were sitting on the sofa when Kris padded out of the bedroom naked

looking for a glass of water.

She startled as she saw us. Then looked back guiltily over her shoulder.

"We know," Jessi said simply.

Kris' shoulders drooped. She looked at me sadly.

"Everything okay? I heard voices," Damon asked as he joined us. He was also naked, his fat dong dangling wetly between his legs.

"Are you okay, Daniel?" Kris asked.

"He's okay," Jessi answered for me, licking her fingers as she did.

Kris went from anxious to puzzled to angry in a millisecond. "You didn't. You little—"

Jessi cut her off. "Sis, you have come running down your leg."

Kris blushed a deep red and then ducked back into the bedroom.

Jessi turned to Damon. "And you, loverboy, as much as I love seeing your strong body and fat tool, maybe you should get dressed too."

A few minutes later, we were all sitting stiffly around the breakfast table in the kitchenette. Jessi was the only one who seemed wholly at ease with the situation. At some level, I guess she liked the idea that we were all similarly debauched. She cracked open four beers, and placed one in front of each of us.

"Well, folks," Jessi began, "the reason I called this meeting..."

I couldn't help it. I burst out laughing. In the end, laughter is the only appropriate response to absurdity. It took a moment, but Kris and Jessi joined in, and even Damon sported a silly grin.

It was the first time I'd laughed—really laughed—in ten days.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

I looked over at Damon. Though he was grinning, I could tell he thought he'd landed in with a group of maniacs.

"Damon, has Kris explained anything to you? Or..." *Or have you just been fucking?*

"Who's Kris?"

I sighed. "Okay, so first things first. I'm Daniel. That's Kris. She's my wife..."

"Wife?" He turned toward Kris. "You told me you only wore those rings to keep away creeps."

She shrugged. "I also told you my name was Tina."

"Yeah, that too," he groused.

"Let me explain," I continued. "This will all make sense. Or maybe it won't. But at least you'll know what is going on."

He looked at me skeptically, but then nodded.

"That is Jessi, though you might know her as Star. She's Kris' sister."

"Oh Jesus," he moaned.

Jessi laughed. "Oh come on, Damon. Don't tell me we're the first set of sisters you've had your way with."

"Actually, it is. It's also the first time I've sat at a table with a man whose wife I just sex with."

I plowed ahead. "Yeah, this is new for us too."

I told the story as best I could, starting with Jessi's boyfriend getting arrested, her coming to live with us.

Jessi took over.

"So, Damon... you know I'm a dancer."

He nodded.

She blushed before continuing. "I'm, um, also a part-time hooker. Sometimes it has been more than part-time. But I was trying to get out of that life. And I was with DeMarcus and..."

She paused and choked back a sob. Her cold and cynical facade didn't just crack, it crumbled.

"Fuck it. Never mind. I'm a fucking whore and destroyed my sister's life."

Kris put her hand on her sister's shoulder. "No. You're not and you didn't. It's okay. We all make mistakes."

Jessi looked over at Damon and then continued. "I'm not proud of any of this."

"Jessi, believe me," he replied, "there are a lot of things I'm not proud of either. But we learn and move on, right?"

She nodded. "Okay. So, fuck, I thought that DeMac and I had something. Or maybe I just wanted it so badly. Wanted to be done with the lap dances and selling my ass. And then he got arrested. And at first, I thought he was gone. I tried to move on. Moved in with sis. Started looking into classes to get my GED. Even hooked with this hunky bartender."

He blushed. It was actually very cute.

"And then DeMac's brother got in touch. Said that DeMac missed me. Wanted to be with me forever."

She summarized the scheme. The plan to get a new bail hearing after she filed a civil rights complaint. Her agreeing to help raise money. She told him about Sal's call to set up a bachelor party for his son. Her plan to parlay her earnings by dealing some coke, and how she'd decided to rip him off when she saw how much he was sitting on.

"I swear, I never thought they would go after Kris. Never occurred to me. But," she added honestly, "I'm not sure that would have stopped me anyway."

Kris picked up the tale. She was forthright and blunt. And as she detailed her three days at Sal's, I could see Damon getting increasingly angry.

I told about trying to pay off Sal. About how we'd burned through our savings and come up short. And then I related the story of tracking down Jessi the first time and then rescuing Kris.

Damon gave me an impressed nod. "That's hardcore man."

"Thanks," I replied. I was genuinely pleased at the compliment, even though it was weird feeling that moment of bonding with a man with whom my only real tie was that he'd had sex with my wife.

Then I explained that after rescuing Kris, we had gone searching for Damon as our last link to Jessi.

He looked at Kris. "So you slept with me to try to find your sister."

She nodded. "I'm sorry I used you. But if it is any consolation, you're an amazing lover."

Even though I knew already she felt that way, it was still painful to hear it. It didn't help that Jessi was also nodding eagerly in support.

Jessi took over and told about the meeting with the judge, her trip to the bondsman's office. She glossed over the details, and I didn't fill in the gaps. It was up to her how much she wanted to share of that experience.

Kris finished off the story by recounting our meeting with DeMac, including what she'd had to do to convince him to talk. And finally what happened in those last few minutes before Damon rescued us.

He shook his head. "Jesus, that's crazy. It was just dumb luck that I pulled up right as those assholes pushed their way in. It took me a while to decide what to do. All I knew what that I'd hooked up with this crazy, hot broad. But I dunno, she," he looked over at Kris, "didn't seem like the typical, crazy chick just looking for a bang."

I laughed. "It's okay. You can just admit she was a great fuck and you wanted more."

Kris slapped my wrist.

"No, I mean it. I've um, had a few hook ups over the years. And, well, Tina... I mean Kris just seemed different." He smirked. "And yeah, I was looking for another round."

"Okay," I said. "Now we all know how we got here. But what do we do next?"

Kris looked over at Damon. "This doesn't really involve you. We appreciate your help back at the other motel. But if you want out, we'll understand."

He nodded. "I appreciate that. And to tell you the truth, I don't know what I can do to help. But it seems like you need all the help you can get."

Kris continued. "As I see it, we have two problems. The first is Sal. He wants his 250 grand or 10 kilos of cocaine back. The second is DeMarcus who seems to think we'd be better off dead."

She paused to see if anyone had anything to add.

"So, any thoughts?" Kris asked.

I shook my head. Jessi looked down.

Finally Damon spoke. "Everyone has a weakness. The key is to find it and exploit it."

It was easy to phrase it that way. Finding actual exploitable weaknesses was a whole other issue. We went around and around, as we finished off a couple of cases of beer.

The best we came up with was a murder spree. Gun down Sal, Rock, Jerry, Vinny for good measure. Then take care of DeMarcus, Tyrell, and Boogs. Oh sure, we might have to hit a few others along the way. But all we had to do was kill seven or eight people, all of whom were armed and dangerous, and get away with it.

It was an enjoyably bloodthirsty, drunken fantasy. But in the end, we ended up no closer to a solution than we were when we began.

It was getting late. Time to go to sleep. We had two bedrooms, and in theory constituted two couples. It was a testament to how fucked up things had become that I didn't know how those two couples would shake out. In a weird way, I wasn't even sure what I wanted anymore.

The idea of spending the night with Jessi was undeniably hot. She was a sexy, dirty girl, and though I'd never really admitted it even to myself, I had always wanted to fuck her. The idea of replaying even half the things I'd seen her do at the Four Seasons or in Ramirez's office was intoxicating.

And anyway, it was pretty obvious that Kris would prefer spending the night with Damon. I had never fucked her like that. She'd never responded that way. I wasn't under the illusion that Jessi would want to be with me for the long-term, but she might be able to salve my wounds if Kris picked Damon over me.

"Let's go to bed." It was Kris.

I looked up, expecting her to be tugging at Damon. But instead she was looking right at me, unwavering and confident in her choice. I smiled.

We walked into the other bedroom.

"You were worried I'd choose him?" she asked perceptively.

My eyes shifted unconsciously to the bed, still disordered from her most recent session with Damon.

"Yes."

"Oh honey. I'm so sorry."

"Don't be," I replied. "He does... things to you."

She nodded. "He does. Daniel, I'm not going to lie to you. He's a sexual dynamo. I really, really like having sex with him. But I love you. It's not a close call. I would never trade you for him."

"Okay," I replied softly. I didn't know how to respond beyond that.

She stepped in close and cupped my face with her palms. "Baby, don't shut me out. Tell me what you're thinking."

"I'm hurt. I don't blame you. But it hurts."

"Okay. Do you still love me?"

"Of course," I replied defensively.

"Well, what about Amber? That's her name right? And what about Jessi? They both gave you pleasure."

I nodded. "They did, but..."

"But what? God, Daniel, for so long we were together, just the two of us. And in a way I wish we could go back to that. But we can't. And now the truth is that whether we like it or not, we've both enjoyed sex with other people. And," she blushed, "I found I can enjoy sex just as sex, without any love or affection, just the physical act. I never thought that is something I could do. I always thought that people who liked sex for sex were weak somehow, undisciplined, whatever."

"Like Jessi."

"Yes. Just as she's spent years living in my shadow, I've spent years looking down on her, on her lifestyle, on her choices."

"Well... she has made a lot of bad choices."

Kris nodded. "And how. But I'm not sure having sex for pleasure was one of them."

"So, what, we have an open marriage now?"

She hesitated. "No. Not an open marriage. But maybe a flexible one?"

"Damon really got to you."

"It isn't just him. Oh fuck, Daniel. I feel so dirty to admit it, but there were times, with Sal, that I really enjoyed it. And Rock. Some of it, I was just trying to get through. But there were several times where..."

She trailed off.

"I dunno," I replied. "All the rules are out the window right now. I don't blame you for anything you've done, whether you had to do it, or just wanted to. But I'm not sure I can be okay with sharing you like that."

She nodded. "I understand, but you wouldn't be sharing me. You'd just be sharing my body... sometimes."

"I'll think about it. Okay? It's not something we need to decide on right now."

"No. It's not."

We remade the bed and got ready for sleep. I was in my boxers. She pulled on my tee shirt. She cuddled up next to me.

"So, how was my sister?" she said after a moment.

"Oh God, Kris. Is that what this is about?"

She hesitated. "You think I'm trying to punish you?"

"Are you?"

"No. I was just, you know, curious. Sal, the others, you know, they'd all had Jessi too. They kept comparing us."

I nodded, remembering the contest he'd held to see who gave better head.

She continued, "They were mostly doing it to humiliate me, taunt me, you know. But I don't know, I guess it put the idea in my head. What did you two do anyway?"

"You sure?"

"Tell me," she said firmly.

I sighed. "We heard you when we walked in. Jessi dragged me over for a closer look."

"Dragged you, eh?"

"Well, I didn't fight her, but it was her idea. You were on your hands and knees. He was behind you. We saw you come. And she went down on me."

"So you were in her mouth while he was inside me?"

I nodded.

"Does it make me sick," she asked, "that I think that's hot?"

"Yeah, a little."

"Did you come in her mouth?"

I nodded.

"When?"

Fuck. She had me.

"When he came inside you."

"Kinky," she cooed.

After a pause, she added, "So you never answered. Which one of us is better?"

"Kris!"

"Maybe you just need a reminder."

"You don't need to do this."

"All this talk has me a little randy," she said as she ducked under the covers.

Jesus. That was almost verbatim the reason Jessi gave for blowing me. Kris seemed to be turning into Jessi.

She pulled down my shorts, exposing my cock. She licked the length of my shaft, using just the tip of her tongue, a ticklishly sexy sensation. She massaged my balls. I stiffened quickly, and as I did, she took me deep in her mouth.

She blew me slowly. Long, wet swallows, punctuated with a swirl of her tongue over my glans. She grabbed me by the base of my cock, pumped me firmly between her thumb and index finger.

"Oh, God, that's good," I moaned.

She crawled back up next to me, breathed hotly onto my neck. "Better than my sister?"

"God, yes."

She giggled.

"Good. Then you probably won't mind if I do this."

She swung her leg over me, impaled her wet pussy on my cock. She was so hot, so ready. I remembered that she hadn't showered since fucking Damon. He was still inside her. But it felt so good, so slippery that I didn't mind.

I pulled her tee shirt over her head, freeing her gorgeous tits. Her areolas were puffy, her nipples erect. I took them into my mouth, one at a time, sucking hard, but not too hard apparently. She let out a sultry moan, ground her pussy against my pubic bone.

I grabbed her ass, squeezed her cheeks hard, and urged her on. She rode me faster, her breaths coming in ragged gasps.

"Oh God," she moaned.

I felt her pussy spasm on my cock. That sent me over the edge. I came inside her.

She collapsed on my chest, both of us breathing hard. She pushed her face into the crook of my neck.

"Daniel, I love you so much."

"I love you too Kris. And I always will."

I woke up a couple of hours later. We'd fallen asleep with the lights still on. I untangled myself from Kris and tucked her under the covers. I turned out the lights and got up, ducking into the suite to get a glass of water from the kitchenette.

I noticed that Jessi and Damon still had their lights on, their door cracked open. I wondered if they'd fallen asleep the same way we had. I decided to close their door; maybe let them sleep in if we got up earlier than they did the next morning.

As I approached their door, I realized they were still awake, talking softly. I peered in. Jessi was face down on the bed, lying on a towel. She was naked. Her body was covered in bruises, welts. I winced to see her that way.

Damon was kneeling beside her, gently rubbing baby lotion over her injuries. They weren't talking about it. They were talking about anything else. Sharing silly stories, memories.

She rolled over after a while and he soothed her injuries. He gently massaged her breasts, her battered nipples. Coated with oil, they gleamed in the dim light, stiffening.

She took his hand, moved it down to her pubic mound.

"There too?" he asked.

She nodded.

He shook his head angrily, but tenderly massaged her there as well.

"That feels nice," she sighed.

She wasn't just talking about soothing her wounds. She slowly began thrusting her pelvis against his hand. He slid his well-lubed thumb into her slit and firmly rubbed her clit.

She moaned happily. Her breaths came in shallow gasps.

"Oh God," she sighed as she clenched his hand to her sex.

"You're the best doctor I've ever had," she said with a big smile.

"And you're my sexiest patient."

She reached for his crotch. "Your turn baby."

He pushed her away. "Naw. Get your sleep."

"You sure?"

He grinned. "What can I say? Your sister wore me out."

"That cunt," she replied with a grin.

Damon kissed her forehead. He lay down beside her and pulled the covers over them both. Then reaching over, he turned out the lights.

We still didn't have a good plan of action when we woke up the following morning. I wanted to trade-in our car. And we all needed extra clothes and such.

Damon and I went out to do those errands. The first bit of business was going back to our house to pick up both some personal belongings and the deed for the car.

Spending time with Damon was more than a little awkward. We tried to make small talk about football and beer, but it was forced at best.

After a while he took a deep breath.

"Look man, we need to talk about this."

I sighed. "Yeah. We do. Okay."

But I didn't know where to begin, what to say.

He filled in the silence. "I didn't know she was married. That's not the kind of thing I do."

"She lied to you," I replied. "I don't blame you."

"You blame her?"

"I... I'm not sure I blame anyone."

I paused before continuing. "This is hard. Let me go back to the beginning."

I told him our story, including things I'd recently learned. About how Kris and I met as kids and shared everything together, our first kiss, our first everything. How we'd been together so long that we never even really questioned it, or why we were there, or what the relationship meant. Precisely because we'd been together so long, from such a young age, meant that we'd never really dug below the surface.

I explained about Kris and Jessi's home life: my newfound realization that part of why Kris had clung so tightly to me for so many years was that I was an escape from the turmoil at home and then later as

Jessi's life became unmoored, I acted as an anchor for her, a touchstone of stability, a shield against what might be lurking inside her as well.

And finally I talked about how things had changed since Sal burst into our house. How suddenly everything seemed to have been thrown into question.

"It's not that she doesn't love me. She does. I know that. But I don't think she ever realized—maybe still doesn't realize—that there is an instrumental component to her being with me. I was there to protect her from chaos. And chaos found us anyway."

"It's not your fault, man," he replied sincerely. "Nothing you could have done."

It was weird talking that way to Damon. He was a virtual stranger. But we were intimately linked. He'd fucked my wife and saved my life. I needed someone to speak to, and he was a good listener.

"So why are you with her?" he asked.

"I don't know for sure. It is easier to analyze others than oneself. I'm sure she has her theories about me. I love her, of course. Can't imagine life without her. Maybe that's it?"

He laughed. "You think too much. It doesn't really matter why you two ended up together. All that matters is that you love each other and you work well together."

"Yeah, but it gets to what our lives look like. I think Kris and I will always be together. But it seems like we're no longer on the straight and narrow."

"Yeah, but that's okay dude. *Two roads diverged in a wood, and I... I took the one less traveled by, and that has made all the difference.*"

I laughed at the incongruity of this tattooed bruiser quoting Frost at me.

"What's your story?" I asked.

"What? A meathead like me can't read books?" he replied gruffly.

I grinned. "We're here. You can kick my ass later."

He grinned back.

The house was a mess. At some point Sal or his boys had tossed the place. Or maybe it had been DeMarcus' guys. We now had so many

enemies that I couldn't be sure.

Damon and I were both armed, and he could obviously handle himself, so I wasn't worried about running into anyone. Truth be told, I sort of relished the possibility. Cold blooded murder was one thing... self-defense in my own home quite another.

It occurred to me that we could actually stage that. Move back into the house, use the girls as bait, and lure in the bad guys. I pitched it to Damon.

He shook his head. "First, that sort of lying-in-wait constitutes premeditation. Second, you never want to get into a firefight if you can avoid it. Third, you don't want to put Kris and Jessi at risk like that."

I nodded.

We packed up some clothes, a few other house wares, and some personal papers. As I left the house, I had a weird sense that I would never return there again. It made me shiver. I pulled the door shut and walked to the car.

We had traded the old Accord for an even older Taurus. With new plates, I felt like we'd put a little more distance between ourselves and the people after us. But I knew we couldn't run forever.

I still didn't quite know what we had in Damon. Bartender, tattoo freak, poetry reader, expert at hand-to-hand combat....

"Dude, I need to ask you. Back at that other motel. What the hell was that?"

"I told you, it was just dumb luck I was there."

"No, I mean once you got in. You took out two armed men in like ten seconds."

"They were punks."

I sighed. "Yeah... and..."

"I've had training."

"What, like MMA?"

"Something like that." He paused. "I was a SEAL."

"No shit?"

"No shit. Two enlistments worth."

"You kill any bad guys?"

He rolled his eyes at me.

"Bin Laden?"

He shook his head. "Naw, I was on Team 4. We were doing mostly counter-narcotics. I... um... I can't really talk about it, you know?"

"Can't? Or don't want to?"

"Both I guess."

I nodded. "Okay. But can I just ask why you got out?"

"I've always dreamed about tending bar."

"Yeah?"

He laughed. "Well, that and getting tired of being on twenty-four hour alert and then getting dropped into a swamp in the middle of the night to shoot it out with narco douchebags."

He paused, shaking his head at some private memory. "Funny thing. Here I am again, mixed up with some drug dealing shits. I guess it's my fate, eh?"

"You don't have to, you know. You don't owe us anything. If anything we owe you."

He chuckled again. "Yeah, well, that's not how I'm wired. Someday you can play amateur shrink with me and we can figure out why."

It was interesting news. I still wasn't crazy about the idea of my wife having sex with another man. But I had to admit, her recruitment of him onto our team had evened the odds.

We got back to the motel. The girls had made sandwiches for lunch. We cracked open some more beers. The sense of domesticity struck me as frightening. Was this our new normal?

The girls were giggling, asking Damon to explain his tattoos. He had a story behind each one, though I got the sense he was making them up as he went along.

I cleared my throat. "Okay... so what's our plan here?"

Kris looked over at me. "Do you have any thoughts?"

I shook my head. "I dunno. But... we're dealing with two drug dealers. Can't we, like, set it up so they turn on each other?"

Jessi objected. "The problem is they are in a different business. Sal is wholesale; DeMac is retail. If anything, they'd be likely to be partners."

I was thinking aloud. "What if DeMac bought from Sal and then stiffed him."

"Yeah, okay," Kris interjected. "But how do we arrange that?"

Jessi said, "Well, I could, I guess, tell Sal I stole his shit on DeMac's orders, but I was, you know, too scared of D to rat him out?"

Kris sighed. "That's actually close enough to true to be plausible. Problem is, I don't see Sal going to DeMarcus to collect, you know. He'd rather squeeze us for it. Unless he could see you and DeMac together."

Jessi chuckled darkly. "Which won't be easy since DeMac seems to want me dead."

"Yeah, even if they were just trying scare you off, after what happened in the other motel, I doubt his bro would be in a forgiving mood."

"Okay," I relented. "So that's not going to work. Anyone else?"

"Witness protection?" Kris suggested.

"What do you really have to offer the feds?" Damon asked.

Jessi nodded. "I'm the only one who knows anything, and I'm not, you know, the most credible witness."

That was for sure. Her hooking, drug use, perjury on the affidavit.

Jessi continued, "D's business is shot. Seems like he's running shit through T, and Tyrell, as you can tell, doesn't like me. It's not even like I could offer to go undercover."

Kris nodded. "Jessi and I could go to Sal, offer to work off the debt."

"No way," I shook my head. "Do you know what that would mean?"

"I do," she replied. "But you didn't let me finish. What I was going to say was that in the three days I was there, I didn't see anything. People coming and going. They're obviously shady characters, but despite what they did to me, I didn't see any crimes."

"And you couldn't prove that, anyway," Jessi added.

"Well," I replied, "we do have videos. Sal sent me several."

Kris looked aghast.

"What?" I asked. "You warned me that might happen."

She shivered. "I know. But you didn't tell me he had. Did you watch them?"

I nodded.

"What did they show?" Jessi asked.

I sighed. "You're right, we definitely don't have a rape case if that is what you're wondering."

Jessi snorted. "That asshole and his fucking videos."

"He filmed you too?" Kris asked.

Jessi nodded. "Yeah. All the time. He could release 'The Sexucation of Star.'"

"What do you mean?" I asked.

She sighed, cast an embarrassed glance at Damon. "Let's just say he captured many of my firsts."

That seemed unlikely. I knew Jessi had been having full-blown sex since she was thirteen. How many firsts could be left by the time she ran into Sal?

Kris was consoling her sister. "It's okay baby, he got some of mine too."

"Wait," I interject. "Jess, what kind of firsts? When did you first, um, hook up with Sal?"

"Daniel, don't badger her," my wife said protectively.

"I'm not. Jeez. And it's not prurient interest either. Jess?"

She looked at me. "I dunno. First group scene, maybe... Not sure about anal..."

"No, no. When did this start? That's what I care about."

"Oh. I dunno. I was sixteen? Seventeen maybe?"

I slapped my thigh. "We've got him."

The others looked at me quizzically.

"We've got him," I repeated. "It's statutory rape at the very least. Age of consent here is eighteen. But the bigger thing is, those videos, that is child porn technically."

Kris gasped and turned to her sister. "Do you have any of those videos? Has he ever sent them to you?"

Jessi shook her head. "No. Maybe? I don't know. Where would they be? I wouldn't have kept them on my phone."

"Fuck," I snapped. "If he sent them, maybe there is a record on his internet provider's servers."

Kris sighed. "That's too thin."

"If he's filming this shit," Damon said, "I'm betting he's keeping it. Probably on his computer if he has one. Password protected, but probably there."

"So what do we do? Break into his house? Steal his machine?" I asked.

Damon shrugged. "We're not law enforcement. Once we have it in our hands, he could argue we planted evidence."

"And anyway," Kris added, "I think this is more useful as blackmail fodder than anything else. What we need is to figure out for sure what he has. If it is damning, we make a copy of it. And then blackmail him to leave us alone."

I nodded. "So, we find ourselves a hacker who can break in remotely?"

Kris nodded. "Either that or we try to hack it on-site."

"I doubt we'd be able to get into his house and work there undetected long enough to pull it off," I said.

"I could," Kris replied.

"Kris, no. If you went back to his place, the only thing you'd see is a metal cot in some back room." I said. "This is crazy."

"Actually, it isn't," she insisted. "I know he said he'd whore me out to recover his loses... and maybe he would. But not right away. He wants me for himself first. He wants to film my own firsts before he turns me out."

Now it was Jessi's turn to throw cold water on the idea, "Sis, you don't want to do this. What they did to you before. That's just a warm-up. Believe me, it can get much, much worse."

"You survived it."

Jessi nodded.

Damon asked, "Even if you got access, how could you prove they were made when she was seventeen? Time stamps are worth shit."

"Well, that's an easy one," I replied. "Jessi got that salamander tattoo on her eighteenth birthday. If it's there, she's legal, if it's not..."

Kris gave me a curious look, but Jessi just nodded. "He's right."

"Hmmm," said Kris. "That makes the plan even more attractive. We get our hands on the right video, with Sal and an under aged Jessi, and we can make at least our problems with him go away."

Damon stood suddenly. "Folks, if there is one thing I learned it is that you should never commit to a plan without reflecting on it, unless you have no choice. Sal, DeMarcus, they will all still be out there later. So let's

all take a deep breath and talk about this again after we consider the ramifications."

The group meeting broke up after that. Damon and I watched some basketball on TV.

I went through the mail that had come in while we were away. Mostly junk. All of our real correspondences come electronically now. But there was one letter from my office that was problematic.

It was a bunch of forms I would need to fill out justify the family emergency leave I'd claimed. I sighed. There was no way I could explain my continuing absence. I was out of a job.

Coincidentally, Kris came over a few minutes later. She was holding her phone by her side.

"Some guys came looking for me at my office."

I waved my envelop at her. "My boss wants documentary evidence of our emergency."

She said, "Yeah, I think that was the last straw for me too."

"Well, now that it looks like we're formally unemployed, it does open up the option of just leaving town."

She nodded. "Truth is, if we packed up, they probably wouldn't track us down, but... But do we want to spend the rest of our lives worrying about it?"

"Yeah, I know. But, I'm not sure that is worse than thinking about sending you back into that lion's den."

"I could handle it," she replied confidently.

"I know," I replied less confidently.

She returned to talking to her sister.

I turned to Damon. "Seriously man, what do you make of her plan?"

He shook his head. "I dunno. It isn't really my style, ya know? But the basic instinct is right. You don't want a war. So you need to convince him to back off. Holding something like that over his head is a pretty good way to do it. I think Kris is right. An inside job makes the most sense... but Jessi is right too. This won't be a cakewalk."

I sighed. "I'm not sure Kris is thinking that way. I think... I dunno... I think she sees that as a test or way to prove a point of some kind."

"You're all under a lot of pressure. That changes people's threat perception and risk tolerance."

I nodded. "And meanwhile, we still don't even have the outlines of a plan for DeMac."

"You could wait him out," Damon replied. "He's just out on bail. Once he goes away for good I doubt his crew will be much interested in rubbing out his old girlfriend."

"That's if he gets sent away. And the process could take months. Naw, we need to hurry along the process of getting him—and ideally his brother—behind bars."

"Do you know the terms of his bail? Does he wear an ankle bracelet? Is he allowed to leave the state? Frequent with known felons?"

"Hmmm, that's interesting. Maybe we could trick him into voiding his bail terms."

"Probably need to do a little research on that," Damon suggested.

"Kris still has that press pass. Maybe she should call up the DA and get details."

Damon nodded. It was weird. But somehow a plan was coming together.

The motel room was stuffy, so I decided to go for a walk. As I did, another email came through from Sal. No text this time, just an a video attachment.

This was a weird one. No sex at first. Just clips of Kris naked, showering, eating breakfast, sitting on a sofa reading a paperback novel. Then Rock walked into the frame and extended his hand. Kris seemed to smile as she stood and allowed him to lead her up the stairs.

It was obviously taken out of context, edited to make it seem as if Kris was actually pleased to be with Sal and his men. It got under my skin as calculated, but I couldn't figure out Sal's game. What was the point of taunting me? It wouldn't get his money back. Was he trying to provoke some sort of reckless reaction? Was it just spite?

I kept walking for a long time. When I finally returned to the motel, it was getting dark. We ate some frozen pizza, drank some more beers, and went to bed early.

I woke up in the middle of the night. I lay still with my eyes closed trying to get my bearings. As I did, I realized I could hear them, Jessi and Damon, going at it through the thin walls. She had apparently recovered enough to want it hard, and Damon was obliging. Their bed was creaking, both of them moaning loud.

I felt my own bed was shaking slightly. It took me a moment to pick out Kris's moans, softer, more muffled than those coming from next door. I opened my eyes, gazed over at my wife. She was on her side, facing away from me, her arm beneath the covers, moving rhythmically.

"Does hearing them turn you on?" I asked softly.

Kris startled at the sound of my voice. She stopped moving. Still facing away from me.

"Yes," she replied in a small voice.

We heard Jessi's voice suddenly, surprisingly clear, "Oh yeah, baby."

"Do you wish that was you?"

She didn't answer. But I saw her arm begin to move again.

"Well?"

She thrust back against me by way of an answer. Her hard ass ground into my crotch. I slid my hand under her t-shirt and cupped her full breasts, feeling the sheen of perspiration in her cleavage. Her body was so hot, almost feverish.

"Is that a yes?" I persisted.

"Stop talking," she sighed.

She reached back and roughly thrust her hand into my boxers. She groped for my cock and seized the shaft at the base, stroking me roughly, hungrily. I was already primed and went rigid at her touch. As she felt me stiffen, she yanked my prick between her legs, running the head of my cock along her soaked, wet slit.

Instinctively I thrust forward, hard. She was so wet that I slid in effortlessly. But as wet as she was, she was still amazingly tight. We almost

never made love with me behind her, and spooning like this was a new sensation. I fucked her tight, hot, wet cunt, shocked at myself when those words formed in my mind.

From next door, I could hear flesh slapping, louder, more desperate sighs and moans. I thought back to what Jessi had said as we watched Kris and Damon go at it.

"He's really fucking the shit out of her, isn't he?" I moaned in Kris' ear.

She stiffened then shuddered, her pussy spasming wildly on my cock.

I thrust several more time, each stroke rougher, hungrier. She reached between my legs, fondled my balls. Another first. I groaned and finished inside her.

As we lay there gasping for breath, I realized Damon and Jessi had also gone quiet in the next room.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The next morning, Kris went to call on the DA. Damon accompanied her as her bodyguard in case they ran into any of our nemeses.

I remained at the motel with Jessi. She sat with me at the breakfast table.

"How did you find me?" she asked.

"You mean with Amber?"

She shook her head. "No. The second time. When you and Kris grabbed me?"

I knew where she was going. "I follow you and that asshole lawyer out of the courtroom. I saw everything."

"Everything?"

I nodded.

"Even?"

"Yes," I replied. "I was standing on a dumpster, looking through a window. Should I have tried to stop it?"

She shook her head. "You might not be talking to me right now if you had. I don't think Ramirez would have taken kindly to knowing he was being spied on."

I nodded. There was a lull in the conversation. She obviously had something she wanted to say.

"Were you expecting it?" I prompted.

"You mean, you seeing it?" She shook her head. "No, you mean what happened there?"

I gave a quick nod.

"Fuck, I dunno. Yeah, I guess. Sort of at least. I mean, I guess I knew Tony was setting me up. I knew what was going to be expected of me."

She snorted, continued, "That should have been a tip off, right? After everything I'd done already, Tony and DeMac were still willing to use my ass to close the deal."

"He knew?"

"Tony wouldn't have done it unless DeMac signed off."

"And still you..."

"What do you want me to say? Denial is not just a river in Egypt, right? You think I wanted to believe that I was just a whore to him?" She paused and gave me a smirk. "I'm not the only one in denial."

"Oh?"

"You and Kris. Jesus. How long ago did you realize it was going wrong with you two?"

"It wasn't going wrong."

"It wasn't going right either. Look at the two of you. You're out there playing detective, scheming about blackmailing a drug dealer. And Kris... she should be in fucking shock. Instead, she's plotting to get back into Sal's house on some crazy Mata Hari routine."

"We did what..."

"You had to do," she droned. She paused. "Whatever it takes. I get it. But you're both getting off on this shit. It's the first excitement either one of you has gotten in... in forever."

"That's not fair. You make us seem like we've turned into adrenaline junkies or something. We didn't want any of this."

She shrugged. "I don't want to argue. This is something you two are going to need to explore yourselves. But look, Danny, you saw what happened to me. And that's far from the worst that can happen."

"What are you saying?"

"Why don't you two skip town, start afresh? Get away from all this shit?"

I was shaking my head before she even finished. But even as I was doing so, I realized I was seeing things in a new light.

From the first moment Sal took Kris, I justified everything in terms of recovering our old lives, and my worries revolved around the fear that we might never be able to do so. More recently, I'd begun to worry that Kris had changed. I saw it as a threat. But Jessi's words had catalyzed an emotion I'd been suppressing, the realization that I didn't really want to go back to how things had been. In a weird, crazy way, the life we'd now fallen into was actually fun.

I'd stared down a robber in an alley. I'd navigated strip clubs. I'd had sex with a whore. I'd rescued my wife from thugs at gunpoint. It was insane, dangerous, scary, but oddly addictive.

Thinking about Kris in all of this conjured mixed emotions. She liked it too. But for her the adrenaline was even more sexually charged than with me. I thought about her suggestion of a "flexible" marriage. I forced myself to face that squarely. For Kris, this was not just an adventure; it was a form of sexual liberation. She was unwilling perhaps, at first, but increasingly over time, Kris wanted it. Going back to Sal's was not just a sacrifice she would be willing to make to trap him, she was also, at some level, turned on by the idea of what he would do to her, force her to do to them.

That realization was painful, and yet paradoxically liberating. We both wanted to cast off the old. But that still left two big problems. The first was that I knew intellectually we'd been lucky. Jessi was right. Things could have been a lot worse, and not just for Kris. Surviving near misses was making us bold, maybe reckless. The second problem was that leaving that past behind also called into question our future. What had always bound us together was our normalcy. Could we still be "us" if we embraced the crazy?

We had another group meeting when Kris returned. The news was exciting. DeMac was on a twenty-mile restriction. We didn't even need to lure him across state lines; we could void his bail by just getting him to drive a few miles down the road.

If Kris was the logical person to infiltrate Sal's house, Jessi was the obvious lure for DeMac. That didn't sit well with Damon. Putting women in harm's way violated his values. Mine too, of course. But Kris and Jessi faced us down. Tough broads both of them.

The girls went off together to plot, and Damon and I worked through what we'd need to support them. There was a "spy" shop downtown. They sold mostly overpriced crap, but we picked up a couple of easily concealable GPS transmitters as well as some surveillance mics disguised as earrings.

When we returned to the motel, Kris had washed out her blond hair coloring, and restored her natural mahogany brown. Jessi had reapplied her violet highlights.

Still, despite the preparations, I'm not sure we'd have followed through on the plot until I got a call from my sister.

"Jesus, Daniel, what the fuck have you gotten into?"

"What's the matter, Stace? Are the kids okay?"

Kris gave me a panicked look.

"Yes... for now," my sister replied. "Mom and the kids were at the park. A couple of guys came looking for you. Dick didn't like the look of them. He got the shotgun out. They said you needed to return your calls."

"Are they gone?"

"I think so. Their car is at least. I called Mom, told her to stay away for a bit."

"Okay, okay," I said breathing hard. "Give me a sec."

I filled in Kris and the others. Kris had her hand over her mouth in horror.

"What should we do?" I asked.

"Get your family out of there," Damon said simply.

"Where to?"

He shook his head. "I have some buddies who could hide them."

"No," Kris interrupted. "We need to end this. Call Sal. Tell him we give up. Tell him I'll go back."

Damon slapped his hand on the table. "That's not the answer."

I held up my hand. I was grateful for his passion. But this wasn't his fight.

"Kris, what do you think this will solve?" I asked.

"It'll keep our kids safe, for one. And anyway, it's what we've been planning. I get inside. Find evidence to hold over him. And that's how we end it."

"And what if you don't? What if he doesn't have vids of Jess?"

"Then at least we buy time. Forty-eight hours. I can make it. If I can't get what I need by then, you guys come and get me."

"They'll be expecting it this time," I replied.

She gestured toward Damon. "They won't be expecting him. I trust you guys to rescue me if it comes to that. In the meantime, you three take care of DeMac."

I sighed. "This is crazy."

"It's the only way," she replied firmly.

I looked at Damon. He was still shaking his head. Jessi was watching her sister, a look of grudging respect on her face. I nodded.

"Okay, we'll try it."

I lifted the phone to my lips. "Sis, I need just a few hours to fix this. Accompany Mom back to her place. By the time you get there, I'll have taken care of it."

"Jesus, Daniel, what the fuck is going on?" she asked frantically.

"I can't explain right now. But you just need to trust me. Keep Mom and the kids safe for a few more hours, and then no one will bother you guys anymore."

"Daniel..."

"Stacy! Just do this for me. Please."

"Okay, but you will explain this later."

"Deal."

I hung up with my sister and looked around the room at Jessi, Damon, and Kris. We'd had a couple of days of vacation, lounging around the motel room, drinking beer and fucking. Now it was time to get back to work and deal with Sal and DeMac once and for all.

We split off into couples again.

"I need you to do something," Kris said as she closed the door to the bedroom.

I was sitting on the bed. She was standing by the door.

"Anything," I replied.

"I need you to be my first."

I knew what she meant. "Kris, baby, I don't know if I can do this."

"Yes, you can. We can," she replied. "I need to put Sal in his place. I can't let him think he won."

"He doesn't. He won't."

She shook her head. "You don't understand. He thinks he broke me, broke you. That's what those videos he sent you were all about. He wanted to show you he'd won. Even if we never paid him back, he'd have taken me from you."

"I don't think that."

"No? Not even a little? Tell the truth Daniel. You know you've thought it. Thought that I gave myself to him too easily. And that will always gnaw at you. You'll always doubt me. Always have questions unless, in the end, we unambiguously come out on top."

"I don't want you to go back just to prove a point."

"I'm not," she replied. "There's more. Pride. Trust. Confidence. That's why we aren't running, isn't it? If we didn't care about any of that, we could just skip town. But I don't want to do that. You don't either."

"No, I don't," I replied. "But that's easy for me to say. I'm not the one who is expected to go back into the lion's den."

"I can handle it," she replied. "But I won't give him the satisfaction of pride of place."

"Jesus, Kris, that's so soulless."

She shrugged. "Fine. Then will you at least make love to me before I go?"

"Kris..."

"Daniel, please don't make me beg. I need to feel you in me, smell you on me, when I go there."

"I don't want you to go."

"And yet, you know we have no choice. There is no better option. So let me do it on my terms, on our terms."

"Kris, I dunno know..."

"Forget about that. For now, it is just you and me."

She unbuttoned her jeans, slid them down over her hips. They fell to the floor and she stepped out them daintily. She stepped up close to me, then closer, standing between my legs. My face was level with her crotch, staring at her plain white panties.

She smiled, hooked her thumbs in her underwear and slid them down over her toned thighs. Her fully bare snatch was still novel enough to me to be intoxicating. She grabbed the back of my head. I allowed her to pull me close. I reached around and grabbed her ass cheeks and pressed my face against her sex.

I kissed her smooth, shaved skin, letting my lips trace the outline of her labia. She cooed happily, her hips beginning to move in slow, languid circles. I licked her slit with the tip of my tongue, up and down, each circuit going a little deeper as I felt her pussy lips swell with excitement, gradually opening for me to expose the sensitive pink flesh within.

Her excitement grew. I could feel, taste her wetness. My tongue found her clit. She clenched me tighter, moaning softly. I took her sensitive nub into my mouth, sucked on it, felt it stiffen. She gasped. I let the tip of my tongue flip under the hood of her clit.

"Oh god, oh gawd!" she cried out, bucking against me in passion.

I looked up at her smiling face. She kept a hand on the back of my head, and then slowly spun on her heels. She thrust her ass toward me, pulled me close.

God, I'd dreamed of something like this, never thought it would happen. I was in a sexual fog, acting on instinct. I palmed her ass cheeks, spread them apart. Her tiny puckered rosebud stared me in the face. I leaned in and tongued her ass.

She gasped, a small shudder running through her body. I licked her crack up and down, and then pressed the tip of my tongue into her anus. There was a small metallic, slightly bitter taste, but her response made it more than worthwhile. She groaned in passion. I slid my hand down between her legs, fingered her soaked pussy. She was wetter than I'd ever felt, and her excitement fed my own.

I pressed a finger into her cunt, could feel her vaginal muscles clenching in response. I pushed my tongue deeper into her ass. With my middle finger still in her pussy, I began to tease her anus with my index finger. She groaned excitedly. I pressed my fingertip in her ass.

"Oh God, Daniel," she hissed.

It was only barely inside her, but I was shocked at the sensation. It was as hot as her pussy, but tighter, a band of muscle squeezing my fingertip like a rubber band.

I slowly pumped my digit in and out of her ass, just up to my first knuckle initially, but as she relaxed, I went deeper, to the second knuckle and then more. With my middle finger in her pussy and my index finger in her ass, I slowly penetrated her deeper and deeper, until both my digits were fully inside her.

She was rolling her hips sensuously, moaning. I ran my thumb up her slit and firmly rubbed her clit. She exploded suddenly, gasping and grunting, humping my hand excitedly.

"Oh God, Daniel, oh God," she moaned.

Her pussy spasmed on one finger, her ass clenched on the other. It was about the most erotic sensation I'd felt in my life. Kris was

overwhelmed as well. She fell onto her knees, her head whipping around to look at me. Her eyes were glassy, her face flush.

She spun around and scooted up between my legs. She rubbed my erection through my pants.

"Have you always wanted to do this?" she asked.

I nodded. It had always been a fantasy; one I'd never had the guts to ask for.

"Why didn't we ever before?"

I shrugged. "I didn't think you'd be up for it."

"I probably wouldn't have been. But now it seems weird that we haven't even tried it."

I patted the bed beside me. She sat on the mattress. I kissed her hard, cupping her breasts. For a few minutes, we were back in high school. I remembered the days when just touching her boobs seemed like paradise itself. Back then it would never have occurred to me that we could ever be in a sexual rut. The idea that Kris would be there, available to me, and that I would be uninterested or too tired was literally unthinkable. And yet, we'd spent years that way, often too tired for sex, too shy to explore our needs and desires.

I stood and encouraged Kris to lie on the bed, face down. I slid a pillow beneath her waist, lifting her butt in the air.

"Are you sure?" I asked. "I don't really know what I'm doing."

She smiled at me. "Neither do I. Let's figure it out together."

I didn't have any lube, just my saliva. But that seemed to be enough, especially as I took it slow. She'd already accepted my finger in her ass, had even come as a result of it, so I had a certain confidence as I proceeded.

I coated my finger with spit, pressed it firmly into her anus. She gasped, but sensuously, not in protest, but rather expressing her enjoyment. I took my time, enjoying the sensation, the visual of it.

We usually made love in the dark. Isn't that how married people do it? The very idea of watching seemed almost pornographic. And yet, that is what makes porn so addictive. Seeing, watching that which is normally private?

I pumped my middle finger into my wife's ass. She was very relaxed, her arms over her head, as if enjoying a massage.

"Do you like it?" I asked.

"Mmm, it's different, but feels very sexy."

I added more spit and then added a second finger, just the tips. She groaned and clenched against my digits. I paused until she relaxed again. As she did, I slowly twisted them side to side, penetrating her a little deeper.

"It looks so hot," I said hoarsely.

She was too busy concentrating on her breathing to reply. I imagined she'd gotten some tips from her sister.

I was now inside her to the second knuckle, thrusting gently into her ass. She was moaning softly now. She slid her hand beneath her and rubbed her clit. She began pumping her ass up and down.

"Okay, try it," she said softly.

"You sure?"

She nodded.

I withdrew my fingers and coated my cock with saliva, making sure the head was wet, glistening. As I scooted closer, she reached back and spread her ass cheeks. It was so lewd that I groaned in pleasure.

I took my cockhead, pressed it gently against her anus. I expected more resistance, but she was relaxed enough that with just a little pressure the head slipped inside.

"Oh Jesus," she sighed.

Her ass clenched against my cock. Again I paused until she relaxed. When she did, I began pumping slowly, small little strokes. She let go of her ass, resumed frigging her clit.

I'd never been much interested in anal. Never quite saw the point. But I had to admit it was very hot. The visual was very sexy, but even sexier was the sense of breaking a taboo.

It felt nice as well, different from regular sex and hot for that as well, like thrusting through a thick, tight ring. I was thrusting deeper now, though still very gently.

"Do you like it?" I asked.

"Yes," she groaned. "I feel so dirty. You can go harder."

"You sure?"

"Yes. Do it. Do it Daniel."

I thrust in harder, even deeper, but also faster. She let out a sultry groan.

"More," she sighed.

I knew what she wanted. She needed to know if she could take it when she was with Sal. He was much bigger than me, and would not be as considerate. I tried to put that out of my mind and focus on the task at hand.

I was already close. It looked, felt, so hot. I thrust in harder still. She squealed softly. I hesitated.

"Don't stop," she hissed.

I grabbed her hips, fucked her harder, getting balls deep inside her ass.

"Do it!" she grunted.

I plunged into her over and over. She was gasping, squealing. We weren't making love. Not this time. I was fucking my wife, fucking her up the ass. And she was taking it, like a dirty slut.

"Oh fuck," I growled.

I tensed and came hard, shooting spurt after spurt of hot come in my wife's ass.

I collapsed on top of her, breathing rapidly.

"You liked that," she teased.

Coming had cleared my mind. "Are you okay?"

She laughed. "Yeah, I am. Not sure I want to make that a regular thing. But yeah, I am."

I gently eased my cock from her ass and rolled onto my back. She draped her arm over my chest.

"No one can ever take that from us," she said.

I knew what she meant. No matter what would happen over the next few days, I would always be her first in every significant way. I'm not sure why that was important, but somehow it was.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Kris took a cab up to Forest Glen. Damon and I followed her taxi. It was very weird.

It had felt like such an accomplishment to free her, and now, here we were, going right back into the frying pan. That said, I didn't feel helpless. It is weird to say given the circumstances, but this time it felt like we were the ones in control.

Kris seemed to feel the same way. As she left, she reached out and put her hand on mine. She gave me a small smile and a determined nod. She was tougher than I had ever suspected.

She was wearing the Bluetooth earrings. They were linked to her phone. At least until the batteries ran out, I'd be able to monitor the situation. We didn't expect the power to last long, a couple of hours at most, but that would be the most critical time. Those first few minutes when Kris was back in Sal's hands would be the most dangerous.

I looked over at Damon. He was sitting seemingly calmly, but I could see his eyes making regular sweeps of the car, our surroundings. If things started to go wrong, we'd have to fight our way into Sal's house. With Damon leading the way, I was certain that if that happened, Sal and his men would end up dead. That was not an outcome I hoped would come to pass, mostly because I didn't want their blood on my hands.

We again parked in the street opposite the cut-through. Kris' cab would have to get through the main gate, so we had a few minutes.

Before I had any more time to contemplate what would happen next, the phone rang. It was Kris, making the electronic link.

"Hey Daniel. You there?"

"Always."

She actually managed a laugh. "Good answer."

Then she added, "Wish me luck."

"You won't need it."

"Okay, here goes," she said.

I heard the cab door slam shut. I knew she'd have me muted now so I didn't reply.

"She's going in," I said to Damon.

He nodded. "I'll be outside if you need me."

He knew the next few minutes would be difficult for me. I appreciated the room he offered me.

I heard Kris' footsteps. Then the sound of her ringing the doorbell. I heard the door open, followed by Rock's gruff voice.

"You shouldn't have come back."

"You'll watch out for me," she replied.

"You know I can't do that."

"So I guess that means Sal owns both of us."

I wasn't sure what that was all about. She was obviously getting under his skin, though I didn't know why. It occurred to me, not for the first time, that despite the videos and conversations we'd had, I still had a very spotty understanding of what had transpired during her three days in captivity.

As she entered the house, I could hear the sound of a basketball game on the TV in the background, the squeaking sneakers an unmistakable give-away. I also heard several other voices. I wondered if it would have been better to time Kris' return for a moment when there were fewer people in the house. I wasn't actually sure how that would cut.

I heard a sudden explosion. It took me a moment to realize it was the sound of a cheek being slapped.

"Welcome back, whore," Sal said gruffly.

"I missed you too," she replied sarcastically.

"Why are you back?"

"We need to talk."

"No. First thing you need to do is get naked. You know the rules."

She didn't reply, but it was obvious she was obeying his order, especially when she pulled her shirt over her head and it rubbed against the transmitters in her earrings.

"I see you kept your cunt shaved," Sal taunted after a few moments. "Does your fag hubby like it, or is it just for me?"

"Can we talk now?" she asked.

He laughed. "Not yet, whore. We have some unfinished business."

"Okay, upstairs."

"Nuh uh, bitch. That ship sailed when your asshole hubby aimed a gun at me and you tied me up. No, whore, you're gonna get your ass drilled

right here, with an audience cheering you on."

I knew Kris was resigned to it, knew it would happen, we both were, but it was still hard to hear her submit to him.

"How do you want me?"

"On your knees first."

I could hear fabric rustling, a zipper opening, then the wet slurping sound of a cock getting sucked.

"That's it, whore," he groaned. "Get my cock hard and wet, just right to slide into your ass."

Since the mic was in her earrings, the sounds of her sucking him were obscenely clear. I could hear her slurping him wetly, kissing sounds as his prick slipped past her lips, small gags as he thrust his huge tool in her mouth.

"Fuck baby, you're in rare form today," he sighed. "You been thinking of me, whore? Thinking about how good my cock is gonna feel in your ass?"

She responded to his taunt by sucking him harder, faster. I could now also hear the sound of her fist pumping his shaft.

"That's enough," he said. "Grab the back of the couch and get ready for the fuck of your life."

I could hear other voices now, laughter. I imagined the others in the room clustering around, the better to watch Sal take my wife.

"Oh fuck," she gasped suddenly.

Sal laughed.

"Ugh, ugh, ugh," she grunted.

"Oh yeah, nice and tight. This the first time you take in the ass?"

"Ugh. Yes," she lied.

"You're a natural baby. Just like your sister. You two are born sluts, you know that?"

Kris didn't reply. She just continued to gasp as he hammered her hard. She seemed to gradually get used to it. Her sounds became less urgent, more subdued. Her breaths seemed to slow. He was right. She was a natural.

"So what did you want to talk about?" he asked.

"I... uh... We... uh... couldn't raise the money. I... um... I'm willing to work off the debt."

He laughed. "You should be paying *me* for this."

She didn't dignify it with an answer.

But she'd piqued his interest. "What about sis?" he asked after a minute.

"She'll come in too. But you gotta agree to some stuff."

"I didn't realize we were negotiating."

"Well... ugh... we are. You get my ass. Everything else. Hers too. Until we're... ugh... square. But we can come and go when we need. No fucking real rough stuff. And you leave my kids, my family, alone forever."

"Or, I could just keep you here and do whatever the fuck I want."

She groaned softly.

"Mmmm, you feel that, whore? That's you taking my nine inches balls deep in your ass. You're a fucking pro."

"So, we have a deal?" she persisted.

"What deal? I have you. What are you offering that I can't take?"

She paused. Then in a crisp, clear tone, replied, "Next time, my husband won't leave you tied up. He'll leave you dead."

The room filled with gasps and laughs. She might as well have spit in his face. It was brave, reckless.

"You think you're tough?" he grunted.

He fucked her harder. I could hear his thighs slapping against her ass. His grunts of effort. She was breathing harder as well, but otherwise silent, not giving him the satisfaction of acknowledging his effort to beat her down.

Suddenly, he gasped and the slapping stopped.

"Oh fuck," he groaned. I knew he was coming inside her.

"Do we have a deal?" she asked.

"You're gonna take all of us up the ass, whore," he growled.

"And then, do we have a deal?"

"You fucking whore. Yes. Okay, fine. We have a fucking deal."

I ended the call. I didn't need or want to hear more. She was okay, or at least as okay as possible given the circumstances. Naked, getting assfucked, Kris had nonetheless controlled the situation. I felt strangely proud.

I rapped on the windshield. Damon climbed back into the car.

"She's got it under control," I said tightly. "Let's go."

He nodded. It was my call, after all.

Before going back to the motel we scoped out some potential sites to set up a meeting between DeMac and Jessi, somewhere just outside the twenty mile boundary. The best bet seemed to be somewhere in Harborside. Lots of hotels and restaurants, but only one road in and out.

If we could get DeMac to show, Damon would seize him. We live in one of the six states in the country where you don't need a license to be a bounty hunter. A GPS, time stamped picture of him violating the terms of his bail should be sufficient for Damon to collect a reward for bringing him back in.

But that was the theory. The reality of it was that DeMac wasn't likely to blunder blindly into a trap. In fact, he wasn't likely to come at all. Instead he'd send Tyrell and Boogs and maybe others to finish the job they'd botched earlier. So we needed to find a location that would force DeMac to show his face.

We had a beer at a bar overlooking the bridge to Harborside and tried to hash out details.

"Well, we could have Jessi offer a meeting in a public place," I suggested.

"Yeah, but why would he show up? Anything he might be interested in, whether it's sex or murder, he's gonna want it to be in private."

"That's too dangerous, though. Even if we're there with her, he might just send in his goons, guns blazing."

Damon thought for a moment. "We need to control the access. Maybe Jess invites him to a motel, but doesn't tell him the room number until she sees he's alone?"

"And unarmed," I added.

He shook his head. "You can't be sure about that from a distance. And anyway, he wouldn't need a weapon to fuck up Jess."

"I dunno. She's got a few tricks up her sleeve," I replied knowingly.

"Well, she can just tell him that Kris or someone knows they are meeting. Anyway, I doubt he'll do the dirty work himself. He'll want to establish an alibi. But I don't like the motel idea. He might just decide to send his boys in to case the joint."

I nodded. "Okay so, it's a two-stage process. She invites him to a meet in, say, a public spot. She tells him upfront she won't be there, but

she'll be watching. She's scared. Wants to make sure he's alone. If he is, she'll call and direct him to their real meeting spot."

"You think he'd go for that?"

"Well, that's the only way he'll have to find her. He goes to the private meeting. He probably has his boys following him. He goes, he apologizes, says it was all a terrible mistake, he still loves her, all that shit. Then he leaves, establishes his alibi, and his guys are in position to either kill Jessi right there or trail her from there to wherever."

"I wonder if we're giving this dirt bag too much credit."

"Probably, but seems like this is a pretty foolproof plan," I said.

"Well, you know the old line, right? 'It's impossible to make anything foolproof because fools are so ingenious.'"

It was getting late, but I didn't want to go back yet, back to the motel where I'd be alone with my thoughts about Kris and what was happening at Sal's.

"Let's get another round," I suggested.

He nodded. He didn't make me explain. I was beginning to like this guy.

When we got back to the motel, Jessi was livid.

"Where the fuck have you been?"

I was little buzzed as I replied. "Did we miss curfew, Mom?"

"Fuck you," she hissed. "You just leave me here. No call. No fucking update. I tried calling you, but it went right to voicemail."

I'd never un-muted my phone, so I didn't notice her call.

She was still going on. "For all I knew, all three of you got killed at Sal's."

Damon had ducked behind her, disappeared into their bedroom. He didn't seem to want to face an angry Jessi. I held up my hands. "Okay, okay, take it easy."

"So, what the fuck?"

"I'm sorry, Jess. It's just, I needed a little distraction. Kris is at Sal's. It's... it's going as expected."

"God, I was so fucking worried."

She didn't say anything for a minute. Then she started to laugh.

"You okay?" I asked.

She giggled her response, "Who knew the day would come when Kris is the one out doing unspeakable things with shady characters, while I'm the one at home worrying?"

I laughed as well. Indeed, bizarro world.

"Don't worry Jess, Damon and I have some adventures planned for you too."

She raised an eyebrow. "Oh really? Both of you?"

"What?"

Her mind, I realized, had gone right to sex. I felt a twinge in my pants.

"No, I meant we figured out a plan for DeMac."

"Oh," she replied, sounding a little disappointed.

I shook my head a little ruefully. Truth is, her hummer the other day had only further whetted my appetite. And the thought of tag teaming her was insanely hot, dirty. Still, it felt like a betrayal. While Kris was out, sacrificing herself, how could I be back at the motel, safe and sound, boning her sister?

I suppressed all of that. Instead I briefly laid out the plan we'd worked out. She nodded along.

"That's clever," she said at the end.

"Thanks."

"So, okay, I guess I need to start texting DeMac."

"Texting?"

She nodded. "Yeah. It won't be realistic if I just call and invite him to see me. Need to start off distant, act pissed, let him talk me into getting back together."

"Okay. Right. That's smart too."

She nodded. For a few moments we just looked at each other. She brushed a strand of violet tinged hair out of her eyes.

"Well, good night," I said finally.

"Yeah, good night."

I turned and started toward my room, the room I'd been sharing with Kris but which I'd be sleeping in alone for the next few days.

"Danny? You gonna be okay?"

I didn't look back, but I gave a quick nod. "Yeah. I think so."

I didn't sleep well, or at all. I tossed and turned. I kept thinking about Kris, kept trying to force those thoughts from my head. But it was fruitless.

Every time I came close to drifting off, the images would flood my mind. That was the really devastating implication of those video's Sal had sent. It wasn't just my imagination at work, but also my memories. The fact that I could hear Jessi and Damon fucking next door didn't help.

I tried to close my eyes.

Kris on her hands and knees, being buttfucked from behind by Sal, her big tits swaying beneath her.

I jolted awake. I began to drift off again.

I could see Rock, Jerry, others, clustered around them, jeering at her, taunting her with the fact that they'd each be taking their turns next.

I sat up, walked into the bathroom and splashed my face with water. I looked at myself in the mirror. It was weird. The man staring back at me seemed completely unfamiliar somehow.

I went back to bed.

What else would he do to her? Titty-fucking, facials, double, triple-penetration? He'd want to humiliate her and me. She might be strong enough to take it. I wasn't sure I was.

After an hour of that, I heard some footsteps. My door opened and Jessi padded in. She was wearing just a tee shirt, her face still flush from sex.

"I could hear you tossing and turning from next door," she said simply.

"I'm sorry. I'll keep it down."

"No. I... I just wanted to see if you wanted company."

I didn't really want to talk. But I felt weird chasing her away.

"Sure."

She grinned. With a quick motion, she peeled off her shirt, leaving her buck naked. She lifted up the sheet and crawled into bed with me.

"What are you doing?" I asked.

"Keeping you company," she replied.

She scooted in close, pressed her body against mine. I wrapped my arm around her, my palm resting on her warm, smooth flesh. It did feel

nice.

"What about Damon?"

She mimed sleeping. "I guess I wore him out."

"But you're not sleepy?"

She shrugged. "We girls have more endurance, I guess. Anyway, I wanted to see you."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

For a few minutes, we just lay there. God, how many times had I dreamed about being in bed, naked with Jessi? And now I was, but it was completely different from what I had dreamed. It was comfortable, comforting, rather than dirty and lewd.

"You and Damon really seem to be hitting it off," I said.

She laughed. "I could say the same thing."

"He's a good guy."

"Yeah, he is," she replied. "Too good. He deserves better than me."

"No, Jessi, don't say that."

"What? It's true. But it's okay. You know, that used to scare me. It's part of why I went back to DeMac. Or tried to. He seemed more my speed. Damon deserves better than me, but now I'm thinking maybe that's the motivation I need to be a better person. I mean, isn't that the best thing you can say about a partner?"

I nodded. "So, why are you here?"

"You saying it makes me a bad person to be here with you?"

"I dunno," I replied.

It was a tricky issue. She was here to comfort me, but she was also naked, implicitly offering sex. Monogamy is so prized in our society that it felt wrong for her to be here. She was potentially cheating on Damon, tempting me to cheat on Kris. But the reality was, I wanted her here with me. It was an act of kindness on her part, a potentially pleasurable one, so why did it have to be a betrayal?

"I don't want to get between you and him," I said, giving voice to my main concern.

She shook her head. "Danny. If me coming to you was going to be a problem, then there is no way he'd be able to deal with my past. And if me being here with you is something you can't deal with, then you're not going to be able to come to terms with everything that's happened to Kris."

"I don't get it."

"Yes, you do. Maybe you're not ready to say it out loud. But you get it. We don't betray with our genitals. We betray with our hearts. Or not. Do you love Kris?"

"Of course," I answered.

She snaked her hand into my boxers. She grabbed my cock at the base, stroked me firmly, confidently. I quickly hardened at her practiced touch.

"You're hard."

I blushed, didn't answer.

"Do you still love Kris?"

"Yes."

She dipped beneath the covers.

"Jessi, don't..." I said, without conviction, doing nothing stop her.

She edged my boxers off, swallowed my prick deep into her mouth. Her mouth was so hot and soft. I moaned in pleasure. Women often seem to wonder why men are so hung up on oral sex. The answer is simple. When done well, it is a sensation that just carries you away like the tide. And Jessi was doing it well. She wasn't trying to make me come. She was just bathing my cock in warmth and wetness. When she broke contact, I sighed in disappointment. She slid back up beside me.

"And now, do you still love Kris?"

"Yes," I replied.

I got it. It wasn't a particularly deep point ultimately. I could see the attraction for Jessi psychologically. It was a way to dissociate from her past. So what if she'd had sex for money? Sex is just a physical act. Except it isn't. It is also about intimacy. But I guess that was her bigger point. Sex builds a connection. It gives pleasure. It is comforting. In the end, betrayal is about malicious intentions and dishonesty, isn't it? Without those negative aspects, what is wrong about giving, sharing pleasure?

She was again stroking my hard cock. That one part of my body, at least, knew what it wanted.

I knew I was over thinking it. I was looking to justify doing what I desperately wanted, namely to lose myself, for at least a little while, in the enjoyment of her body. I shut off my mind, determined to let myself do whatever came naturally.

I pulled down the sheet, let my eyes roam over her. God, she was gorgeous, so slender, her stomach perfectly flat, her legs impossibly long. Her nipples were extraordinary, large, red raspberries capping perfect, small, firm mounds.

I leaned forward, took her nipple in my mouth, circled the rapidly hardening nub with my tongue. I switched to the other nipple, trailing my fingers over each bump in turn.

"You have beautiful breasts," I sighed.

She chuckled. "I'm so jealous of Kris' tits. I used to dream about mine coming in, looking like hers. Instead I got stuck with these."

"They're perfect," I said honestly.

I loved Kris' big boobs, always had. But Jessi's were delightful in their own way. They fit her slim, athletic body in a way that hangers wouldn't.

I traced the outline of her breasts, let my fingers roam across the lines of the Sanskrit poem on her rib cage.

"What does it say?"

She laughed. "You really want to know?"

"Yeah."

"Okay... Here goes..."

*Still I recall the white-toothed girl, from whom
It was poison for a moment to be parted;
Then in renewed embrace anointing me
With copious nectar, she new life imparted.
Herself fatigued by love; if she is mine,
Why do I need the trinity divine?"*

"Where is that from?"

"It's a really old poem. Like 1000 years old. The Love Thief. It's about a man who falls in love with the king's daughter. There are happy endings and sad ones."

"It's beautiful."

She laughed. "Most guys just think it looks cool."

"Damon will like it. He likes poetry too."

She raised an eyebrow. It occurred to me that she was going to enjoy getting to know him better over time.

"Mmm, that feels nice," she cooed.

I was still trailing my hand across her smooth skin, feeling the bumps of her ribs, the flatness of her belly. I slid my fingers down over her abdomen. She shivered slightly, sexily. I traced the outline of her sex with my fingertip, spiraling inward to her honey pot.

She was already wet, slippery. Was she excited for me? Was it just leftover from Damon? I didn't really care. It felt so nice. I slipped a finger inside her. Her pussy seemed to clench at me.

We lay side by side. I fingered her gently, letting my thumb trail across her hardening clit. She stroked my cock firmly. We were both breathing hard, in time, our eyes locked. It was an intensely erotic moment, one I never could have imagined I could experience with a woman other than Kris.

"I want you inside me," she moaned.

"I want to be inside you," I sighed in response.

I sat up and slid my boxers the rest of the way off. She pulled her knees up and back to her chest, opening herself completely for me. I kneeled before her and ran my cock up and down her slit. She moaned. It was all the encouragement I needed.

I pressed my prick inside her. This time I moaned, feeling her delightfully tight, hot, wet cunt engulfing me. I slowly churned back and forth.

She reached out and grabbed me by the scruff of the neck. She pulled me close, straightening her legs and spreading them wide to allow my body to press up against hers. I could feel her hard nipples digging into my chest. She kissed me deeply.

I continued to fuck her with deep, slow strokes. I wanted to extend it as long as possible. It was just what I needed. For several minutes, my mind was completely blank but for experiencing Jessi. Her wet, inviting mouth. Her hard, limber body. And most of all the feel of her pussy, hot, wet, grasping at my cock.

She came suddenly, at least to me. It began with a small shiver that ran through her body, but built to a rumbling explosion as she pulled me tight and her cunt spasmed wildly on my cock.

"Oh fuck," I groaned.

I had wanted to last forever, but feeling this gorgeous creature orgasming beneath me was too much. I threw my head back, plunged deep

inside her, and came explosively. I collapsed onto top of Jessi, breathing hard.

As we recovered, she gave me a teasing smile. "You're a pretty good fuck. I finally get what Kris sees in you."

I laughed. "You may not know this, but I've thought about doing this for years."

She laughed as well. "See, it turns out that me ripping off Sal was a good thing."

I shook my head. It was a crazy thing to say... and yet, there was some weird truth to it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

I awoke early to the sound of my phone buzzing. I glanced at the alarm clock. It was 5:43 am. Jessi was still in bed with me, both of us naked. I found the phone, saw the call was from Kris.

"Baby, you okay?" I asked.

"Yeah," she whispered back.

"What's going on?"

"They're all asleep. I'm at his computer."

I couldn't help but think back to Jessi's statement "girls have more endurance." She'd fucked a house full of men into exhaustion. I shook my head. I didn't want to think about it.

"Okay, what can I do?" I asked.

"I need some info. He's got everything password protected. I can't find them written down. I'll try to work on him today. But I need whatever you can get from Jess. How many kids does he have? What are their names? Birthdates? What about pets? What's Sal's favorite sports teams?"

"Um okay," I replied skeptically.

"He's a drug dealer and amateur pornographer, but I bet he picks the same lame passwords the rest of us do."

"Okay. How should I..."

"Email it," she replied quickly. "I need to go. I hear footsteps."

The phone went dead. At least one man in the house hadn't been fucked insensate by Kris. She'd probably be taking care of that shortly.

I shook Jessi awake. We had work to do.

We compiled a quick dossier. From Jessi, we knew his full name, Salvatore Brantone. His son Vincent Brantone. No other kids. Like most douchebags, he rooted for the Red Sox. No pets.

Going online, I found an old arrest record giving his birth date as March 21, 1959.

Vinny had gone to State. Jessi called their registrar and schmoozed a birth date for Vinny out of them, July 9, 1985.

Knowing he was a Sox fan, I sent along some Red Sox related names and numbers: Yastrzemski, Williams, 406, 2004.

It was a long shot, but Sal was a drug dealer, not a cyber criminal. Kris was right. Odds were that his passwords would be just as lame as anyone else's.

We packaged off this collection of data and suggestions in an email to Kris. An hour later I received a quick reply, "thx bye." She still had access to her phone, even if she was using it furtively.

I tried not to think too much about what was happening with her. If I understood the rules, they had her naked and always available for Sal or any of his guests. I tried not to think of it... but I couldn't help it. The images forced their way into my mind whenever I had a spare moment. So the key was to keep myself busy.

Problem was, there was only so much I could do. Damon and I had gone over the plan a dozen times, spinning out various contingencies and options. Should Jessi be armed? Where should he and I be? What if DeMac didn't show? What if his men were following close on rather than waiting for him to leave before moving against Jessi? It was a good way to pass time even as the scenarios became outlandish.

Jess meanwhile had begun an angst-ridden dialogue with DeMac. We watched over shoulder as she slowly allowed herself to be convinced that it was all a big misunderstanding, that Tyrell and Boogs had been freelancing. He called several times. She refused to pick up, texting that she was still too distraught to talk.

She finally spoke to him that night. I listened to her reel him in, alternating between angry, weepy, and naively in love. When she hung up, she rolled her eyes. She was a brilliant actress. It was at once impressive and terrifying. I couldn't help but wonder about what had happened in her young life to make her such an effective manipulator.

DeMac had had to work so hard to talk her into a meeting that he seemed grateful even when she laid out the conditions: he'd show up alone in the parking lot of the Pelican Bay on Harborside, she'd call and direct him to their meeting spot nearby. They set a time, 2:00 pm the next day.

I was sleeping alone. Jessi had poked her head in earlier, but I'd thanked her and sent her away. As much as I'd needed company the previous night, tonight I just wanted solitude.

Everything was coming to a head. It thought about how crazy my life had become. My wife was undercover, literally, with one drug dealer trying to hack his computer. And I was part of a plan to ambush a second drug dealer in a waterfront motel.

I drifted in and out of restless sleep.

My phone buzzed.

"Yeah?" I answered automatically.

I checked the time. 2:26 am.

"Daniel?"

Her voice put a smile on my face.

"You okay Kris?"

She seemed to hesitate before answering. "Yeah. Sure. It's weird, ya know?"

I didn't know what to say.

"Do you hate me?" she persisted. She was speaking in a low, but insistent whisper.

"What?"

"Do you hate me?"

"Jesus, Kris, what are you talking about?"

"Daniel, I've had sex with four men in the past day. Dirty sex. You understand?"

I'd fucked her sister in the same time period. Who was I to complain? But that wasn't the issue anyway.

"You don't need to explain..."

"Yes. I do. They don't have to force..."

"Kris, stop," I interrupted firmly. She paused, and I continued. "Do you like Sal better than me?"

"Daniel, no. What the fuck are you asking?"

I chuckled. "I'm just asking what I already knew. You don't even like any of those men, do you?"

"No," she replied sadly. "That's what makes it so sick."

"Kris, baby, you're not losing me. And I'm not losing you. But the last two weeks... we've discovered a lot about ourselves. And personally,

I'm sort of excited to explore how we live with and indulge these new discoveries."

"Daniel, you don't..."

"I don't understand? Yes, Kris, I do understand. I do. And as long as you're going to be willing to allow me to explore my own desires as you explore yours we'll be okay."

I heard her take in a deep breath. "That's hard."

"Yup. It is. But we can't undo the last two weeks. And we shouldn't want to. If we tried, we'd just end up dying a little with every passing day."

"Daniel..."

"Kris, for twenty years, we followed a nice straight highway. Obeyed all the rules. And now we've swerved off-road. No more lane markers, no speed limit, but it's still the two of us, driving together. Let's enjoy the scenery."

"Scenery, eh?"

"Some scenery is more interactive than others."

She stifled a laugh. "You have no idea."

"Then you'll have to fill me in later."

She swallowed a quick sob. "Daniel, I love you."

"I love you too, baby."

There was a pause before I changed the topic. "So, any luck with his computer?"

"Not yet. But I have a plan."

"Yeah?"

"Describe one of the videos he sent you."

"Why?"

"I want to get him to give me a show. I'm gonna tell him I saw one he sent you. I'll tell him how hot it made me. How much I want to see more. So describe one. A hot one."

"One of them had you swallowing his come. Another had you getting double-teamed by Jerry and Rock. But, I guess, the hottest was one where he filmed you riding him, facing away."

"I remember that," she sighed. "He made me come."

"That's what made it hot."

"You're a pervert," she teased.

"And you're a slut," I teased back.

"Yeah. Who knew?"

Another pause.

Then she filled it. "What about you guys?"

"We have a plan."

"Is it a good plan?"

"I dunno. I guess we'll see tomorrow."

"That doesn't sound good."

I shrugged, though I realized she couldn't see it. "It's no crazier than what you're up to."

"Stay safe," she replied simply.

"You too, baby. And enjoy the ride and the scenery."

"See you soon."

"You too. Goodnight."

I hung up.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

I was back at the bar in Harborside, on the outdoor terrace. I had a pair of binoculars by my side, a book on Sea Birds of North America on the table. It was a little past the lunch rush, such as it was this time of year, so they didn't seem to mind me taking up a piece of prime real estate, especially since the chill in the air meant only a couple of us were out there.

I scanned my surroundings. Below me was a parking lot adjacent to a renovated pier with shops and restaurants. Across the parking lot, I spied Damon in a small park. He was dressed in sweats and doing chin-ups on a set of kids swings. I continued to swing my binocular to the right, until I came upon the Sheraton Harborside. I counted up three floors, scanned from left to right until I spotted Jessi standing in the fourth set of windows peering out into the parking lot.

"Hey guys," I said.

"Yo," replied Damon.

"See anything?" asked Jessi.

I was wearing a Bluetooth earpiece. Jessi and Damon had similar devices and we were all conferenced-in together.

"Not yet," I replied. "We chose a good time to do this. Not a lot of traffic."

"Stay alert," Damon said quickly. "Lots of things can go wrong."

As he spoke, I noticed a black BMW crossing the bridge. Darkly tinted windows. It immediately attracted my attention.

"We may have something," I said.

Through my binoculars, I followed the car into the parking lot. The driver drove cautiously. He pulled into a spot in the far corner, close by where Damon was stationed.

"See it?" I asked.

"Yeah," replied Damon. "Jessi, is that his car?"

"No idea," she replied. "Could be. He's usually in a flashier ride, but might be trying to be low-key."

I laughed. "Only a drug dealer would consider a blacked out Beamer low key."

"Keep an eye out for lookouts or tails," Damon advised.

I scanned the bridge and the lot for activity. There was a UPS truck, an elderly couple heading toward the pier, and a handful of joggers. There was a meter maid slowly waddling around the parking lot, periodically writing out tickets. There were a dozen cars in the lot, but all of them had been there for a while.

"Show time," Damon announced suddenly.

"It's him," Jessi confirmed.

I trained my binoculars on the BMW in time to see DeMac shut the driver's side door behind him. He looked around cautiously. He was in sweatpants and a oversized North Face jacket. I observed him closely, looking for evidence of a weapon, but he could have it hidden anywhere in his bulky outerwear.

He slowly made his way over to the fried dough stand. He ordered a funnel cake and ate it by the railing overlooking the bay. I pulled out my camera with telephoto lens. I got a number of good shots of DeMac, both close ups and wide shots to establish location. At the very least, we had him on violating terms of bail. But we still wanted to bring him in. We couldn't risk him going to ground.

"Anyone else in that car?" Damon asked.

"I dunno," I replied. "Can't see inside."

"So should I call him?" Jessi asked.

"Wait a few minutes," Damon replied. "Dan, keep scanning for anything suspicious."

Nothing jumped out at me. There were shops, cars, tourists, but nothing and no one that seemed out of place. The only person in the parking lot itself other than DeMac was the meter maid making yet another lap of the dozen or so widely-spaced cars. There was no one who seemed to be watching over DeMac.

"I think he might be alone," I said.

"I told you we might be giving him too much credit," Damon replied.

We'd planned all of this on the assumption that DeMac would be looking to construct an alibi before moving on Jessi. But maybe he planned to take her out of the picture himself. I shivered. What the fuck was I doing mixed up with potential killers?

"Either that or he really misses Jessi," I replied optimistically.

She snorted. "Don't count on that. He probably just thinks no one will much care about a dead hooker in a waterfront hotel."

"Alright. I'll head over to you Jess," Damon said. "Give me a couple of minutes, then call him. Dan, keep an eye out. Let us know if he calls anyone after Jess talks to him or if you notice anyone trailing him."

We'd gotten Jessi a second phone to call him so that she could stay connected with both of us. She dialed him.

"Fuck," she snapped. "Says his phone won't accept blocked numbers."

"How are people supposed to reach him? What the fuck kind of drug dealer is he?" I asked.

"One who's out on bail and needs to be careful," Damon replied. "Alright, Jess, you'll need to call him on your phone. We'll add you back on the call after."

"Okay," she replied.

She disconnected from the conference call. A minute later, I saw DeMac reach into his pocket and pull out his phone. As he spoke, he looked around, obviously trying to figure out where she was. They spoke for a couple of minutes, and then he turned toward the Sheraton. I could see him scanning the windows, but she'd drawn her curtains and was, at most, peering at him through a crack.

He continued to look around and then began to stalk toward the hotel. I searched the parking lot and the area around with my binoculars. I kept checking his car to see if anyone else might be hidden in there.

"You see anything?" Damon asked. I could hear him climbing stairs.

"No. Looks like he's alone."

"Okay, I'll wait in the room with Jessi. Looks like he's gonna make it easy on us."

"Maybe," I replied.

"I'll call her and let her know I'm on my way."

He hung up on me. I saw him walk through the side door to the hotel. DeMac heading toward the main entrance.

I didn't know why, but I had a weird sense of unease. He was apparently making it easy on us. Too easy. He'd already tried to have Jessi killed once. He had to suspect a trap. And yet, here he was, violating his bail terms, on his own. He was either overconfident or maybe he was being

honest when he claimed that Tyrell and Boog had gone rogue. Something wasn't adding up, but I wasn't sure what.

And then it struck me. We were out of season. Parking was free this time of year. I searched for the meter maid. I spotted her moving briskly toward the hotel... and as I looked closer, I realized it wasn't a she. It was Tyrell. He was on the phone. Not to DeMac who was still walking, hands in pocket. There was someone else nearby.

I fumbled with my phone, dialed Damon's number. No answer. Had he muted it? Had he lost reception in the building? Had someone jumped him?

I leapt up and ran out of the bar. I began moving toward the hotel. I felt in my pocket for my gun. My heart was racing. I started to call Jessi, but in my anxiety I misdialed. Fuck. No time to try again.

I was through the front door. I looked around the lobby for DeMac or anyone else suspicious. No one. Just a bored looking clerk behind the front desk, engrossed in her Smartphone.

I looked at the elevator. Saw it stop on three. I found the stairs, took them three at a time. My heart was pounding. I could feel sweat running down my face.

I pushed open the door to the third floor. Half way down the corridor I heard a woman scream. A door slammed. I ran toward Jessi's room.

At the other end of the hall I spotted a large mass crumpled by the emergency exist. It was a man. He lifted his head. Damon. His faced covered in blood from a gash on his forehead. He forced himself up onto his arms. His eyes rolled back into his head and he collapsed again.

No time to check on him. I reached into my pocket for my gun, yanked at it, but it snagged on the fabric. With my other hand I was already pushing open the door to her room. I burst through the door before freeing my weapon.

Jessi looked up at me from her knees, tears in her eyes. Standing behind her was Boogs, his gun pressed into a pillow against the back of her head. I didn't have time to think. I launched myself at him.

He lifted his arm instinctively. As I sprinted into the room, I caught a movement in my peripheral vision. I ducked my head to avoid a fist. I was off my feet. There was a gunshot, deafeningly loud by my ear. I choked on a

cloud of shredded foam as the bullet exploded the pillow. From behind me I heard a thud, a wet splash.

My momentum carried me into Boogs. We both collapsed onto the floor in a pile. I was laying on his arm, the same arm Damon had injured in the other motel room. I brought my fist down hard on his wrist. He howled in pain, released the gun. He tried to grab it again, but instead knocked it under the bed. I spun around.

We were face to face. I brought my forehead down on his already flattened nose, a spurt of his warm blood splashed on my face. He recoiled, slammed his own head against the floor knocking himself out.

My head ached. There was a ringing in my ears. Through it all I heard a scream.

"Danny, watch out!"

Too late. My ribs exploded in pain, I flew into the air, landed on my back. I looked up to see DeMac standing over me, a handgun in my face. I could see into the barrel. A tunnel with no light at the end of it.

Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Jessi racing toward him. He wasn't taken by surprise. He launched his fist at her, caught her flush on the cheek. She crumpled across me, my ribs exploding again in agony. Her head lolled from side to side.

That was it. I couldn't lift her off me. I could barely breath. DeMac reached for the pillow. He put it down on my face. I felt him press his gun against the other side.

I thought of Kris. And our kids. God how I'd miss them. We'd gone off-road, just for a few weeks, and now I was dead.

"What the fuck?" DeMac suddenly shouted.

I shook the pillow off my face just in time to see Damon, blood still running down his face, lifting DeMac off the ground. DeMac was flailing around wildly, trying to bring his gun hand around. Damon seized his wrist and shook the weapon loose.

Two quick punches to the kidneys and DeMac dropped incapacitated.

"How bad are you hurt?" Damon asked.

"I have some busted ribs I think," I groaned. Even taking small breaths was excruciating.

He pulled Jessi off me, laid her on the bed.

I immediately felt better.

"Can you stand?" He asked.

I grabbed his outstretched hand and he lifted me to my feet.

"Yeah," I replied clutching at my side.

"Watch him," he said, pointing at DeMac who was still rolling around in agony.

Damon returned shortly with some wet towels. He pressed one against Jessi's forehead as she slowly stirred. With the other he mopped the blood from his face and put pressure on his own head gash.

DeMac shook his head. Tried to press himself off the ground. Damon ended that with a quick, brutal forearm to his face.

"We need to get out of here, now!" Damon ordered. "Grab her. I'll take him."

Jessi was coming around. I lifted her to her feet. She wrapped her arm around my neck, mine was around her waist. We stumbled toward the door. Both of us froze. An entire wall was splattered with blood. Tyrell's body was slumped below, his face almost completely obliterated.

"Oh Jesus," I sighed.

"Go, go," Damon urged.

Jessi and I hobbled along. Damon followed with DeMac over his shoulder. Going down the stairs was agony. The sound of sirens in the distance kept us going though. We went through the side door and stepped right into our car parked right outside.

I drove. Jessi was in the passenger seat, staring dazedly out the window. Damon was in the back with DeMac. We'd flex tied him and Damon was sitting on his chest to keep him still. We crossed out of Harborside just as a line of cop cars drove in.

We needed to go to the hospital. All of us had been banged up pretty good. But first we had to get rid of our guest.

"You sure that's not gonna kill him?" I asked, looking back at DeMac straining under Damon's weigh.

Damon shrugged. "It shouldn't."

I drove a little faster. I wanted to get rid of him before we found out for sure. On the way, Jessi emailed the pictures we'd taken of DeMac at the pier to Ramirez. An email back told us to bring him in.

Driving past the courthouse, with cops and prosecutors all over the place was paranoia inducing. But no one stopped us as we turned the corner and pulled out to the bondsman's shop.

Damon manhandled DeMac out onto the sidewalk and shoved him toward the front door. As they ducked inside, DeMac looked back at us in the car with such a murderous look that I doubted prison would stay his vengeance. His brother was dead. We'd caused it. He'd never forgive, never forget.

A few minutes later, Damon emerged, stuffing a thick envelope into his pocket. He opened the door to the car, and as he did, I heard a loud pop coming from the pawnshop. Damon went wide-eyed.

"Go, go," he hissed.

I pressed down on the gas.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

A doc-in-the-box stitched up Damon. He had a minor concussion as well. I went to the local emergency room where they diagnosed two broken ribs. There was nothing they could do for me other than prescribe painkillers. Jessi ended up with just a bruise across the cheek.

We sat in the motel room, too dejected to talk. Everything had gone horribly wrong. We'd almost gotten killed. We'd left a dead body in a hotel room. We should probably have made a run for it, but what was the point? It was only a matter of time until the cops tracked us down.

I flipped on the local news. It was the lead story. "Drug War!" screamed the chyron.

"Police today arrested Robert 'Boogs' Powell, of Cederville, on suspicion of the double murder of drug lords DeMarcus and Tyrell Martin. Police suspect that Powell may have sought to take advantage of DeMarcus Martin's recent arrest to bolster his own position in the drug gang. Sources close to the investigation believe Powell had accomplices, likely other members of the Martin drug ring.

"Police responding to reports of gunfire at the Sheraton Harborside discovered Powell unconscious in a room with Tyrell Martin's body. There was evidence of a struggle that culminated in Martin's demise. DeMarcus' body was later found in a dumpster in Iron City. He had been shot in the back of the head at close range."

Drug war? Gang accomplices?

"What just happened?" I asked.

Damon shook his head. "Well, Boogs did shoot Tyrell. And it is a hotel room. There has got to be physical evidence of hundreds of people in there. Unless they have a good reason to think someone else was involved, I doubt they'll press too hard."

"What about DeMac?"

"Ramirez was probably watching the news. He put two and two together. Figured that if DeMarcus was involved in the shooting he'd definitely skip town if he had the chance. They decided to safeguard their bond by offing him."

"But we know he was alive when he got there," I said shakily.
"We're witnesses."

"Yeah, and Ramirez knows we were in Harborside. I'm guessing he figures we aren't likely to talk. We'd take the 10 Gs in cash and forget about it."

"This is so fucked up."

"Yeah it is," echoed Damon. He walked toward the bedroom. Over his shoulder he muttered, "I need to sleep. Don't wake me."

I turned toward Jessi, winced in pain as my torso twisted. She was sitting beside me, mute. She hadn't said a word since we'd left the bondsman's shop.

I pulled my container of Codeine from my pocket and popped a capsule, washed down with beer.

"You want some?" I asked her.

She nodded. I shook out two capsules. She swallowed them dry.

"You okay?"

She looked at me. "Yes," she answered, shaking her head.

I chuckled mordantly.

"Or not."

"It's okay to feel sad you know."

"The fucker tried to kill me. Twice. He traded my ass for a bail bond. I should hate the motherfucker. But I keep thinking of him, feeling that gun barrel on the back of his head just before he bought it. Jesus."

"He was an asshole," I replied. "But also probably the first man who ever even seemed to care about you, right?"

She looked at me silently. Her eyes slowly glazing over. A tear ran down her cheek.

"You saved my life," she said softly.

I shrugged. "I can't say I planned it. If I'd thought about what was happening, I would probably have run."

"I didn't even mean in the hotel room. I meant you and Kris..." she trailed off.

"Naw. You didn't need us. You're tougher than you realize."

She shook her head again. "No. I'm much softer than I ever thought."

I shrugged. "Ah, who the fuck knows what we are. Who cares?"

She didn't reply. Instead, she gently pressed herself against me. I wrapped my arm around her. I felt her body soften, mold itself to mine. She felt so delicate, so breakable.

I didn't wake until early morning. Every inch of me ached. My ribs throbbed. My arm was asleep under Jessi's head. My neck was stiff.

I pushed her off me gently. She curled up on the sofa like a cat and went back to sleep. I stood, popped another Codeine and gingerly woke my arms and stretched out my sore limbs.

A wave of panic washed over me. It had been over thirty hours since I'd heard from Kris. I checked my phone. Out of juice. Fucking iPhones.

I plugged it in and a moment later it buzzed with a voice mail notification. It was from Kris, at 4:33am. She was brief, but oddly excited.

"I got it and more. You won't believe what I had to do get it. But check email. Once upload is done, come get me."

I checked my email. Nothing. What was she talking about? Was I supposed to go get her? Both Jessi and Damon were still racked out. I decided not to wake them quite yet. Instead I went out and picked up the usual coffee and doughnuts.

"Whoa, dude, rough night?" asked the clerk. He was young guy, had obviously worked the overnight. He had tats peeking out from under his shirt, combat boots.

I looked at my reflection in the mirror behind the bar. I had deep circles under my eyes, a massive bruise on my forehead.

"You have no fucking idea."

He nodded. "Have a bear claw on the house," he said, tossing the extra pastry into my bag.

"Thanks man," I said, surprised at the implication of kinship.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Jessi and Damon were up when I returned, both of them looking as haggard as I felt. We ate in near silence, the TV providing background noise. There was no more news about the double killing. In twelve hours it had already dropped off the radar. No one cared about the death of a couple of drug dealers.

I checked email obsessively. I hadn't mentioned the voice mail to Jessi and Damon. I didn't know what it meant, didn't want to speculate about it until I knew more.

And then mid-morning I logged on and received a notification from Google: "User KrisTaylor82 has shared a file with you."

I clicked on it. It was a video. It opened with a close up of Jessi. She was even more slender. Her face almost gaunt. I didn't need to see more. I stopped it.

I turned to Jessi and Damon. "It's over guys. Let's get Kris."

Jessi turned to me.

"What happened," she asked apprehensively. "What did you see?"

I shook my head. "Nothing. I don't need to watch it."

"Okay," she replied.

Damon gave me a quick nod of thanks.

"Let's go," I repeated.

They followed me out. We got into the car and drove up to Forest Glen.

I knocked on the door. Three firm raps. Pause. Another three. Jerry answered the door in boxers, a white tee shirt, and a shoulder holster.

"Nice look," I snarked. "Let us in."

He hesitated.

"Your boss will want to see us. Move over."

"Good timing," he said with a leer, "wifey is putting on a show."

I pushed past him. Damon and Jessi followed.

We surged into the living room. Even after everything I'd seen and done, I gasped at the depravity on display.

On the TV was a high def close up of Kris sucking on Sal's fat tool. And there on the sofa was my wife servicing three men at the same time. I recognized them from the bachelor party. She was bouncing up and down on the fat kid with the Rolex, while the frat boy was enjoying her mouth. Sal's kid, Vinny, had the place of honor, standing behind her, ramming his cock into her ass over and over.

With her mouth full of cock, Kris was limited to grunts and gasps, but her body told the story. Glistening with sweat, she was the enthusiastic center of the triangle, responsive and eager, she thrust back against each invading prick, determined as it seemed to make each man pop as quickly as possible.

Sal was moving around them, filming on an iPad.

"That's it, fuck that whore," he growled at the younger men. "She can take it, she can take anything."

As he circled them, he looked up and saw us. He looked at me first, glanced apprehensively at Damon, then fixed on Jessi.

"Star, baby, looks like I found a bigger slut than you. But don't worry, I have big plans for you too."

At the sound of his voice, the rutting foursome looked over at us. Vinny retreated at the sight of Damon's menacing glare. Kris disentangled herself, though I noticed she gave the fat kid one last roll of her hips before lifting off him. She approached me looking a little sheepish.

I gave her a smile and took her hand.

"What do you think you're doing, whore? We haven't even started with you today," Sal said. His bravado seemed forced.

"Enough Sal. I'm leaving with my wife," I replied.

"You think so?" He laughed. He looked over at Jerry who had drawn his gun.

"Yeah. It's over."

He hesitated.

"Not until I say it is," he replied, though I noticed a hint of apprehension in his voice.

I turned toward Jerry. "Put that fucking gun away. Pour us some drinks. Your boss and I need to talk."

Jerry looked over at Sal. Sal looked from me to Jessi to Damon. He looked at Kris standing there defiant, unbowed. He seemed to deflate. It was over.

We sat in his living room, Kris now covered in a robe of her own. I debated letting her drop the hammer, but decided I wanted to do it myself.

"You know what they do to kiddie diddlers in prison," I asked.

Sal bristled at the accusation. "I don't fuck kids."

"No, just underage hookers. You film them too."

He glanced over at Jessi. She flipped him the bird.

"Her word against mine. No one is gonna believe a coked up whore."

I saw Damon surge upward. Jerry raised his weapon. I held out my hand. It wasn't worth it. Damon got the message. He sat back down.

"They don't have to. We have video."

"You... what?" Sal stammered. He turned toward Kris.

She shrugged, a grin on her face. "You probably shouldn't have left me alone, logged in on your computer."

His face dropped.

"So here is how it is going to go," I continued. "We're going to leave now, and you're never going to bother any of us again. And you had better hope nothing happens to Kris and me, because if it does, those videos go right to the district attorney."

"Fuck you," he snarled. "You owe me. And your whore wife and her whore sister are going to keep working it off until I say I say when."

I shook my head. "No. We're not negotiating. I'm just telling you how it is. It's over. We go our separate ways now. You go back to selling coke and whatever else you do. We go back to our lives. Just write it off as a bad couple of weeks of business."

He looked at the four of us, then at Jerry. I could see him trying to figure a way out. But anything would be cutting off his nose to spite his face. I was pretty confident that he was too much of a capitalist to do that.

He laughed and turned toward Kris. "You're the most expensive piece of ass I've ever had."

Then he faced me. "We turned her out, smart guy. You know that, right? All of us. Her cunt. Her ass. Her mouth. Next time you kiss her, think about how many loads of come she swallowed. Live with that."

I shrugged. "Then I guess you got your money's worth."

"Get out of here," he snapped.

As we drove back to the motel, we told Kris the story about the shootout at Harborside.

"Did you really launch yourself at an armed man?" Kris asked.

"He sure did," Jessi interjected. "You should have seen him."

I shrugged. "I wasn't really thinking. It just happened."

I thought back to that night after the theater. I know Kris was doing the same. It felt like a lifetime ago. In a way it was. I felt like a wholly different person now, and from the way she was looking at me, I knew Kris was seeing me in a new light as well. It made me uncomfortable. I changed the subject.

"How did you hack his computer?" I asked.

"I didn't," she replied.

"So..."

"It's a little tawdry," she replied, but her grin made it clear she wanted to tell the story.

I laughed. More tawdry than walking in on her getting triple teamed?

"I presume you induced him into giving you his password?"

"Not quite. I asked him if I could see some of the videos he took of me. And when he showed me, I told him they turned me on so much that I couldn't control myself. So we watched some of them, um, together. And when he was done, I got him ready, and we watched another. Then a third time. And at the end of that, I told him I wanted even more. So he went to rest for a couple of minutes, while I kept watching and, you know, playing with myself. When he started snoring, I started uploading files."

"God, Sal's right. You have turned into quite a whore, sis," Jessi said with a laugh.

"I have a long way to go to catch up to you."

"It's not a competition," I offered.

"I'd have to step up my game to keep up," Jessi teased.

It was weird. We were all more than a little giddy. Excitement, lack of sleep, a feeling that we'd gotten away with something. I should have been devastated to hear about how my wife had fucked a houseful of men into submission. Instead, I was amused, proud, maybe even a little turned on.

I pictured her sitting in Sal's lap, riding his big cock, her boobs bouncing in his face as they watched dirty videos on his computer. It was a strangely sexy image, made even hotter by the realization that she was playing him, had played him perfectly.

"There's more," Kris said suddenly. "I've been a bad girl."

"We already know that," I replied.

"No. It's just... I didn't just upload videos while I was on his computer."

"Oh?"

"Well, he had his bank bookmarked. So I decided to check it out. I guess he didn't think about it. But he had his online banking password saved. And well, I made a little transfer."

"You didn't," I replied.

"I did."

"How much?"

"Ninety-seven thousand dollars. I left him a grand in his checking account. I didn't want him to get charged any fees."

I looked at Kris, then back at Damon and Jessi who were both gaping at Kris incredulously.

Kris shrugged. "Well, he did say I was the most expensive piece of ass he'd ever had."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

On the way back to the motel, we stopped by the market and picked up some bottles of cheap champagne and a bucket of chicken wings, a redneck celebration feast.

Back in the room, we put on some music, got drunk. The girls got up and starting dancing. There was lots of laughing, silliness. They pulled Damon into the mix, the two sisters grinding on him lewdly. My cracked ribs kept me on the sideline, but it was fun watching them. I don't think I'd ever seen Kris and Jessi so playful with each other.

It was also sexually charged. Both Damon and I had been intimate with both sisters. Given the celebratory mood and the fact that we still had a couple of bottles of champagne to drink, I knew things would become still more charged. I wondered which one I'd end up with tonight.

After a while, Kris came over and sat down heavily beside me. A surge of pain rushed through my ribs. I almost reached for a Codeine, but decided against it.

"We go back to our lives tomorrow," she said with a slight slur. She never could hold her champagne.

"Uh huh."

I'd called my mom already and told her we'd be picking up the kids. Kris was looking at me expectantly. I knew what she was looking for.

I pulled her close. Kissed her hard on the mouth, mashing her big boobs with my hand. Jessi and Damon where looking over at us, grinning at our PDA.

"We might as well live it up tonight," I suggested.

Kris immediately shot a quick look at Damon before giving me a big smile.

I reached for the bottom of her shirt, lifted it over her head. She reached behind her and unsnapped her bra, letting her full breasts spill out. Leaning over was painful, so I maneuvered her into my lap and began sucking on her nipples in turn until they stood erect and turned dark red. She was moaning softly, grinding her pussy against me through our pants.

She leaned in close and kissed my neck, alternating between firm sucks and tender tickles with the tip of her tongue.

I whispered in her ear, "So you want to fuck him again?"

She stiffened a little, then went back to sucking my neck. "Does that upset you?"

"I'd have thought you'd have had enough strange cock to last you a lifetime," I replied.

"Maybe I like strange cock."

I reached between us, firmly grabbed a nipple with each hand. "Oh, I know you do. You make your sister look like a nun."

We both looked over at them. They were getting in the mood as well. Jessi had peeled off her jeans and was dancing around in her tiny panties. Damon had his shirt off, showing off his muscles and tattoos. Kris groaned softly and ground harder into my erection.

I heard another champagne bottle pop open. Jessi came by and refilled our red Solo cups.

"That's the lamest lap dance I've ever seen," she teased. "Let me show you how it's done."

I groaned as Jessi pulled Kris off me. But it was hard to complain too much when Jessi proceeded to strip off the rest of her clothes and straddle my legs. She swayed back and forth sexily and ran her hands down her sides and over her toned thighs. When she reached her knees, she brought her hands back up her inner thighs, pausing to spread her pussy for me before continuing up over her belly and and palming her breasts.

She pressed her knee into my crotch and again caressed herself. This time she let out a sultry moan as she touched her snatch. She leaned forward and let her hair brush my face. She sucked on my earlobe, moaning at the same time. Then she switched knees, and did it again.

Kris had sat down next to me on the sofa and was watching us closely, her face flush, breathing hard. Damon sat behind her, gently rubbing her back, her shoulders.

Jessi turned on her heels and waved her ass at me. She bent low at the waist, and with her fingers spread her labia again to give me a glimpse of the pink within from between her legs. She reached back and grabbed a firm ass cheek in each hand, pulling them apart, flashing me her tight little rosebud.

She lowered herself into my lap, pressed her ass against my hardon, gyrating in firm, slow circles. I reached around and caressed her stomach, cupped her breasts, feeling her hard little nips sliding between my fingers. A few more minutes of that and I'd have come in my pants. Jessi seemed to sense it though, and not wanting to conclude her tease, she rose up off me.

She straightened again and then turned to face me. Her pussy was puffy now, split. She lifted one leg, placed it on the back of the sofa and brought her snatch closer to my face. I could smell her excitement, feel the heat coming from within.

It was intoxicating, irresistible. I grabbed her ass cheeks and pulled her firmly toward me, burying my tongue in her vagina, sucking her clit into my mouth. She grabbed the back of my head, ground her wet twat into my face.

I startled a bit when I felt Kris's hands in my crotch, unzipping my pants. With a bit of effort I lifted slightly off the couch enough to allow her to slide off my jeans and boxers. I wasn't exactly sure what to expect next, wasn't really much thinking of anything but the luscious creature grinding against my face.

Kris swallowed me deep into her mouth, her tongue twirling around my shaft, her hands fondling my balls. I arched my back involuntarily and suppressed a groan as my ribs screamed out in pain. It would take more than a passing moment of physical agony to forego the experience I was enjoying.

I dug my fingers into Jessi's ass, feeling her hard muscular butt, loving the way she was now gyrating raggedly. Her moans were getting louder, her pussy so wet that I could feel her juices coating my lips, my chin, my cheeks. In the meantime, Kris was sucking on me harder, taking me fully inside her mouth, bobbing up and down vigorously.

Again, I was close. Then Kris pulled away, leaving me to groan in frustration into Jessi's beaver. I looked up to see Kris' hands on Jessi's shoulder, pressing her down into my lap. I gasped at the realization that she was trying to get her sister impaled on my cock.

Jessi was eager. She grabbed my cock firmly and with a sigh sat firmly on my prick. She was so hot, so wet. She wrapped her arms around my neck, kissed me hard, tasting herself on my lips. At the same time, she began to grind against me.

Jessi broke the embrace and leaned back, her hands on my thighs, her body arched backward as she pumped her hips back and forth. As she did so, Kris leaned in and kissed me wetly. Kris and I wrestled tongues even as Jessi slung her pussy back and forth on my cock. It was unimaginably erotic.

Kris slowly pulled away, our kisses shallower and shallower until just our lips were touching. She gave me a last quick flick with her tongue. Damon was in the corner of the sofa, and Kris lay back against him. He wrapped his muscular arm around her and gently began playing with her nipples.

For a while they both just watched us, their faces aglow as they watched Jessi and I fucking in front of them. Kris turned her head and they awkwardly, but passionately, kissed. His hand drifted downward, over her flat belly, down the front of her yoga pants. Through the clingy fabric, I could see him gently fingering her pussy. Kris closed her eyes and moaned passionately.

Suddenly Jessi slapped me across the face, playfully, yet firmly. She stopped pumping her hips. I looked up at her.

"Pay at least a little attention to the girl you're fucking," she teased.

"Sorry," I replied.

She gave me another small slap. "Don't you forget it."

"I won't. Now get back to work." I gave her a grin and spanked her ass.

We locked eyes for a few moments as she resumed fucking me. I looked over her body, taking in her fit, toned arms, the bulge in the vein in her neck as she began to move faster. I watched her small breasts, jiggling slightly, her nipples hard as erasers. I admired her flat stomach, her abs rippling as she thrust. But the sexiest thing was her tight, little pussy swallowing my cock over and over.

I reach out and rested my hand on her abdomen, sliding my thumb across the top of her slit until I felt her swollen clit. I made slow circles against it, gradually increasing the pressure. She moaned, gasped, wheezed, and then with a growl I felt her pussy spasm around my shaft.

Jessi leaned forward, put her hands on my shoulders, and fixed me with a fiery gaze. She thrust even harder, faster against me. Every moment I didn't come seemed an affront to her. I reached around, grabbed her ass,

squeezed her cheeks hard enough that I worried I would leave bruises. She rode me like a demon.

I felt my balls tighten. I came hard, each spurt causing my abs to contract, which in turn set fire to my ribs. It was agony and absolutely, completely worth it.

"Now that is a lap dance," Jessi crowed.

"I'll say," I replied.

But Kris wasn't paying any attention. She was still draped across Damon. Her eyes were closed. His hand still in her pants, her hand was wedged beneath her, probably rubbing his crotch.

"Oh God, I need it," Kris sighed softly.

She rolled off him so that she was now sitting right beside me. She peeled off her pants, exposing her pussy, swollen and wet and more than ready. She slid down on the cushions and spread her legs wide.

Damon gave me a quick glance. Jessi was still in my lap, kissing my neck, and still grinding her wet snatch against my cock. I gave him a quick nod. He smiled and pulled down his own pants.

He kneeled between my wife's thighs. Fuck, he was hung. He rubbed his thick, veiny tool against Kris' pussy. She pumped her hips involuntarily.

"Don't tease me," she hissed.

He grabbed her thighs and slowly eased his big cock into her receptive box. She arched her back, her big tits thrusting toward the ceiling. He gave her a long, slow stroke. She moaned and reached out, gripping my hand firmly.

Damon fucked her with deep, deliberate thrusts. Each time he filled her, she gave my hand a hard squeeze. It was weirdly intimate, and the sensation was further enhanced by Jessi's excited reaction to watching her sister getting fucked. With each thrust, she'd moan hotly in my ear.

My cock softened and slipped out of Jessi. When it did she gave me a deep kiss and then slid out of my lap. She kneeled down beside Damon and rubbed his shoulders. Her eyes were wide, locked on the sight of Damon's cock penetrating Kris over and over and over.

"Fuck her, baby, give it to her good," Jessi urged.

Kris opened her eyes and looked up at her sister in surprise.

"She's a whore," Jessi continued. "Wear her out."

She turned toward me. "Tell him, Danny."

Kris squeezed my hand. I grinned.

"Yeah, do it," I grunted.

He thrust harder. She was so wet that her pussy squished wetly.

"Harder," I urged.

Damon pulled almost all the way out and then plunged again deep into my wife. Kris arched her back and gasped.

"Again," I ordered.

He hammered into her over and over. Kris was moaning loudly, her head now swinging back and forth with each stroke. Jessi cupped Damon's ass, urged him on. I saw her fingers slid between his muscular ass cheeks. His thrusts became ragged.

Suddenly Kris squeezed my hand painfully. Her body shuddered violently.

"Oh fuck," Damon groaned.

Jessi reached around and seized Damon's cock by the base. She yanked him from Kris' pussy and jerked him roughly until he came. His jism splashed across Kris' body, a thick rope of come lacing her breasts, the rest pooling on her belly.

Kris was still lost in passion, her body humping up and down slowly. She released me and slowly rubbed the come into her skin like lotion.

"Fuck, that's hot," I sighed.

"Yeah, shit," Kris confirmed.

Jessi laughed. "Welcome to the dark side."

Kris looked up at her sister and then from her sister to Damon.

"And welcome to the light."

"You're all fucking crazy," Damon said with a laugh.

We all joined him, all of us drunk, naked, and sexually sated... at least for now.

EPILOGUE

I tossed Damon a beer, which he caught and opened in a practiced motion. He was sitting on our newly constructed deck.

"Not bad, huh?" he said looking around.

"Not bad at all," I replied. "Did they teach you construction in the Navy?"

"Naw," he chuckled. "They mostly taught us how to blow shit up." I laughed as well.

The deck project came out of Damon's guilt. He'd been living with Jessi for several weeks now, in the *au pair* suite. He kept offering to pay rent to Kris and me, but we could never take money from the guy. We'd always be in his debt.

Working together on home improvement projects was a compromise, a chance for Damon to contribute to the household without money changing hands. I had an ulterior motive as well. I just liked hanging around with him. We'd worked together, digging postholes, pouring cement, hauling lumber, sawing, hammering, and even though it was exhausting it was also just fun.

If you'd told me, a few months ago, that my new best friend would be a tattooed ex-Navy SEAL who also happened to be my wife's lover, I would never have believed it. If you told me that I'd also be sleeping with my sister-in-law... well, a lot had changed in our lives.

I don't want to make it seem as if it was a constant orgy. For the most part, Damon was downstairs with Jessi and Kris upstairs with me. But, well, our love lives had become more flexible.

So had our professional lives. Both Kris and I had lost our jobs. Jessi wasn't dancing or hooking anymore. The money Kris had stolen from Sal had reset our finances and given us a small cushion, but we still needed to work.

I initially looked for another engineering position. I got an interview and spent the whole time looking out the window. The idea of moving back into a cubicle, writing and reviewing specifications, was

almost physically painful. When I didn't get the job, I was actually relieved. Kris felt the same way about her job. Our old lives seemed so far away.

In the meantime we'd taken on odd jobs. Kris was doing some bookkeeping and copyediting. I'd taken a part-time job for one of the "geeks on call" services, helping technologically clueless people plug in their computer and configure their home WiFi. I liked being out and about, working on different short projects. But I was also doing some research on the side for something longer term.

"You still thinking about trying to be a PI?" Damon asked.

I nodded. "I think I did pretty well as a rank amateur. You going to join me? Or are you committed to tending bar for the rest of your life? I could use a partner. You know, some brainless muscle."

"Seems like a lot of sitting around and waiting."

"And taking pictures of adulterers."

He laughed. "I'll think about it."

We clinked our bottles and drained them.

"You get the next round," I said.

"Yes, boss."

One Friday, I came home after a tech job. It was a lovely spring day, sunny, a little windy, crisp.

Kris was sitting at the kitchen table, drinking a cup of coffee as Jessi did homework for a math class she was taking at the community college. Jessi was preparing to take her GED.

I leaned down and gave my wife a kiss.

"Don't I get one?" Jessi said with a wink.

I chuckled.

Kris rolled her eyes. "Don't you have homework to do, sis?"

Jessi pouted exaggeratedly, but she wasn't serious. Jessi and I periodically fucked. Yet we didn't cuddle or casually kiss. The same was true with Damon and Kris. We were all open about sex, but exclusive about intimacy and tenderness. At least for now it allowed us to keep some necessary boundaries in place.

I looked over at Kris. "It's going to be a beautiful weekend. Wanna get out of town?"

I saw her hesitate, could see her mentally cataloguing the plans and projects she'd mapped out for the weekend. There would be laundry and grocery shopping and a play date for Suzie and a myriad other things.

She surprised me. "Sure."

She looked over at Jessi. "Do you mind watching the kids?"

Jessi gestured at her math book. "I'm not going anywhere anyway this weekend."

I knew the kids would be delighted. They loved playing with their young Aunt and "Uncle."

"Where do you want to go?" Kris asked.

I shrugged. "I dunno. Let's just drive."

We each packed an overnight bag, just toiletries and a change of clothes. We drove to the highway on-ramp.

"Which way?" I asked instinctively.

"Well..." Kris began. After a pause, she replied, "Flip a coin?"

I laughed and accelerated onto the eastbound on-ramp. We drove for an hour, playing music and just talking and laughing.

"Oooh, Eastport?" she said as we approached the sign.

I hadn't been since I was a kid, and never with Kris. But I had fond memories of corn dogs and the kids-sized amusement park on the pier.

"A little chilly for the beach. And the boardwalk will be deserted," I replied.

"So much the better."

I took the exit and drove into town. A mob scene in the summer, it was sleepy despite the bright early spring sunshine. We pulled into the driveway of a B&B. The startled owner showed us to a room.

The proprietor recommended a small cafe in town that was open year-round. We had French onion soup and split a surprisingly tasty roast beef sandwich. A few other tables were occupied with locals, reading Kindles or doing crosswords.

After, we walked along the deserted boardwalk, our bodies huddled together. It was chilly despite our sweaters and the blanket we'd borrowed from the B&B, which was wrapped around our shoulders.

Kris put her hand to her mouth and giggled.

"What?" I asked.

"Oh God, I just remembered a story about Eastport."

"Yeah?"

"My folks sent Jessi here for a summer. To get her away from bad influences."

I looked around at the boardwalk, imagining it in its garish summer incarnation.

"Uh oh."

She laughed. "Yeah, right. I guess my folks had never seen a beach movie."

"Or heard 'Under the Boardwalk.'"

She raised an eyebrow. "We do have a blanket."

The lyrics played in my head. *Under the boardwalk, down by the sea, yeah; On a blanket with my baby is where I'll be.*

"I've always wanted to bring a girl down there."

Giggling we scampered down the stairs. We removed our shoes and felt the cold sand between our toes. We ducked into the shadows. It was actually warmer down there, out of the wind.

"So what did you imagine you'd do with this imaginary girl?"

"I'm pretty sure any girl willing to follow me under the boardwalk would know what to do."

"Is that so?"

"Well, it is a fantasy."

"Hmmm, a fantasy," she cooed.

She pushed me back against the pilling. She leaned in close and kissed me hard, her hand roughly groping my crotch, rubbing my rapidly hardening prick through my jeans. I ran my hand through her thick hair, taking handful in my fist.

She let out a throaty growl and dropped to her knees. She fished out my prick and swallowed it deep. With my hand still in her hair, I began thrusting in and out of her mouth. Her wet slurping sounds competed with the rumble of the waves.

Suddenly she pushed me away and sat back on her heels. She looked up at me with flashing eyes.

"My turn."

I nodded and she quickly stood. She shimmied out of her jeans and kicked them aside.

I grabbed her hair again and shoved her against the pillar in turn. I dropped to my knees. I attacked her pussy with my mouth, through her panties at first, sucking on her until I could taste her despite the fabric. She was still shaved. I liked it like that. I slid the crotch aside and pressed my tongue inside her. She gasped and ground against me.

I pulled her panties down to mid-thigh. I've always found that to be an unaccountably erotic look. I went back to work, taking her clit into my mouth, feeling it swell and stiffen, until the little nub felt almost rock hard.

She sighed as I backed away, but she didn't protest when I spun her around. She bent at the waist and grabbed the pillar. I entered her from behind, moaning in pleasure at the sensation of her hot, wet cunt. We fucked hard, thrusting against each other with abandon.

I reached under her sweater and pushed up her bra so that her big tits dangled freely beneath her. I palmed her breasts, letting her erect nipples slide between my fingers.

"Oh fuck," she hissed.

I felt her clench on my prick. I thrust in one, two, three more times and with a grunt came inside her.

After a moment I stood her back up and hugged her.

"I love you Kris," I whispered in her ear.

"I love you too, Daniel, and I always will," she replied equally softly.

They say every dark cloud has a silver lining. I don't know if that is true, but at least in our case, things have never been better.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

I have been writing erotica for many years. I began publishing my work online at Literotica.com under the username Misterstan back in 2011. Those stories are a mixed-bag. Some were written more than twenty years ago and are, frankly, immature in both conception and execution. Still some of those stories are pretty entertaining.

Reader feedback is what keeps me going. Please feel free to contact me at ben.boswell.author@gmail.com or visit my blog at benboswell.blogspot.com. You can follow me on Twitter @BenBoswellAut.

My first effort at longer-form fiction was published in January 2014. The description follows:

Two Sides of Terri

Bill has just about the perfect life. Good paying job. Lovely home. Perfect children. And most of all, he has his wife Terri--smart, funny, great with the kids. Thing is, she's a good girl trapped in a bad girl's body. Blonde, busty, and devastatingly beautiful, she makes him want to do dirty things--things you don't admit to wanting from the girl-next-door.

Or so he thought.

It starts with a revelation about Chucky, a past boyfriend, and everything he thought he knew about his sweet wife unravels. He becomes obsessed with learning more about this other side of Terri--and everything he learns points back to Chucky, a man she couldn't say no to. Does he dare invite her past back into their present? And if he did, would she now be able to say no?

Available at Amazon: <http://www.amazon.com/Two-Sides-Terri-Ben-Boswell-ebook/dp/B00HSCMZTW>